you and me, in the summertime

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by invibelle

Summary

Phainon is twenty-nine years old, possessing a degree that does nothing but sit in display, and working odd jobs. Oh, and also close to losing his home thanks to Aedes Elysiae's delightful housing costs.

An opportunity comes in the form of a Jadeslist posting made by concerned parents seeking a 'date' for their son, Mydeimos, who has been suffering the curse of being single for all twenty-one years of his life. The pay? Nymphbook Air and twenty-five thousand Balance Coins.

Phainon might just be the person for the job.

(or: one sweltering summer, two people who are absolutely not in love, and a play in three acts.)

Chapter 1: days blend to one

Chapter Summary

Phainon has done worse jobs for worse pay.

Chapter Notes

I take so many liberties in modernizing Amphoreus and based so much of Aedes Elysiae on my own province (tehepero), so early apologies for that. Filipino readers… #ifyouknowyouknow

I've had the concept of 'being paid to date a rich kid' sitting around since early 2021, and it kept jumping from pair to pair because I'm indecisive. Then I saw No Hard Feelings (2023) last week with my friends and went, 'wait a damn minute.' So here we are! I love romcoms to death! Romcoms set in the summer will always be the best!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon is broke. No, scratch that—he's *beyond* broke at this point. Beyond saving, even.

There is silence within the four walls of his home, save for the faint hum of the fan as its blades spin. There are no eyes on him. Just Phainon and his degree on display by the fireplace. The degree that is almost mocking him; to all persons to whom these presents may come, be it known that the local car-washer and lawn-mower has so well merited as to be proclaimed Master of History.

As the most expensive piece of paper lies secure behind glass, its competition comes in the form of piles of overdue mail sitting at the kitchen table. The electricity's taken care of. The water bill is relatively low and affordable. As for the house itself…

He’s fortunate enough to live in the picturesque town that is Aedes Elysiae. Wheat fields with swaying gold, sprawling green hills that turn a chocolate-like brown in the summer, the air filled with the song of the rushing rivers, the crystal blue waters of the ocean… It’s a provincial paradise. Phainon is proud to call it home.

Very few people came by; they were mostly travelers who were passing through. Aedes Elysiae was, at first, just a pitstop. People who stopped were friendly—Phainon remembers being no older than thirteen, assisting a lost Aidonian, guiding them through the maze of beat-up paths near the fields. Some would stay just long enough to sing and dance with the locals at festivals. Some would stay forever, finding their fated half and their new home.

An omen comes in the form of a popular influencer taking a digital detox and travelling to find his inner peace. When he came back to the world online, he posted about his nomadic experience, talked about how a certain town was so sweet and welcoming and just the perfect getaway to escape the fast-paced city life; a hidden gem, one he dared not gatekeep. Before everyone knew it, Aedes Elysiae made its way to the list of the world’s top must-sees, hashtag cottagecore, hashtag nature, hashtag aesthetic.

Trouble starts with T. T, as in *tourists*. Everything slowly changed. The sleepy town soon became lively as more and more people flooded in, rude and elbowing their way through everything. Tourists come in droves every summer to see Aedes Elysiae’s wonders in person. Cell towers stand on the horizon, a connection once difficult to reach now coming with ease. Homes are torn down to become *summer* houses, because there’s low demand for home walls painted vivid orange with flowerbeds on the lawn as opposed to a monochrome modernist house. Neighbors start moving, and faces come and go. Prices double, sometimes even triple.

Worst of all, property tax only gets higher. It was already bad enough when Phainon was still young, still getting waved off with ‘don’t worry’ and ‘just focus on school.’ Those smiles and pats on the back do not render him deaf; he used to overhear his parents talk late in the night, whispering conversations of *maybe* one of them going to the city to find a new job, just to have something to keep their home. Desperation leaves a mark, and

Phainon is not so naive as to pretend he doesn't see it through their forced smiles and reassurances.

Now, there are no smiles, no one to tell him not to worry. Just him at his kitchen table, with paper demands to keep him company.

"You're kidding," he mutters to himself, staring at the numbers in bold. He rubs his eyes just to check if he's imagining one of the zeroes. Nope. Still the same number. A whopping *twenty thousand* Balance Coins overdue. Twenty thousand! Kephale wept.

He tries, in vain, to think of a way to save himself. He's working at a bar every Friday and Saturday night. Bleak schedule, he knows, but it's better than nothing. Washing cars is a possibility, but an automated car wash just opened recently. He also cleans yards, which is perfect for the summer—the tourists love their green lawns and uniform lines more than anything. It's just a matter of beating others to the gig. Maybe he'll put up a post about that later.

He doesn't need to do mental math to know it's not enough. It's not half, not even *a quarter* of what he owes.

His grip on the paper tightens as his stomach twists into a knot. He doesn't feel any better when the bill crumples under his hold; it's not like its destruction means the erasure of whatever debt he's found himself falling into.

It's hard to accept that, just as he once outgrew his favorite yellow sweater, his town is outgrowing him.

He knows this is expected. He lives in a tourist magnet. A 'must-visit.' Naturally, people will gravitate towards his home, buy summer houses that will put the neighborhood value through the roof, and then drive the locals out when everything gets too pricey. Tale as old as time.

But, this is just beyond ridiculous, isn't it? Where is he going to get twenty thousand in three weeks? It's definitely not through cleaning yards or repairing some broken fans or serving some drinks or walking dogs. Not in

three weeks. In three years, maybe. But before then, what? He'll live in cardboard boxes? Let someone have his home—his *family's* home?

He lowers the crumpled letter, lets it rest on top of the unopened envelopes of bills. *Twenty thousand,* he repeats in his head, as if it's not real enough for him. Twenty thousand that he needs to pay in three weeks, or else. He doesn't want to think of the *else*. Not when he can still see the scratches on the floor from when he'd carelessly drag his chair when he was younger, not when he can still see the lines marking his height on the kitchen doorway, not when he's still left his parents' room as it is.

He's spent years running along dirt paths, laughing until his sides hurt. He's danced in every festival, claimed his title as the longest reigning champion in climbing greased bamboo poles. He's familiarized himself with the shapes of the hills, the hues that the leaves take in every season. Aedes Elysiae is his home, and it *always* will be. But if it wants him out so badly, then—

He closes his eyes.

He'll be fine.

He has no choice but to be fine.

"You look terrible," Cyrene says in lieu of a greeting, voice sweet and melodic. She sits in the old swings they used to waste hours on, swaying lightly as she sips at her morning tea.

Phainon's other half, his closest friend, and the sister he never had comes in the form of a head of light pink hair and an even brighter voice. Despite her being older by two years, she stands a foot shorter than him. She never grew, not really—she's given Phainon some grief for him daring to have a growth spurt when he was fourteen, and she's also given him the most immature of smiles and jokes. Poking fun at him comes naturally to her, just like how biting her bait comes naturally to him.

“Thanks. I had a terrible morning,” he replies. He doesn’t want to talk about what’s wrong. Not yet. Not when she’s all chipper. So he says, “Messed up my coffee.”

“Oh? Whose fault is that?” she hums, wiggling her brows. “Did you have someone over again, huh? Have them serve you world’s worst breakfast in bed?”

He makes a face, half exasperated and half amused. He loves her dearly—it’s Cyrene, it’s hard *not* to love her—but she’s impossible. He’s long accepted the fact that he wouldn’t have it any other way, but that doesn’t mean he doesn’t feel an incoming migraine at the prospect of her endless teasing. “No,” he says. “I just tried something new. I learned I didn’t like it.”

“Really?” she presses, persistent. “What did you try?”

He pauses for a split second, just enough to spit out a blend off the top of his head. “Cranberry coffee.”

“Aw, so it’s really just coffee news today? No sexcapades gone wrong?”

“Cyrene, please…”

She laughs. It’s something familiar in the ever-changing Aedes Elysiae. Phainon is assured that, no matter what happens, he’ll at least still have that. His mother once joked that she and he were a package deal. He’s happy to think of them that way; as long as there’s Phainon, there will be Cyrene, and vice versa.

“Come on! Don’t clam up on me,” she gives him a little tilt of her head and a knowing look. Translation: *jig’s up*. He should’ve known there’s no hiding anything from her. She doesn’t make discovery twist into *dread*. Instead, it feels more like acceptance, a warm embrace to sink into. “Your nose always does a little scrunch, and you’re all tense when you’re trying to hide something. Plus, that dark look on your face… My sensors tell me that that can’t be anything but bad news.”

Oh. He tries to relax. His shoulders sag and he fixes his expression, undoing that alleged scrunch. He marks this as a record-breaker as the shortest time he's ever spent hiding something from Cyrene. *Less than a minute.* It's either he's bad at acting or she's a mindreader, but he's leaning towards the latter.

"The house," he begins, and it feels almost too heavy to say aloud. It feels like a curse on his tongue—like just saying it would just establish the fact and indicate his surrender. "It's… I may or may not be sinking into debt as we speak."

Her eyes practically pop out of their sockets. Her mug falls from her hand, and her tea is reduced to a mere splatter on the wooden platform. It's exactly how he predicted.

"*Debt?*" she clutches at her chest, standing up from the swing. "What do you mean, debt? What did you do?"

"I didn't do anything insidious like betting my house, if that's what you're thinking," he weakly laughs. "It's… twenty thousand Balance Coins due on taxes. On the property. They're upping it, as you know. You must've seen your own bills… and managed it much better than I have."

Cyrene's face shows her concern, brows furrowing and teeth worrying at her bottom lip. He hates to see that expression, most of all because it's *he* who brought it to her face. He's never been fond of sharing his burdens; he knows she would carry its weight along with him. Shared misery is misery halved… or so they say.

"You… haven't been paying?"

A pained laugh. "No."

"Oh, Phainon," she sighs the same way an owner would sigh at a dog chewing their shoes.

"Not intentionally," he jumps to his own defense. He swiftly continues, "I mean—*yes*, intentionally. But not because I don't feel like paying. I just…

can’t afford to pay.”

The admission is humiliating. Cyrene knows Phainon as well as he knows her, but matters such as money problems frequently go unsaid. Saying it aloud is a type of shame he wouldn’t wish upon anyone; the shame of admitting that he’s not making enough money despite… *everything*.

(He was a hopeful eighteen-year-old once upon a time and dreamt of becoming a museum curator because he’s yet to realize that there are very few openings in the entirety of Amphoreus that pay a humane wage for that position. Reality slaps him in the face hard when he gets turned down at everything else he’s applied to for being apparently overqualified. He’s hit even harder when he catches word of his mother falling ill, a fact hidden from him so as not to worry him. That’s something that runs in his family’s blood—the need to shoulder everything alone.

If he were to waste his time in the capital getting rejected by everyone, he might as well just go home and tend to his mother. And so, that’s exactly what he did. He packed his bags, left Okhema, and returned to Aedes Elysiae with only two sheets of paper to show for all he’s done while away from home. Though his mother held his hand and told him she was proud, he didn’t feel pride over anything he’d done. Not when all he could do was watch as his mother grew worse, and his father followed in heartbreak.

His parents worked hard to keep him happy. He repaid them by doing fuck all in Okhema and returning with no money and watch them go.

Years passed, and nothing’s changed.)

“What do you plan to do?” Cyrene asks, stepping close to Phainon. She places a hand on his shoulder, comforting and grounding at once.

He smiles, because that’s what he does best, and it’s the most he can offer. “What I usually do. I’ll work my magic.”

It’s half past noon when he makes a posting about offering his landscaping services. The sun is high up in the sky and burning through the window

pane, heating up Phainon's back. The spinning fans of the computer are not helping the weather, either.

The computer runs slow. His phone is working perfectly, but it's not the best way to go to Jadeslist. He's tried it before; the mobile display optimization is nonexistent. Besides, the computer is *fine*. Slow, but not so much that it's borderline unusable. It's just enough to make him feel like he's watching a snail race rather than one of humanity's greatest inventions. The attached images aren't helping, he figures. But he needed it to sell his services convincingly, to show that he's cleaned up gardens devastated by storms before. Trimming some grass and hedges is peanuts to him.

He chews on his lunch of chicken and brown rice, left hand holding his spoon and the right holding the mouse. He shifts to lift one leg and rest it on the chair. It does little to ease his discomfort. Sweat is forming on his forehead, and his back is not getting any cooler.

He turns his gaze to the fan. It shakes where it stands from the speed at which the blades are spinning. Though it seems a few seconds away from exploding, he knows better—it's one dramatic fan, rattling every few seconds for nothing. It's also hardly helping him feel cool; it simply propels the warm air in his direction. Still, Phainon would rather not bathe in his sweat and decides that a warm breeze is better than feeling no breeze at all.

"Come on…"

Uploaded. *Success*. His post is up. Now, all he has to do is wait.

And then, he gets a harsh reminder. *Right*. No, he can't. He literally *cannot* afford to waste time sitting on his ass, waiting for someone to come and give him money. He has to move.

Services in Aedes Elysiae. *Click*. The loading wheel spins and freezes mid-animation, because it just does that sometimes. *Huh*. It's surprisingly quiet. The posts are calls made by people like him, looking to be hired, but the dates between posts are rather far apart. The latest listing was posted five days ago, and the previous one a week ago.

He scrolls down. And then he stops. He cannot help the way he perks up at the first few words of the title alone. Who knew the words *‘we are looking for’* could bring so much hope?

Without thinking much of it, he clicks. He shoves a spoonful of rice as the page takes its sweet time to load, each element acting as though it’s a fifty gigabyte game. It’s as if it can smell Phainon’s excitement and wants to keep him waiting for as long as possible. Unstoppable force (Phainon’s need for a job) meets an immovable object (a computer half Phainon’s age). It’s a game of who gives in first.

The page *finally* loads. He swallows his food and leans forward, eager to read.

“We are looking for anyone aged early to late twenties to *date* our twenty-one-year-old son,” he reads aloud, brows furrowing. “Temporary arrangement, lasting only throughout the summer. Compensation will come in the form of—”

He coughs when his eyes land on the following few words.

“—in the form of a secondhand Nymphbook Air and twenty-five thousand Balance Coins, serious inquiries only?!”

His eyes narrow at the screen. Seriously, the listing is too weird. It was posted two weeks ago and updated a day ago. It means no one has answered, and they’re probably sweetening up the deal to attract anyone stupid enough to fall for such a blatant scam.

Hah! Well, Phainon isn’t a fresh graduate who’s desperate for a job. He’s a twenty-nine-year-old in debt who’s desperate for a job. Get it right. There’s a difference. He knows what’s legit and what’s not. It’s all up to him not to get his hopes up.

He presses the back button. The loading screen stays on display for a full minute for his viewing pleasure. An impatient groan leaves his lips, but he refuses to be frustrated by something as simple as this. *Don’t be frustrated by things you cannot control*, his mother’s voice reminds him in the back of

his head. And she’s right. He also has bigger priorities than getting a better computer.

The listings come to view once more. He scrolls further. *Are you looking for an Amphorean tutor?* Nope. *Willing to be a part-time housekeeper.* Ah. *Will take any job at all.* Oh… They’re all just people looking to get paid, each post only getting more desperate the deeper he goes.

He scrolls up, returns to the outlier. *Click*. The loading page gives him time to contemplate his decisions. When it loads, he gives the listing a stare, as if it could grow legs and walk right out of his sight. And who knows? Maybe it could. The possibility of this only opportunity slipping by is not a thought lost on him.

He lifts his other leg, rests both feet at his seat, resting his chin on his knees. If something is too good to be true, that’s because it *is*. Twenty-five thousand Balance Coins and a Nymphbook? It’s ridiculous. The pay might as well be a free cruise ship complete with a staff.

And what if the son in question is a murderer? Someone who’s off their rocker? Someone who’s so creepy he needs his parents to beg people online to date them? And what do they mean by *date* in quotation marks? What does ‘date’ imply? Is he supposed to wine and dine the son in question? Oh, Kephale, maybe *have sex* with the son? What if there were no parents involved, and it’s just one sick individual pretending to be a hopeless and loveless man to lure people for nefarious reasons?

He drags his mouse over the compensation, highlighting the words in blue. Twenty-five thousand. Secondhand Nymphbook Air.

A glance at the bills waiting on the dining table. They sit with a half-empty fruit basket, a sweating pitcher of water, and the silver pot for the rice cooker. It ruins his appetite.

If he dies… at least, the debt will die with him.

He clicks to reveal the contact number.

Phainon gives up on riding his bicycle uphill, opting to just drag it along as he walks through the more extravagant side of Aedes Elysiae, summer houses galore. He's gone to this side of the province before, but only to clean pools—because the beautiful river and the white-sand beach are not enough—and not for a job interview.

At least, job interview is what *he* calls it. When he made a call, they said it was just a conversation to talk about the details and know more about him. They provided an address, and Phainon did his due diligence by checking it on Loogle Maps first. His phone displayed a luxurious mansion, and he had to hold in a humorless snort. *Of course*. Only people who lived in such an ostentatious home would get the idea of hiring a date for their son.

(The last time Phainon went on a job interview was years ago, back in Okhema. People in Aedes Elysiae know him as Audata and Hieronymus' son and north star, reliable, sweet, and kind. It's gotten him jobs with every business that opens and closes; people's trust in him allows him to skip the formalities and just get straight to the point.)

He's slightly winded when he stops in front of a set of silver gates. The house number plate reads 13. An intercom waits half a foot away from the gate.

"Hello, it's Phainon," he greets after pressing the call button. "From the Jadeslist post."

A woman's voice greets him back, "Come right in."

The gate unlocks for him. *Wow*. Rich people… *No,* he shoves all his thoughts to the back of his head. Bitterness does not look good on him, and he wants to give the best first impression for his potential employers. That's the rule. A smile fits him far better.

He walks past a garage housing two shiny, red cars. One is flashier than the other, though; a convertible, open two-seater. The other is more practical—a six-seater MPV, perfect for road trips. Phainon thinks both are beautiful, but that may just be him longing for something he can't have.

A window cleaner glances at him as they wipe the glass. He offers a polite wave. They don't wave back; their hands are occupied. Not a local, he notes. He knows everyone in Aedes Elysiae—the ones who have always been there. Their numbers are dwindling by the day, and he doesn't blame the ones who leave.

"Phainon," the same voice from the intercom calls from the balcony above. He tilts his head up to look, gaze landing on a woman with long, blond hair. The woman gestures to the set of stairs below. "Come in, please."

He lets his bike rest on the stone wall on the side of the stairs. He ascends the steps, palms suddenly going clammy. Interviews have become linked to rejection in his mind—every step feels like one getting closer to the inevitable apology preluding a hard *no*.

Welcoming him on top of the stairs is a fancy fire pit. To the left, glass sliding doors. The entire house is practically made of glass, really—it's like living inside a clear cube. Does it look good? Debatable. Is it almost an obscene display of wealth? Absolutely. Everything inside is on display.

A man emerges from the left, and Phainon instantly feels on guard. His hair is long, tied back with a bun. He looks well into his fifties, just a few inches taller than Phainon, made of pure muscle. He could probably punt Phainon off the balcony, and Phainon would leave nothing but a little glint in the sky before disappearing.

"Phainon?" the man asks.

"Yes, that's me."

He gestures with a tilt of his head to follow before he turns around and walks back into the home. Phainon trails behind him, careful to keep his footsteps light. They walk past the living area where a helper is vacuuming the floor, and past the kitchen where *another* helper is cutting watermelons. Another set of stairs is trudged through, and only when white double doors come to view do they stop.

The man opens the doors and wordlessly gestures for Phainon to come in. Phainon prays that his smile has not melted into a grimace in the wake of the ostentatiousness he had to pass through.

Inside, the woman from earlier is sitting on one of the couches, legs crossed and comfortably leaning against soft cushions. This close, Phainon is almost taken aback by how gorgeous she is. Her blond hair fades to a red hue at the tips—a detail easy to miss at a distance. Her arm, slung on the backrest, features bulk of muscle. Her eyes are gold, almost matching the signet ring on her finger. Smile lines leave their mark around her lips.

“Please, get comfortable,” she says, voice rough yet welcoming all the same. She motions to the seat opposite hers.

The door closes with a click, and the man takes his position next to who Phainon assumes is his wife. When he takes a seat, Phainon follows—he’s been taught not to sit before the host does.

“I’m Gorgo. And this—” she places a hand on the man’s thigh. “—is my husband, Eurypon.”

Phainon nods, “Thanks for having me.”

“Right,” Gorgo replies. “So, where are you from, Phainon?”

Straight to the point, no small talk about his favorite biscuit dip or his typical weekend. He appreciates that. “I’m from here.”

“A local,” Eurypon notes with a nod. “Must be wonderful, living in such a beautiful town.”

Yes, but also *no*. He makes no move to voice out his true thoughts—that’s not what he’s here for. He instead replies, agreeable as ever, “Absolutely. Can’t imagine leaving by the time summer ends.”

“Aedes Elysiae has always been on our list of places to visit,” Gorgo says. “But Eurypon and I… well, we feel bad leaving without our son, since he’s

always so busy with studies. So, we waited until he finished his studies. Have this vacation as his graduation gift."

A *vacation* as a *graduation gift*. Must be wonderful. Not that Phainon would know; he can only imagine. He slowly nods in response.

Eurypon adds, "He's a kind boy. Too kind, if you asked me. It'd do him some good to—"

Gorgo clicks her tongue. She gives her husband a look, and it instantly quiets him down. With his silence, she turns her attention back to Phainon and continues, "The ID you sent us… You're twenty-nine, no? You're not married, are you?"

Phainon nearly chokes on his own spit. "No, I'm not. Ha-ha."

"Had to be sure," Gorgo says. "But I'm curious. Do you have any experience as an… escort?"

He runs his tongue across his teeth, the pause lingering in the air for a second too long. His first mistake, he realizes. He quickly amends the mistake with honesty. "No. *But* I have enough dating experience to know what to say and what to do." Another pause. He adds, for good measure, "Two girlfriends and four boyfriends."

(Oh, and a handful of one-night stands, but that's overkill, isn't it?)

The couple exchanges a glance. A sigh escapes Gorgo's lips. Phainon braces himself for the inevitable, the *no* about to hit him like a punch to the gut.

"Our son… Mydeimos," she says. "He's a sweet boy. Not much of a talker, but a good listener. He's withdrawn, though. He prefers to spend most of his days indoors. And when he's out, he's alone. He came out to us back when he was fifteen, and we expected a boyfriend to come along with it, but there was nothing. Just… an announcement. He hasn't had a single girlfriend or boyfriend his entire life. And we're so worried."

Oh? The pit in Phainon's stomach closes up in a snap. He can't help it—he leans forward, resting his elbows on his thighs. He hums, indicating his interest in whatever it is that Gorgo may say.

Eurypon is the one who continues, "It's not good for him to be alone. People need nourishment in all aspects—physical, social, spiritual. Mydeimos… is severely lacking in the social aspect. We're not getting any younger, and we want to see our son explore his options and find his other half while we're still here. We don't want to be jars in the background of his wedding photos."

Awfully morbid, Phainon thinks. He slowly nods in response, not quite sure what to say.

Gorgo adds, "Mydeimos is just… avoiding the dating scene for reasons beyond us. We've asked what puts him off, and he says there's just a lack of sincere people in the pool. But how would he know, if he doesn't try?"

Your son is concerned with the lack of sincerity, so you'll pay me to pretend to love him to ease his anxiety? Phainon is in awe. Still, he sets that thought aside. "Mm, I see," he says. "So, when you say you need someone to *date* your son, what do you mean by… date, with those quotation marks on the post?"

"Give him some love," Eurypon answers. "Show him the delights of having someone by his side. Be a… what do they call it? A summer fling, right?"

"Right." That clarifies very little. He asks further, "So, I'll bring him on a few dates, get him curious about the world of dating, and nudge him towards it?"

"Yes, exactly. Get him out of his shell," Eurypon affirms. "Mydeimos' friends… well, the *very few* friends he has, they're not people who promote relationships. They want to act like eternal bachelors, probably jumping from woman to woman with no intention to commit."

"Love, they're… they're gay," Gorgo says in a hushed voice, but loud enough for Phainon to hear. "His friends, they're a 'polycule.'"

“A what?”

“I think that means they’re dating each other.”

“That’s worse,” Eurypon grunts. “They can’t even invite Mydeimos in? Is he *that* unappealing to them?”

…*Okay*. A parent’s concern can be too much, sometimes bordering on insulting, when they keep seeing you as their baby sent off to daycare instead of a whole separate person. But is Phainon really about to lecture a couple about how they’re supposed to treat their twenty-one-year-old son when he’s hoping for some cents from their pockets? Fuck, no.

“Well! If he looks anything like either of you, he’s sure to be a looker!” Phainon laughs lightheartedly to remind them of his presence. He also prays to all the gods that their son is not adopted. “And Aedes Elysiae has an abundance of people for him to meet. Who knows, he might meet the one right here.”

“That’s what we hope,” Gorgo says. “But really, we don’t care where or who. We just want him to find his match.”

He presses his lips together. “That bad, huh? Bad enough that… there’s all this… for twenty-five thousand Balance Coins and a laptop?”

“Yes. That, and no one’s responded to our listing,” Gorgo replies, and Phainon is tempted to tell her that it’s because it reads like a scam. “It’s been up since we got here two weeks ago.”

“I’m up to the task,” he replies, a little too eager for his own ears. “I promise, your son will be taken care of. We’ll have the most peaceful and amicable breakup to send him right back to your home and get him craving more of the sweetness of dating.”

Gorgo looks at him, just eyes him in a rather scrutinizing fashion that makes Phainon’s skin crawl—before she says, “You’re a very cheery person, Phainon. You’re the sun our son needs. We’ll put him in your care.”

His brows practically fly to his hairline. He rushes to fix his expression because his astonishment at the acceptance is not one he wants to show so readily. “Oh, great! So… when do I start? Do I just… go up to his room now, tell him he has another gift?”

“No, he’s out right now. He’s at the beach, probably brooding,” Gorgo huffs and shakes her head in fond exasperation—a mother’s love shines through despite the trouble their child brings… even if said trouble is just the sin of being an introvert. “You can come in here tomorrow, pretend to fix—”

“Honey, he won’t believe that,” Eurypon interrupts. “I built him a treehouse from scratch. Anything we have broken doesn’t need anyone’s hands other than mine.”

Gorgo rolls her eyes and lets out a weary, heavy sigh. “Fine. Phainon, you can come by the beach tomorrow at two in the afternoon. We’ll be at the grilling area. You can… use your imagination on how to approach Mydeimos.”

“Of course,” Phainon nods. “I’ll see you there.”

Eurypon chimes in swiftly, “But can’t tell him about this. This remains between the three of us, you hear?”

It sounds suspiciously close to a threat. Phainon knows when not to negotiate when trying to secure a job. “Yes, of course. I promise, my lips are zipped. He won’t know. No one would know. Ever.”

“To a wonderful summer!” Phainon raises a glass with no response whatsoever.

Livia and Piso remain as quiet as a mouse and as judgmental as he expected them to be. They’re nursing glasses of orange juice, much to their own chagrin, but Phainon will absolutely never hear the end of it if their parents find out they’re drinking under his supervision.

The silence is fine—Phainon tips the shot glass and downs it in one go, feeling it burn its way down his throat. He squeezes a lemon slice right after. He hisses, “Whew…”

Piso, once a little boy eager to get Phainon’s attention, is the one to give Phainon the dirtiest of looks. The years have turned him sharper, his mouth faster—fewer dreams about being a hero spouted and more derision dispensed. His snark softens only for one certain girl, who just so happens to be sitting beside him. He breaks the almost-solemn silence on their table, sarcastic when he asks, “Are you… okay? No, seriously, we’re concerned.”

“Fine and dandy,” he replies, voice coming out all sorts of wrong in the aftermath of his hasty drinking. “I’m celebrating, as you can see.”

“Ignore him,” Livia says without missing a beat, because of course she does. She’s soft to everyone but the so-called outsiders and Piso. Her hands are accustomed to both painting pretty pictures and slamming down on Piso’s back in reproach. She’s got a good eye for design, but Phainon frequently catches her staring at Piso’s back despite the boy’s usual plain clothing. “He’s just being mean to be mean.”

“Coming from *you*, of all people?” Piso rags. “This might be the pot meeting the kettle.”

“You’re an idiot. And you’re just not observant enough.” Livia then turns to Phainon. Her voice is softer when she asks, “You usually don’t drink unless something really bad happened. Are you okay?”

They’ve already grown up, Phainon knows. But now, he sympathizes with the helicopter parents who have to hire someone just to get their son out there. Livia and Piso will always be kids in his eyes, he thinks, remembering the days of them tugging on his arms and asking him to come humor them for a game as though it only happened yesterday. They don’t need to know that he’s so desperate to make money that he’s getting himself involved with the outsiders they’re so wary of, don’t need to know that he’s a few weeks away from possibly losing his home if he messes it up.

“Fine and dandy,” he repeats pointedly, just to tease. “I’m celebrating.”

The effects of the night before have already long worn off by the time the afternoon rolls around. He's feeling as fresh as a dewdrop on a leaf on a spring morning. He's in prime condition for some… well, seduction. Unbuttoned summer linen shirt? Check. Freshly shaved? Check. Hair raked back carelessly? Check. He's the quintessential Aedes Elysiae surfer without the surfboard.

His target having no prior experience in dating is a challenge. If he just knew a little bit more about this Mydeimos person, Phainon could wear that type as a mask. A bad boy? He'll put on such a convincing act that he'd be worthy of being a male lead in a Penaconian TV show. The boy next door? Sure, why not; he can be sweet and down to earth. Nerds? Cool, he can play the part. (He can hear Cyrene's voice in the back of his head, singsong as she says he is a nerd already.)

With the way the man's parents talk, he doesn't know what to expect in terms of appearance. Mydeimos is apparently kind. A sweet boy. Not a talker. Phainon's mind conjures an image based on that. How funny would it be if he looked exactly like his father except… like, deflated? Scrawny, no muscle whatsoever. If he's withdrawn, he's probably pale. But then again, Gorgo did say Mydeimos was at the beach yesterday. Maybe he was out to get a tan.

He descends on the beach. There are plenty of people sprawled on the sand, splashing around near the shores. The sun burns high up in the sky, merciless and unyielding as it always has been during this season. Summers in Aedes Elysiae have always been brutal as far as Phainon could remember.

His hand comes above his eyes, a shield against the rays, giving him a better view of the grills from afar. *Damn*. He's in need of glasses, isn't he? All he sees are lumps of color from a distance.

The scorching hot sand making a home on his slippers is ignored, long used to the feeling. He continues to approach the grills. The roof over it provides reprieve from the harsh heat, and Phainon is ready to make a casual remark about the summer and the sun and start the usual small talk he tries to strike

up—but a man is working on the grill right there, and Phainon thinks, no, it's *still hot*.

Grilling some weiners is the hottest man Phainon has ever seen. And Phainon has seen his fair share of attractive people; he does not give that title willy-nilly.

It's not a local. Of course, it's not. If this man were a local, Phainon would've noticed him long ago. The man's conspicuous: tall, tanned skin decorated with red lines of ink, and… shirtless. Okay, duh, it's the beach, but *holy shit*. His body is on display, pecs and abs and all. Phainon is in possession of basic human decency, so he doesn't say anything indecent out loud—but he's also in possession of functioning human eyes and good taste, so he leers as quietly as humanly possible.

His eyes flick down. "Wow. Nice weiner."

The man turns his head to Phainon's direction, golden eyes narrowed. There's a little twitch to his features, one with a meaning that Phainon can't decipher. "What?"

Phainon gestures to the grill, where the frankfurters are being charred. "*That*. Looks delicious."

"…Right," the hot man slowly says as he moves the food a little bit to the right, closer to him, as if Phainon's about to snatch them up with his bare hands and run.

A beat of silence. Then, Phainon tries again, "You're here for the summer?"

There's a momentary pause, likely the hot man contemplating if it's worth humoring Phainon or if he should just pack up the wieners, close the grill, and walk off. He doesn't seem like a person who enjoys small talk. Tough luck! To survive in the world, a bit of small talk must be endured.

The hot man casts a wary glance at Phainon. Well—a glance, then a second, longer look. Phainon sees him get a good gander, eyeing him from head to toe. Phainon welcomes the not-so-discreet ogling with great relish.

When Phainon smiles and playfully raises his brows, the hot man seems to catch himself. He clears his throat and then replies, “Yes. Vacationing with family.”

“Oh, family? You got a wife and kids?”

“No,” comes a hasty answer. “*No*. I’m here with my mother and father.”

“Hey, ease up, I’m joking,” Phainon laughs. “How are you liking Aedes Elysiae? Even better than in the photos, right?”

“Yeah. It looks good. Really beautiful.”

That, at least, sounds a little less forced. Phainon can’t help the smile on his face. Despite his predicament, he feels some sort of warmth and pride at the fact that *this* is his home. This paradise that they can only escape to for the summer? *This* is his *life*.

Only once the silence between them lingers does Phainon realize he’s wasting time yet again. He’s supposed to be here to seduce the single-since-birth son of his employers, not hit on a random tourist. But the thing is, he doesn’t see the family he’s supposed to be meeting. Did they go the grills further to the left, near the bar? Maybe they did.

Just as Phainon’s about to turn around and wave the hot guy goodbye and all the usual pleasantries, Eurypon and Gorgo arrive. Just the two of them. And when Phainon opens his mouth to ask where their son is, if he’s brooding in his room this time—

“Mydeimos,” Gorgo says, her eyes flicking to the shirtless man and then to Phainon. “You made a friend?”

The hot man replies, “No.”

Phainon’s head snaps towards the hot man—no, *Mydeimos*, at high speed. *This?* This was Mydeimos? No, wait, it makes sense. He has his mother’s hair, eyes, lips, nose… well, everything. Was Eurypon involved, or was he simply a *suggestion* in the creation of Mydeimos? In any case, Mydeimos is

gorgeous. He looks like an angel descended from heaven with that pretty face. And the body? Oh, *the body*.

But… this is the man who hasn't gotten a single date in his entire life? There is no way. The world's order must have gone awry, the planet must've gone off-kilter. Is Mydeimos an apparition who only appears to men sinking into debt? There's no way that his man, this *Adonis*, has been single his entire life. Phainon simply doesn't believe it. Maybe he *is* a part of his friend group's polycule and just refuses to disclose it to his parents for some unknown reason.

Eurypon looks at Phainon expectantly. Phainon doesn't want to fail before their eyes, so he says, "Yes! We're friends now. Mydeimos, huh? Nice name."

Mydeimos' brows furrow at the sound of his name coming from Phainon's mouth. He says, "Uh-huh. I don't know who you are."

"Phainon," he supplies, easy as ever. "Now, you know. I will also have you know that I can show you around because I know this place like the back of my hand."

"Whatever you two have going on, you can leave us out of it," Gorgo says. On cue, Eurypon makes his way to Mydeimos' side, taking over on the grill and practically shooing off his son.

Mydeimos doesn't budge from where he stands. "I don't—"

"Go, Mydeimos. Take it easy, make some friends," Eurypon says, nudging his son. It sounds final.

Oh. Now, Phainon just feels awkward. Like he's wandered into someone else's home and overheard a father scolding their five-year-old for tugging on a classmate's pigtails. Only that, the one being scolded is a whole adult man with muscles matching his father's.

Hot-man-now-known-as-Mydeimos shows the strength of his will; he huffs, shakes his head, and steps away from the grill. A dry look is sent Phainon's

way, but Phainon's smile remains unwavering. His charm won't fail him. It *can't*.

"Let's go."

Phainon learns three things about Mydeimos quickly.

One: Mydeimos is fond of sweets. When stopping by the bar, his order comes in the form of a strawberry milkshake topped off with whipped cream. Phainon's prepared tease gets lodged in his throat when Mydeimos glares at him sharply as if to challenge him as his lips wrap around the straw. The amusement then turns to mild surprise as Phainon watches Mydeimos finish the beverage in what seems to be the blink of an eye. And get this—he even gives Phainon a look of judgment for not downing his watermelon shake just as fast.

Two: Mydeimos is drier than the desert. Every conversation Phainon tries to start swiftly turns into a monologue. For every fun fact Phainon dispenses, all he offers is a polite or acknowledging *oh* or *ah* or *hm*. It quickly gives Phainon an explanation for his status—who wants to date a man who can't even hold a proper conversation? Minus ten points!

Three: Mydeimos can throw a really good punch.

Phainon stumbles back and into the river when Mydeimos' fist meets his cheek. He sputters out the water that flowed into his mouth. He says the only thing going through his mind. "What the fuck!? What did I do?"

Mydeimos looks down at him, face steely. "You think I haven't caught onto your cheap tricks?"

Shit. Does he somehow know that Phainon was hired by his parents? Did he let something slip by accident? But Phainon's not careless, never has been. Trust doesn't come by easily, and once lost, it's forever gone. He's delicate when he handles everything entrusted to him.

“Spare me from your schemes, *Phainon*,” Mydeimos continues. “If that’s even your name. I’ve heard of human trafficking rings happening in the countryside, but I didn’t think you’d be so bold as to target someone who can fight back.”

A beat. Phainon’s jaw drops. His cheek pays the price, still feeling the burn of the punch. The flow of the river water fills his ears. Mydeimos’ glare doesn’t soften all the while.

And then—

He laughs. Incredulous, at first. Then, genuine. Amused. He spins the idea in his head. Mydeimos the beefcake is on guard because he thinks… he’s about to be a face on a missing poster? A cautionary tale about vacations on Aedes Elysiae?

Mydeimos steps away, looking at Phainon as if he’s gone bananas and ready to start biting. He hisses, “What?”

“You think–” Phainon breathes in, trying to recover from the pain on both his sides and his cheek. “–you think I’m trying to *traffick* you? Seriously? Do I look like I could just pick you up and run?”

“You do,” Mydeimos responds, dragging his gaze across Phainon’s figure. “If I was caught unaware.”

Phainon elects to ignore the scrutinizing gaze in favor of defending his integrity. “But I don’t plan to! What even gave you that idea?”

“You came to the grill in the most suspicious way possible. You act weird when there are others around, almost as if you’re trying to act unassuming. Then, you volunteer to ‘show me around,’ as if a tour guide would offer their services free of charge.”

Phainon props himself up by his elbows, getting up from the shallow water he had unceremoniously fallen into. “Unfamiliar with someone being friendly to you, buddy?”

“Don’t call me that,” Mydeimos says, and Phainon raises his hands in surrender. “You’re trying to get me alone.”

Phainon looks left, looks right. He says, chary, “Sorry, I’m not a professional tour guide, just a local. Did you expect me to bring along a whole wagon of tourists?”

“You brought me to a bar. Hoped to get me drunk, didn’t you?”

“I didn’t! Day drinking is not my style, *and* I got you the strawberry milkshake that you were eyeing on the menu.”

“Right.”

“*Dude*,” Phainon breathes out. “You have tattoos all over. You’re *not* getting trafficked.”

Mydeimos crosses his arms. He shifts his weight to one foot, still looking down at Phainon quietly. He has no more retorts up his… nonexistent sleeves because he’s still shirtless, and Phainon takes it as an invitation to explain.

“I’m going to be honest,” he says, standing up from the river. The afternoon heat works to keep him warm despite the drenched clothes. “I approached you because I thought you were hot.”

If Mydeimos did not look skeptical enough a moment ago, he definitely did now. At least, he doesn’t take a step back when Phainon approaches—makes sense, given that he had just proved that he’s more than capable of defending himself.

He decides to be a little more direct. “Let’s start all over again. Hi, I’m Phainon. Let’s go on a date, please?”

The way Mydeimos’ expression curls into a mix of disbelief would almost be humorous if not for the fact that his fists are clenched. “You’re out of your mind. You don’t know who I am.”

“I don’t know you *yet*. I want to. The point of a date is to know more about the person you’re going out with. I’ll consider it as an apology for you punching me for no reason.”

“*No reason?* I had my reasons. I just told you.”

“Reasons,” Phainon says, “that I’ve countered. I’m not a criminal. What *is* criminal is the way you’re walking around looking that gorgeous.”

Mydeimos cringes. Phainon internally does, too.

“You seem so assured that I’m interested in people like you,” Mydeimos says, and Phainon knows what he means by *people like you*. It doesn’t carry the same distaste that the older people in town have. “that I wonder where you get that arrogance from.”

“I mean, I saw you checking me out a while ago.”

Silence, once again.

Phainon drawls, “*So,* tomorrow night? There’s this restaurant bar…”

Cyrene doesn’t know the full truth of the situation, but Phainon has dropped enough hints for her to find out. He can say in earnest that he did not tell her—he didn’t, not directly—and keep his promises to both people at once. *No secrets* for Cyrene, and *no telling anyone* for Eurypon. They’ll have to chalk it up to his best friend having the uncanny ability to see through Phainon. The fact that he makes himself as transparent as glass when it comes to her is not his fault and is entirely unrelated.

(She *did* have a few choice words to say about his latest racket and lightly swollen cheek, but whether because of the desperation she can smell on him or something else altogether, she didn’t let the lecture drag on for a minute longer than necessary.)

She does exactly what he expects her to do. She lies in bed, legs up and against the wall, as she scrolls through her phone. He sits beside her and

occupies himself with toying with the eight-year-old stuffed cat he won for her at the fiesta while she does the Cyrene-typical stalking (*investigation*, as she prefers to call it) of whoever Phainon is involved with.

“He’s really quiet online,” she muses. “His profile might as well have a dust bunnies collecting on it. *But!* He has a friend who posts a lot.”

“Yeah? What are they up to? I need to plan around his interests to keep him hooked.”

A disapproving look is sent his way, but she answers his question nonetheless, “The pictures don’t say a lot about their interests. They’re just sitting down at a table on every single image.”

He snorts, “Sitting down at a table. Are you sure those aren’t business partners?”

“There *is* alcohol present, and it’s not celebratory wine,” she says.

“May I see?”

Cyrene hands her phone to Phainon, and he takes a good look at the image on the screen. Seated among four men Phainon doesn’t recognize is Mydeimos, smiling in a way that almost seems strange. With all the frowning and grumbling that the man had to offer earlier, Phainon was not aware it was possible for him to make such an expression, but he digresses —the entire group in the picture is smiling. One man has his hand on top of another man’s hand, whose free arm is slung around another man.

A lightbulb turns on above Phainon’s head. “This is the polycule.”

“Hm?”

“No, nothing,” he shakes his head.

It doesn’t look like Mydeimos is out of place; he seems perfectly happy where he is, which just further supports the possibility that his parents might just be a little too dramatic. But then again, Phainon accepted the job, his house is on a three-week timer, and the man agreed to a date.

The word drops on Phainon's head like an anvil. A *date*.

He's dating a man for money. Money from *his parents*, at that. And the man himself is not supposed to know that he's going to be paid just to lure him out of his shell. The facts process a day too late, and it makes his stomach churn the same way eating something rotten would.

"Oh, Kephale," he mumbles. "I'm *actually* doing this."

For the first time in years, Phainon's not sure what message Cyrene's face is supposed to express—is it *sorry,* or *I told you this was a bad idea?*

The destination for the night is more a bar than it is a restaurant, and that's what he told Mydeimos—the good food is usually just a bonus, because everyone comes for the drinks. It's open all year round, unlike half the places near the beach. When tourists leave, half the businesses leave, too.

(Mydeimos had given him the stink eye when the word *'bar'* left Phainon's lips. But really, there were very few options on where to go. A quick scan of the commercial side of Aedes Elysiae, and one will see bar after bar after *bar*. Unless Moneybags wants to sit outside an eatery—and Phainon has a strong feeling he *doesn't*—their options are slim.)

Phainon waits outside. Summer is more merciful by the time night rolls around, but it doesn't hurt to dress cool. He's comfortable in his plain shirt and linen shorts—a *safe* outfit, according to Cyrene. Whatever that means.

Mydeimos arrives a minute past nine. A whole minute of tardiness that Phainon can use as leverage for jokes, because if he doesn't will away the guilt in his stomach, he'll look like a hostage the entire date despite being the one who asked Mydeimos out.

However, whatever joke Phainon had planned to spit out remains lodged in his throat. Mydeimos seems to have that effect, he thinks—make his tongue foreign in his mouth, render him stupid with just a look.

The first thing Phainon notices is the hair. Mydeimos' hair is held back by a claw clip, exposing the nape of his neck. Phainon is not a hormonal teenager, he *swears*, but the tattoos reaching Mydeimos' neck are making his imagination work overtime.

The second thing he notices is that Mydeimos smells really, *really* good. It's citrusy. He's tempted to tease and ask if he can see if Mydeimos tastes as good as he smells, but the dull ache on his cheek prevents him from doing so. He'd rather not destroy both his and Mydeimos' image by fistfighting in front of a business.

"Hey," he greets, pretending Mydeimos' sleeveless shirt is not making his head spin. He offers a hand for his date to take because he's willing to push his luck past its usual bounds. "Let's go?"

Mydeimos gives the offered hand a second of his attention before deciding he doesn't want to take it. He nods, "Mm."

Tough. Phainon is not used to the nonchalance. All his previous dates were, in ways, like him—desperate for someone to embrace for the night and stave off the creeping coldness that came with an empty bed. Fingers are quickly interlaced, kisses are given like they're mere candies, and sex is… expected, by the end of it all. One might even say that sex is the main event, and that the dining and sweet talk is just an opening act.

Mydeimos is a change from Phainon's usual picks, though that's partly because he's not one that Phainon picked for himself. Yes, he found Mydeimos attractive—who *wouldn't*—but it's not his style to be so persistent. A single wilting glance is all it takes for him to back off, because he's not one to push his way into places he's not welcome.

"They have really good fries here," Phainon says as they take a seat. He gives Mydeimos his full attention. That's the mission—make the man feel special, lay it on thick. Like he's courting some princess.

"Greasy," Mydeimos notes simply, but his voice has an inflection to it that sounds too close to disapproval.

He blinks. “Oh, I’m sorry. Did you want a salad?”

A flat response to a sarcastic question, “No, I didn’t. I’m not hungry.”

What a conversation-killer. Mydeimos’ talent for making Phainon speechless is not just through looking like a model that just escaped a magazine. He also makes Phainon speechless through his extremely engaging responses. Some banter would be nice, he thinks, but the other half is an unwilling participant.

He claps his hand once, trying to fan away the gloomy air that Mydeimos’ reply has brought to their table, “You know, I have to ask. What’s the routine?”

“The routine?”

“You know, the workout routine for…” he raises his brows, makes a show of eyeing Mydeimos’ body, and then licking his lips. He grins in lieu of finishing his sentence.

“Oh,” Mydeimos replies. His eyes light up. Phainon counts it as a small win. “I warm up ten minutes on treadmill first, then…”

Phainon zones out, eyes zeroing in on the way Mydeimos’ Adam’s apple moves, and he feels an urge to bite the side of that throat. Mydeimos has a blank look on his face now, but how will his features shift if Phainon were to drag a tongue along the side of his neck, he wonders? And will he breathe out shakily, maybe cuss? Will he be shy and try to tug on Phainon’s hair to pull him away, or will he try to press their bodies closer?

“Phainon,” a waiter stands by their table, and just as luck would have it, it’s a friend. “And his date! What are you two having tonight?”

“I’ll have whatever drink he’s having,” is Mydeimos’ response.

Phainon knows a hidden challenge when he hears it. He has two options: he could order the strongest thing they have and watch with delight as Mydeimos struggles through it like everyone does, or he could order

something that Mydeimos would like. The first option is rather tempting because Phainon, frankly, loves to see a tourist's reaction to the local drink, witness how their face scrunch up at the intensity—but he knows it won't be received well, remembering their encounter by the river. It leaves the second option, which would be troublesome… if not for the fact that Mydeimos had already revealed his drink preferences.

"Honey Kumquat Caipirinha for me and this…" *Tumbleweed*. "Hottie."

Kyros shakes his head and sighs, but amusement tugs at his lips as he turns to leave. "Right, right, I'll leave you lovebirds to it. Don't mess this one up, Phainon."

"Ha-ha. I won't!"

When Kyros is out of earshot, Mydeimos turns to look at Phainon again. "You're uninterested."

"I *am* interested," Phainon replies, and he's *honest*. Uninterested? In what world? Phainon has been staring at him all night, save for the time they—*he* had to order. It's just that Phainon would be a hell lot more invested in what comes out of Mydeimos' mouth if he stopped talking like he's perpetually bored. Phainon knows he isn't the problem; he's not boring. Many of his past dates can vouch for that. This twenty-one-year-old celibate, on the other hand? *Hah*.

"You aren't," Mydeimos says. "You haven't been listening to me at all. I can tell. It's more like you're imagining me… standing up on the table and giving you a strip show."

"Are you offering to make that a reality?" is Phainon's immediate response, punctuated by a laugh. The air's getting a little too heavy for a first date—he needs to rein in the mood that keeps going off-course.

Mydeimos' eye twitches. "So you aren't denying it."

The joke falls flat.

For a moment, neither of them speaks. Phainon puts his head in his hands, rubs his forehead. Then, he looks up at Mydeimos again. He lets some honesty bleed through when he says, “You’re just not a very entertaining conversationalist.”

“Say shallow things, get shallow answers.”

Now, *Phainon’s* eye twitches. “Let’s talk about your childhood, then. Mydeimos, where did it all go wrong? When did you realize Santa wasn’t real and that it was just Daddy in a white beard?”

That prompts the faintest of titters from Mydeimos. “You expect me to pour my heart out to you? In your dreams.”

“You are the most confusing man I’ve ever met.”

“Thanks. An honor, considering it’s coming from you.”

“Now, what’s that supposed to mean?”

“You seem to know plenty of men,” Mydeimos replies with a sassy little brow raised. “I’m happy to stand out and claim a title.”

“Hoh,” Phainon guffaws dryly. “You know, it’s not very polite to call your date a slag.”

“I didn’t call you that.”

“You might as well have. What gave you the impression?”

“It’s a conclusion I formed after hearing you fill my ears with pointless fluff.”

“Pointless fluff?”

“Praise. *Empty* praise.”

“It’s not empty praise. I mean it. I do actually think you’re hot.”

“It *is* empty praise because you’re only saying that with the goal of getting me in bed with you.”

About thirty thousand potential replies fill Phainon’s head at once. Ranging from *no shit* to *I would never* to *but will you let me?*

“You’re very intelligent,” Phainon decides to reply. “But wrong. And I do wonder—what counts as meaningful praise to you, Mydeimos? Please, do tell.”

“Not anything that comes from your mouth, that’s for sure.”

He puts a hand to his chest, feigning hurt. “Oh, you’re so mean. Is this any way to treat a date? We hardly know each other, and you’re already at my throat!”

“We hardly know each other because you keep saying worthless things that don’t move the conversation along. You’re a bore, and your attempts at praise are laughable.”

What Phainon feels is *beyond* disbelief at this point. They have to make a new word for it. “*You’re* saying this, mister *‘oh’* and *‘humph?’*”

Mydeimos says, “I already told you. Say shallow things—”

“—get shallow answers,” Phainon finishes. “Right.”

Their drinks are placed on their table. Phainon’s incredulity hasn’t worn off, and he’s sure the smile he gives Kyros as thanks is not the most pleasant one he can offer.

As he lifts the glass to take a sip, he peers at the man seated across the table. Phainon might know what the issue is, why he’s single.

Mydeimos is a brat.

He can’t say he’s shocked, not really. Rich kids from the city tend to have an arrogance that is unmatched. It’s from a lack of discipline as a child; a cheeky remark in kindergarten will go unpunished because daddy can buy

the whole school and all the staff, too. Phainon is willing to bet a good amount of money (even if he probably shouldn't) that Mydeimos' dear parents once called him—or maybe even *still* call him—their precious little prince.

Phainon tries again, because he's many things and one of them *isn't* a giver-upper. "Where are you from, by the way?"

Mydeimos answers, "Kremnos."

"Kremnos?" His brows raise as he echoes the response. "Wow. Wanted to give it a visit back when I was younger."

"Only back then?"

Phainon laughs, "Well, I still do. But I'm comfortable here at home."

"Didn't think you were the type to want to stay in," Mydeimos replies.

"It's not about wanting to stay in," Phainon clarifies. "It's more about a vacation to Kremnos costing a fortune."

"Oh."

And that's another potential pleasant conversation taking a nosedive. *Why* did he say that? He could've said something else. Anything, really. Money talk is the fastest way to bring the mood down.

"…So, what do you do for fun?" Phainon asks, managing a smile. *Move on*, because he is not about to let them sit in here in complete silence. That would be a shoddy first date to have, especially if he's trying to score a second one. And a third. And a fourth. And maybe even a *fifth*, if Mnestia wills it.

Mydeimos, thankfully, replies and goes along with it, "I draw."

"Draw… what?"

Mydeimos hesitates. He looks down at his glass, almost as if… shy. Is that it? Is he ashamed of what he draws? Could it be that he draws something lewd? Maybe something not so easy to admit? Could he be one of those artists Livia talked about—a furry artist? No shame in it, of course. Whatever brings in money! He's not one to judge. In fact, he should be the last to judge a person for what they do for money. Look at him, being a sort of secret sugar baby at the grown age of twenty-nine.

"I draw," Mydeimos swallows. "Animals. People. Or both. Whatever piques my interest."

What a delightfully elaborate answer. And an interesting combination. Phainon might have actually been right about his date being a furry artist. He prompts, "Like, realism? With pen and paper?"

"No. I draw digitally. In a—" Mydeimos frowns. "—cartoon style. And I animate them when I have the time."

Yep. Definitely a furry artist. "You're the artistic type, huh… Didn't expect that one."

Mydeimos eyes him suspiciously. "Why not?"

Phainon gets the feeling that whatever he says next will decide whether the honeyed drink in Mydeimos' hand will stay in the glass or find itself splashed on his face. He cautiously says, "I mean, it's a pleasant surprise! Not a lot of people appreciate art nowadays. Especially with the rise of that, uh, generative stuff recently. You know, the trend of 'turn my image into a Clockie Studio anime.'"

The tension on Mydeimos' hand eases up. He replies, "Oh, that garbage. I find value in the process of creating. It's not always about the outcome."

"Of course, of course," he nods.

"And what do you do when you're not busy acting suspicious on beaches?"

Two feelings emerge at once—incredulity with a side of amazement. Mydeimos is actually asking him questions now. It came with an insult, of course, and Phainon would like to record it, keep a tally for every jab he has to return. But for now, he'll answer properly. "I like to read all sorts of books, no matter the genre. I also like to do treasure appraisals but—" he laughs, catching himself before he says something about his financial situation again. "It's not a very common hobby, so I'm usually watching others do it instead."

"Hm."

Yet another beat of silence. Oh, no, *no*. Phainon is not going to let this momentum die. He turns the conversation back to Mydeimos, asking, "Can I see anything you've made?"

"Huh?"

"You know," he vaguely gestures with a hand. "Your art."

Are Phainon's eyes deceiving him, or are Mydeimos' cheeks getting dusted with the faintest of reds? His date's eyes are lowered, seemingly ashamed. On one hand, there's nothing to be ashamed of, because Phainon won't laugh at anything a person is passionate about. On the other… He wants to see this expression on Mydeimos more frequently.

When the silence lingers for far too long, Phainon adds, "I mean, it's fine if you don't want to. We're all at different skill levels—"

"*Haikas*," Mydeimos grunts, eyes snapping right back at Phainon. "Are you trying to imply I'm not a skilled artist?"

Phainon would ask about the unknown first word, but he decides against it for now. He has to throw in the bait, get Mydeimos to bite it. "No? I'm just saying, it's okay to be unconfident with your art. You know, I wouldn't be jumping to show someone poetry I wrote when I was just starting out," he whistles. "Rookies make rough stuff, so."

A tug on the fishing line. Mydeimos practically snatches his phone out of his pocket. Without breaking Phainon's gaze, he keeps tapping on the screen. And then, he turns his phone around, showing the screen.

On the screen is a cartoon GIF of a man looking suspiciously close to one of Mydeimos' friends, relaxed on a couch with a cat on his lap. The man is petting the cat on loop, and the cat's tail is slowly wagging in response. It's… adorable. It's a sweet scene—and certainly not what Phainon expected. Sure, Mydeimos *did* say he draws animals and people, but a part of Phainon was… well, imagining a whole other thing. That, and he doesn't believe Mydeimos to be the type to draw something cute. But, as they say, to see is to believe.

Mydeimos turns his phone back to him and locks it before hastily shoving it back into his pocket. "Did it look rough to you?"

"No," Phainon smiles. "Looks perfect to me, really."

Yet another pause. Mydeimos says, "Thanks."

Phainon takes in the light flush on Mydeimos' cheeks. He decides to be polite and not comment on it. Instead, he says, "How you're still single is beyond me."

Mydeimos doesn't frown, doesn't give him a dirty look. What he says is, "When did I say I was single?"

Phainon's mouth opens wordlessly. Then, another laugh is pulled from his lips as his brows knit. "An attempt was made at comedy, huh?"

Mydeimos smiles.

(Here, he allows time to melt. Talk, laughter—all from him, unfortunately—and stories filling the in-betweens. Phainon talks about his friends. Mydeimos talks about *home*, fondness coating every word. Phainon finds it just the slightest bit humorous; one would think Mydeimos was torn from his home instead of simply taking a vacation. People filter in and out of the bar until—)

“I had fun,” Phainon says, the greeting that would normally prelude a cheeky little invitation to come back to his place. He doesn’t continue the habit. “Maybe we could do this again?”

Much to Phainon’s surprise, Mydeimos agrees. “Sure.”

Phainon freezes for a split second before grinning. “Ah, let’s—”

“I’ll see you when I do,” Mydeimos says, so sure of himself, and then he’s gone.

“He’s… a bit of a showoff,” Phainon concludes the obligatory debriefing. “And a little dry. But he’s not that bad.”

“You’re going through with it?” Cyrene asks. There’s a very thin trace of distaste on the question, small enough to go unnoticed. Not by Phainon, though. *Never* by him.

A sigh of surrender, “What other choice do I have?”

Livia makes herself at home at Phainon’s kitchen, chowing down on her treat of choice—fried bananas, its exterior crunchy with caramelized sugar. Piso’s on the other side of the table, gnawing at the half-empty plastic of iced candy.

“Wow,” Phainon places his hands on his waist, watching the two with their shamelessly lifted shirts, his shaking fan pointed in their direction. “First of all—it’s *late*. And second… you guys were helping yourselves to my fridge while I was gone?”

“There’s nowhere for us to hang out in without those noisy tourists all stinking up the whole place. *Plus,*” Piso retorts, “you’re the one who said we can come in here anytime.”

“Right. I haven’t forgotten.”

The call of the shower is loud and tempting, especially after a long night at work; Phainon had to smile at a customer trying to ask for his number, tolerate people who spoke far too loudly despite the close proximity to the bar, and another customer whose drunkenness brought memory loss and practically smacked the drink out his hand, claiming they didn't ask for anything. The typical summer night, really. Phainon takes off his nameplate, placing the pin down the table. Then, panic. There's a distinct lack of piles of paper on the surface and—

"Your mail's on the coffee table," Livia explains. "Piso moved it, by the way. I told him not to touch it."

His head snaps at Piso. "You didn't look, did you?"

"Uh, no?" Piso says. "I wouldn't do that."

A sigh of relief. Then—"Don't move anything next time."

Two days later, Mydeimos is looking out of place and overdressed in a family mart—linen shirt with the first few buttons undone, dark pants, half of his bangs braided back, and he completes the look with sunglasses resting on top of his head. It's ridiculous, it's flashy, and somehow expected. While everyone else minds their own business in their tank tops and home shorts, Mydeimos looks ready to be whisked off into a summer-themed photoshoot.

Phianon approaches the man as he's scanning the shelves for snacks. "Hey."

Mydeimos doesn't spare him a glance. "Do you need something?"

"Did you forget me already?" He pretends to pout. "The man who gave you an amazing date just a few days ago?"

"Unfortunately, no," Mydeimos dryly replies. He repeats, "Do you need something?"

“I thought you’d see me when you do, and then we can talk about that second date you agreed to?”

“I—” Mydeimos finally decides to give Phainon a glance, but does a little double-take as his eyes land on the red shirt and trail down the green cargo shorts. His sentence is abruptly cut off, but he immediately tries again, frowning, “I didn’t see you. Not until you started disrupting my shopping experience.”

“Disrupt?” he echoes. “You’re pretty rude, you know that?”

Mydeimos stops as he’s about to put a pack of local treats in his basket. He says, “I’m sorry.”

At that, Phainon blinks owlishly. He says, “I was just joking. I don’t mind.” And he means it—in part because that pretty face can get away with anything, and in part because he’s hired for this. Being around people who liked to tease meant growing a thick skin, too.

The pack of treats rests on the basket, plastic crinkling, the only noise between the two. Phainon thinks he’ll have to carry the conversation again. So, he asks, “Shopping here, huh? What’s on the list?”

“Just shopping for some snacks for my friends back home.”

“Doesn’t that usually happen when you’re about to go home?”

“I’d rather have it done now than rush later.”

“With all these weeks of summer still about to come, they’re more likely to end up in your stomach than anywhere else.”

Mydeimos shakes his head. “I have plenty of self-control.”

“Huh! Must be why you’re still able to resist me after all this time.”

Mydeimos turns to look at Phainon slowly, his face expressing just how unamusing he found the remark. “*You*,” he says the word with heavy

emphasis and mild vexation, “are the most cocky man I’ve ever met. This conversation is over.”

“So our second date’s off, huh?” Phainon jokes. “Aw, you got me all excited for nothing.”

“I didn’t say it was off. I just wish that you would stop yammering on.”

He perks up, “So, we’re still on?”

“You don’t have to sound *that* happy about it,” Mydeimos grumbles, but there’s amusement to be heard beneath it all. Just trying to hide it, and doing a poor job at it, too. “Are you always this desperate for a date?”

“No, not really. Just desperate to be with you.”

“Flattering,” Mydeimos flatly says as he begins to walk towards the cashier. Phainon follows. “This time, no bars. I’ve got a place in mind.”

“Oh? You planned our second date, huh? You weren’t dreaming about seeing me again, were you?”

Mydeimos does not attempt to return the tease. He says, “If you bring me to another bar again, I’ll start thinking you’re an alcoholic.”

“Hey, you agreed to the date! If you didn’t like where we were going, you should’ve told me.”

“I should’ve,” Mydeimos agrees as he places the goodies on the counter. “So I’m telling you now.”

When Mydeimos’ items are rang up, Phainon notices the cashier—Possephone, fresh from her honeymoon—eyeing them with great interest. He considers it a small mercy that she says nothing now, but he’s aware that rumors spread faster than any disease, and he’ll soon hear things about himself that he never knew.

(Later; Phainon will realize that he’s made the most pointless mart run of his life, leaving empty-handed, having forgotten why he came to the mart

thanks to Mydeimos.)

Mydeimos pulls out his wallet, takes out a few bills. He takes the plastic bag, “Keep the change.”

Possephone’s gaze flicks to Phainon, then to Mydeimos. Then, a smile spreads across her face—not a customer service smile, but a *sly* smile. “Thank you for your patronage.”

Phainon begins the interrogation once they’re outside, “So, where are we going? When?”

“Now, since you’re already here. Get in the car.”

What car, Phainon was about to ask, but then they turn the street and he lays his eyes on a red convertible parked in an alley. But of course, the flashy car previously seen is the one owned by Mydeimos. Sure, why not.

The look of mild judgment on Phainon’s face must’ve been clear as day; Mydeimos explains, “It was a graduation gift, back in high school. I didn’t ask for it.”

The explanation does not make it any better. It is not any less gaudy. And Phainon is not quite sure what an incoming college student needs a convertible for when there are more practical cars to have, but what does he know? Rich people do live in a world of their own.

“Get in,” Mydeimos repeats.

Phainon follows the orders. His hand tugs on the handle, and he slides into a car worth more than his debt. He sits stiffly—

Mydeimos extends a hand, offering the plastic bag of treats to Phainon. “Take this.”

“…Do you want me to eat it?”

“No. Hold onto it,” Mydeimos clarifies, exasperated. “The passenger seat’s for my stuff.”

“Oh, I’m sorry for taking the spot, then.”

His sarcasm is not well-received. Mydeimos simply drops the plastic bag on Phainon’s lap. Both hands now free, he peels the car out of the alley… and begins to speed through the road as though they’re in a chase.

“Whoa,” he laughs, nervous because, while he does not know the speed limit, he knows they’re well past it. “Are we in a hurry?”

“Scared? Should I slow down?”

Sort of. “Me, scared? No. This is fine.”

Phainon distracts himself by gazing out the window. He clutches the plastic bag of treats that Mydeimos has placed on his lap as he watches the scenery blur. Trees and more trees. Some people. And then trees again.

“May I ask where we’re going?” Phainon says. “Or will you drive both of us off a cliff if I keep talking?”

“I won’t do anything unreasonable,” Mydeimos says, and Phainon is tempted to argue that he is already unreasonable with his speed. “We’re going to the next town over.”

He can’t help but huff. “Wow, eager to escape Aedes Elysiae?”

“No,” Mydeimos says. “But you’re a local, so everything must be the same old to you by now. Let’s go something new for both of us.”

Phainon turns his head, checking to see if Mydeimos has grown a second one. *Is that a trace of softness in his voice?* “Huh. And how are you so sure I don’t go here, either?”

“Because you’ll tell me,” Mydeimos easily says, looking at Phainon. “Won’t you?”

There’s something about the way Mydeimos speaks—something so attractive that Phainon can’t quite describe. It’s deadly on its own, but combined with the eyes… he can’t help but shift on the leather seat. Like

some sort of school boy having a crush, his heart speeds up under the attention. He's supposed to make Mydeimos' heart race, and yet…

"Eyes on the road," he admonishes instead.

Mydeimos chuckles before turning his gaze back up front. Phainon wills his heart to slow.

Phainon is, at least, in charge of his safety now, behind the wheel of a bumper car. Surrounding him are children giving both him and Mydeimos weird looks, but Phainon is willing to ignore it—especially when Mydeimos has the most diabolical smile on his face, and Phainon can almost see the invisible target that his date is painting on his car.

An amusement park might just be the last place that Phainon expected Mydeimos to take an interest in. Frankly, he looks like a grouch, ready to scoff at anything childish, disapproving of joy. Mydeimos seems set on keeping Phainon guessing, though, and the surprise isn't an unwelcome one. If the man wants to go to the amusement park, then he will. Not like Phainon will protest.

"No head-on bumping," he gestures to the sign. "Be good, Mydeimos. You don't wanna set a bad example for the kids, don't you?"

The warning is ignored. Phainon's car jolts as Mydeimos bumps against him. When Phainon shoots Mydeimos a look of exasperation, Mydeimos defends himself, "It's not a head-on bump."

He murmurs *smartass* under his breath. He returns the favor, steering his car to Mydeimos as the other tries to weave through the packs of children giggling. It's a fail—the children are too close together, closing the path, and Phainon scores a hit on Mydeimos.

"Are you challenging me, Phainon?"

"Me, challenging you? I would never."

(Mydeimos then proceeded to make a point of bumping directly into Phainon—and only into Phainon—the entire time. Seems like so long as Mydeimos is behind any wheel, Phainon's safety is not ensured.)

An aching neck later, Mydeimos practically drags Phainon to a game of ring toss. (Mydeimos wins two rounds, all the rings around the bottles; Phainon doesn't come close to even one win.) And then, air hockey. (Phainon wins; Mydeimos is terrible at playing defense.) And then, balloons and darts. (Mydeimos wins; Phainon's aim has never been the best.) And then, reaction ring. (Phainon wins two rounds; Mydeimos' record sits at seven of ten batons and was about to demand another rematch before Phainon successfully dragged him away.)

"The final challenge," Mydeimos says as he finishes up his cotton candy. "To decide the true victor."

They stop before the high striker, lights obnoxiously blinking. It stands rather tall, taller than most games Phainon has seen before. Or, maybe, that's just a trick his memory is playing on him; he was a boy when he last played such a game and would waste his money repeatedly attempting it for a higher score.

Phainon chuckles, "The *true* victor, huh? What's the prize?"

"Loser will have to pay for the next date," Mydeimos says. "So the winner can freeload in the café of their choice."

Traitorously, Phainon's heart starts racing in his chest, aching to escape the confines of his ribs. It'd be no good to show how ridiculously excited he feels over the prospect of another date. He says, "Next date on a café? You haven't even asked me if I agree to a third one just yet."

"Are you saying no?" Mydeimos challenges, an eyebrow raised.

"It's hard to say no to a face like yours."

"That's not an answer."

Phainon purses his lips. Then, a sigh, and he lowers his head. Strangely, the laugh that leaves his lips sounds fond. “Yes, I’ll go on another date with you. There, happy?”

“Humph.”

Typical, Phainon thinks, and pauses when he realizes he’s formed an idea of what a usual Mydeimos is like. He pushes the thought aside as he moves closer to Mydeimos, watching as the man takes the mallet. He’s half-tempted to ask Mydeimos to slam it down his head instead of the game, but manages to reel in the urge. Mydeimos takes a step back, lifts the mallet above his head, and—

A loud bang as the mallet meets the lever. The machine flashes its lights even more obnoxiously—a feat, truly—and the screen at the very top of the machine reads 147.

Mydeimos turns to Phainon, smiling smugly, so assured of his win. “Your turn.”

“I’m a little occupied at the moment,” he says, looking down at their spoils of stuffed toys from previous games won. “So, if you would please…”

The plushies are transferred to Mydeimos’ arms—a funny yet endearing sight. Muscled arms wrapped around stuffed cats and dogs. Phainon, for the briefest of moments, allows himself to indulge in the image of him taking the place of those toys.

He picks up the mallet, flexes his fingers, and tightens his grip. *Think of your wallet,* he whispers to himself. *Your poor, poor wallet.*

A foreign power surges through his body. The power of being a penny-pincher, he supposes. Empowered by the image of his wallet, healthy and full, Phainon lifts the mallet and brings it down as hard as he possibly can. *Please, 148 or higher. Please.*

The screen reads 146.

Mydeimos' laugh rings from the side, a little too amused over a win in such a childish game. "Too bad," he says as he proceeds to shove the stuffies back to Phainon's arms, bragging both his win and his free arms. "So sad. Don't make that face, I might start to feel bad for you."

Bewilderment is not strong enough a word to describe what Phainon feels. He feels as though he has gotten a clearer look at Mydeimos—sweet-toothed, speedy driver, gloating winner Mydeimos. Phainon doesn't know what's worse: the defeat, or not minding losing as much as he thought he would?

(He and Cyrene have gotten into far too many petty fights during their childhood. *Phainon, the sore loser*, Cyrene would jeer, sticking her tongue out and making an L with her fingers. They wouldn't talk for hours, sometimes *days* afterwards. Then, he'd come crawling back, still pouting, but missing the warmth of her company nonetheless. Grudges have always been Phainon's strength, and Cyrene has always been his weakness.

And Cyrene will remain his only weakness, or so help him.)

"Don't be too happy," Phainon mumbles, embracing the plushies tightly. "I'll beat you next time."

Mydeimos drops him off a few streets away from the fields; the roads are tricky to navigate, and Phainon doesn't want Mydeimos to deal with the headache of looping around just to go back to his posh summer home.

"Are you sure?" Mydeimos asks as Phainon struggles to wiggle out of the car with everything that has been placed on his lap. "You're carrying quite a lot."

Phainon turns to the side, trying to prevent the plushies from practically exploding out of the car should he open the door. "Please, when I was ten, I'd carry sacks of rice from our home to the shops."

"Uh-huh."

At last, the door opens. None of the plushies spill out. *Success*. Phainon's about to leave—then he looks at Mydeimos, plastering a worried look onto his face. "Hey, wait, you forgot something."

Mydeimos bites the bait once again, clueless as ever. He frowns, "Huh. Did I?"

"Yeah," Phainon nods, then grins. "You forgot to give me my goodbye kiss."

In an instant, Mydeimos' face twists as though he has licked a lemon. He heaves out a very heavy sigh. "Get out."

The plastic bag of treats takes its rightful spot on the passenger seat, and Mydeimos drives off. Phainon stays at the side of the road until the tail lights disappear into the distance, waving as much as he could when he's been burdened with keeping their prizes.

The walk back home is short. No matter how long he's seen the same sprawling scenery, its charms never grew dull and, honestly, he thinks it never will. From where he lives, he gets the perfect view of the seemingly endless sea of gold and the sea. Just a stone's throw away are his friends. His whole life, all in a little bubble.

When he passes by a familiar set of pink fences, he briefly considers visiting Cyrene, but then he thinks better of it—tales of his date will be shared only when prompted. He doesn't want to be one of those friends that only speaks about their latest fling and nothing more.

His home is as empty and welcoming as it always is—unpaid bills still waiting, an unwashed glass still at the sink, unfinished book still at its spot on the coffee table. He collapses on the couch, plushies raining down on him. Warmth spreads across his face, unbidden.

(Later, at night, Phainon will lay awake in bed, his gaze meeting a plush cat. Under the dim light of the moon spilling from his windows, he will eye the orangey threads for its eyes, the upside-down V for its mouth, and he'll

think of Mydeimos. Whether he finds himself giddy at the thought or not—that's between him and Mnestia.)

Chapter End Notes

Eurypon: Get a girlfriend, son
Gorgo: Or a boyfriend! He's bi
Eurypon: Damn, nobody want you for real
Gorgo: I'm saying like

Chapter 2: two hands on me

Chapter Summary

> Too serious, too fast, too much.

Chapter Notes

> Massive thanks to Seb, the Phainon to my Cyrene, for beta reading this chapter! Please subject him to 33550336 cycles in case of any mistakes in this chapter; I’m completely blameless!

Phainon’s home had always served as the base of operations for their little band of misfits. Back then, it was because Audata had the most delicious home-cooked meal to offer when they were all tired after a long day of studying and playing, and because Hieronymus had the most exciting stories to tell about his brief trips outside Aedes Elysiae. The dining table accommodated six people—always a space for Cyrene, Livia, and Piso because Phainon likes to bring them along—and the four of them would pretend not to hear when the grown-ups sighed about how they’re all attached at the hip.

Years pass—and maybe it’s because time seems to move slowly in Aedes Elysiae—the house keeps its title. Only now, it’s Phainon running the kitchen and following recipes his mother wrote down, and it’s Cyrene who has stories to tell, sharing what information she’s gleaned from hours working at the beauty parlor. The dining table only accommodates four people now, two chairs having been moved to the patio (and absolutely not because Phainon still feels an ache in his heart when he sees them empty). Cyrene and Phainon find themselves in the grown-up club. It’s not quite the same, no—but the house remains as warm as it always has been, and Phainon is always there to welcome them.

Tonight, their base of operations is in use for movie night.

The theme for tonight's movie night is over-the-top horror—bring your own DVDs, because no one is buying a subscription to Epsilon or Iris Max or whatever platform, and Phainon still has a functioning DVD player. Cyrene taught a masterclass on how to burn a DVD a few years ago, just for the sake of having the two participate in movie nights, because they keep complaining that Cyrene and Phainon are running on nostalgia and are showing films older than them.

Cyrene is brushing Livia's hair in Phainon's living room, comfortably making a home on the couch. There's the smell of the microwave popcorn and too-sweet orange juice. The windows are thrown open, the moonlight pours in beams, and summer feels less like boiling in a pot and more like being cradled with the warmth of a hearth after being in the cold for hours.

"That movie," Piso begins, because he always starts the post-movie conversations with his brilliant commentary. "Was terrible."

"It wasn't that bad," Cyrene says, an elastic band between her teeth. "I think the effects were good."

"No offense–" because bluntly insulting Cyrene is off-limits, "–but I think… you should get your eyes checked. The effects were the worst part. They looked cheap and out of place."

"That's *exactly* why it's so good. It's funny!"

Piso makes a face, but says nothing more. He seems to find a better use of his time, watching Livia as her hair is woven into a braid. Suddenly, that face turns a lot softer and a sort of faraway look is on his eyes, like he's not quite there. It's a look Phainon recognizes, but not one that Livia does; she meets Piso's eyes and her brows draw together.

Before any stray sparks come flying and set the living room on fire, Phainon chimes in, "It's… okay! I mean, we shouldn't expect that much from a forty-year-old film."

Piso seems rather grateful for the distraction. He spares Phainon from the usual snark. "I guess so."

“I think it was okay, too,” Livia says. “The sound effect that played whenever someone was getting stabbed, though… It’s tacky.”

“You’re all so mean,” Cyrene pretends to whine as she secures Livia’s braid with the hair tie. “I was just following the theme! If anything, you guys were too afraid to explore and find *real* over-the-top movies.”

“Who even decided the theme? We already see an over-the-top movie every day. We have Phainon.”

“Thanks,” Phainon dryly says. “I feel the love.”

Phainon knows the battle is lost when even Livia agrees. “He sort of has a point. I mean, remember when that one girl slapped Phainon in front of everyone—”

“—because he didn’t realize they were dating the whole time?” Piso finishes. “Yep. Still do.”

“That was one time! *One!*”

The night goes like this: Piso brings up an embarrassing memory for everyone save for himself. Cyrene brings up the time Piso was caught sneaking out of class and was chased around by his father. Livia laughs as Piso flushes from embarrassment, and Phainon has to peel Piso’s hand from Cyrene’s mouth. They trade stories, share laughter, and then fall asleep all curled up into each other on the sofabed like they’re still children on a sleepover. As long as it’s the four of them, Phainon thinks it’ll always be like this—comfortable and familiar, never changing.

(A text from Mydeinos comes in as Phainon gently moves Livia’s arm from his face. *I’ll see you tomorrow at 11 am*, and then a location pin of a café hidden in the deep alleys of Aedes Elysiae that Phainon never bothered to visit after they tore down the old park.

Tomorrow? You missed me already? He texts back.

Don’t flatter yourself.

It’s so hard to joke around with you. Then, *how did you even find this?*

Looked around virtually using Maps.

Phainon snorts. Of course. But his amusement quickly dies down at the next text Mydeimos sends.

And please don’t wear anything terrible. No bright reds with deep green.

I dress just fine, he replies. Delivered, seen, and silence.

Phainon, for some reason, falls asleep feeling lighter than a feather.)

The next day, Piso insists on walking Livia home. Their shoulders brush as they walk through familiar roads.

Cyrene shoots Phainon a knowing look, and Phainon offers her an amused smirk in return.

“I’m going to bet that they’ll be together by the end of the year. Fancy confession with a letter and flowers and all,” Cyrene says.

Phainon’s smile grows wider. “*Please*, they’ll be together by fall. I don’t think they’re *that* patient.”

“You sound so sure of yourself. What are we betting?”

“Bragging rights as the better seer.”

It’s a flimsy prize at best, but Cyrene smiles back at him nonetheless. “Heh, you’re on.”

A car honks persistently outside of Phainon’s home just as he’s about to take a shower, and he thinks it’s someone sent to tell him about bills he is very much aware of. A twinge of annoyance pricks at his skin as he lets go of the towel and leaves it to dangle on the bathroom hook. *In, out.* He takes in deep breaths, mentally preparing himself for the smile he’s going to have

to plaster for the next few minutes as he mumbles repeated *‘sorry’*s and *‘I understand’*s.

He turns the knob and peeks out—

A red convertible, roof folded, ridiculously flashy and completely out of place in the midst of *this* side of Aedes Elysiae.

“It’s only half past ten—” then, a shake of his head. “No, actually, the bigger question is, how did you find my house? I never gave you my address.”

A second head pops out from the passenger side, the rider popping out of their deliberate concealment from behind Mydeimos. Pink hair, blue eyes, a grin that rivals the sun. *Cyrene*.

“Hi!” Cyrene waves a hand, too happy and smiley for someone who had once made her disapproval of Phainon’s job so apparent.

Mydeimos looks mildly confused as he looks at Phainon. He glances at the woman beside him, “Phainon? You… live together?”

“Oh, we aren’t. Don’t get the wrong idea. We’re neighbors,” Cyrene waves her hands around, then winks. “Don’t worry, he’s all yours. Especially with how much he talks about you…”

Mydeimos turns his head away from Cyrene, which only puts him in view for Phainon to see the red blooming on his cheeks. Phainon doesn’t know whether to smack Cyrene or give her a grateful smile. Maybe both, in order.

In the end, he chooses neither. He slips from behind the half-opened door and closes it behind him before he approaches the two in the car. He then asks, “What is this? Why are you…?” His words trail off in favor of gesturing vaguely at the two.

Cyrene hums, “Oh, he’s driving around the area and saw me struggling to carry my groceries, so Prince Charming offered me a ride to wherever I had

to go.” A dramatic, dreamy sigh. “Wow, so sweet. I should pay you for the ride.”

“No need,” Mydeimos mumbles. “Not after you threatened to smash that brick over my head.”

Phainon peeks in and—*oh*, Cyrene has a hand around a brick on her lap. A whole red clay brick is on the ready, and Phainon… honestly doesn’t even want to know anymore.

“Lesson one as a girl,” Cyrene chirps. “Never get in the car of a random man who offers help.”

“And yet, here you are,” Phainon shakes his head.

“I recognized him a little late, okay?” Cyrene says in defense, her lips forming a little pout. “You *did* go on and on about how he’s attractive, but you hardly talked about his features in actuality! Besides, I had to see for myself what the fuss is about, personality-wise!”

Two very exasperated sighs and an opened trunk later, Mydeimos and Phainon both find themselves carrying grocery bags on the next house over—a house painted in pink and blues, Cyrene’s abode. It’s a place so familiar to Phainon, so much so that he could almost call it his second home. Their rooms faced one another, and, once upon a time, he would sneakily escape his room late in the night in favor of staying in Cyrene’s room. Her home has always been empty, even before her parents passed—always quiet, the only sign of life being the plants that she kept. She was prone to getting lonely, and he, the best friend he declared himself to be, wouldn’t let that happen; he would climb over her window with her help, and then they’d collapse on the floor, trying to keep their laughter to a minimum out of fear that his parents would overhear and drag him back home by the ear.

(Years later, Phainon finds out that they’ve always known, but simply turned a blind eye. His father shakes his head and asks, *Phainon, do you really think we would keep you away from her?* His mother corrects, *Do you think we* could?)

Mydeimos and Phainon are waved off as soon as the plastic bags are put on the kitchen floor, Cyrene declaring she'll let them have their alone time (with yet another wink) before shoving them out of her door.

Then, silence. Silence is very common when it comes to Mydeimos, Phainon knows; he's not very chatty. It's always up to Phainon to fill the empty air.

"You want to wait at my place while I get ready?" Phainon offers. He hadn't expected a visit from anyone—anyone who isn't Livia or Piso or Cyrene, anyway—and grimaces at the thought of his living room still a mess after movie night. "I'll be quick. Just a shower and I'll get dressed."

"Alright."

Phainon leads the way. Mydeimos sticks beside him. The wind blows—what once was a relief for the summer heat is now cruelly sending Mydeimos' intoxicating scent Phainon's way. He catches a whiff of that citrusy perfume once again, and he finds himself swallowing back whatever feeling the scent induces.

Nearby, the bell hanging near the door dings. Mydeimos' gaze stays on it for a beat, and Phainon is grateful for the distraction, his luck finally working in his favor instead of *against* him.

"They're for the fairies," Phainon explains.

Mydeimos gives him a look, like Phainon is just one sandwich short of a picnic. He echoes dryly, "Fairies."

"What?"

"Aren't you a little too old to believe in that?"

"And aren't you a little too young to have frown lines?" A full laugh is tugged from Phainon when Mydeimos' expression twists into a frown. He gestures, "See, that's *exactly* what I mean. You're lacking whimsy in your life, Mydeimos."

Mydeimos doesn’t attempt to respond. Instead, he goes right into the house as Phainon holds the door open.

Phainon is avidly aware that his home is… well, humble compared to Mydeimos’. The kitchen is right next to the living area, there are no glass stairs, and the entire thing can be toured in about three minutes. He’s not ashamed, not really—he simply knows that his place isn’t one to marvel at.

“Don’t mind the living room, please. I have kids.”

Mydeimos turns to him, bemused, “You… have children?”

“No,” Phainon laughs. “I’m kidding. But I did have some friends over last night.”

“It’s fine. The place is cleaner than I thought it would be.”

“What, expected the country bumpkin to live in a pigsty?”

“You have a talent for putting words in my mouth.”

“Not the only thing I could put in your mouth.”

“…You’re not funny.”

Mydeimos stops near the display by the television, eyeing the picture frames. Audata and Hieronymus are sentimental people—*were* sentimental people, and there is no shortage of pictures in albums and frames. However, only the best of the best and sweetest of memories earn their spot on the display, happiness immortalized and there for everyone to see. There’s one of Phainon at his high school graduation, smiling as he holds his diploma and a flower bouquet. Another frame features his exhausted mother smiling as she holds a tiny, wailing Phainon with a red face, fists clenched angrily at the world for having been born. Next to it, a picture of him sitting cross-legged on the grass, making a peace sign as he grins with a missing front tooth, and Cyrene is next to him with a softer, sweeter smile and an arm around his shoulder.

“You’ve known her a while, huh? That pink-haired girl.”

“Cyrene,” Phainon supplies as he stops next to Mydeimos. “Yes. She’s been my best friend since forever.”

(*Best friend* feels too light a word, frankly. He was there when she was still scared of ghosts, crying that she *swore* something moved in the dark. She was there when he still believed he’d someday be a hero, wearing a blanket cape around his shoulders. He was there when she got her first crush on a girl and first heartbreak in one go, comforting her after her letter was torn to shreds and a cruel word was thrown in her face. She was there in the aftermath of his first physical fight, handing him a cold compress as he stared at his face in the mirror, tender with bruises. They were *Phangry* and *Reney* together, starry-eyed children trusting tarot cards to foretell their fortune. Now, they’re just themselves—*Phainon* and *Cyrene*, no longer children running through the dirt paths, but adults who drink shitty beer together at every B-movie night. *Best friend* is the closest, existing word to describe what it is that he and Cyrene have.)

Mydeimos’ voice lowers. “Best friend…”

Phainon can’t help the glee he feels when he hears that tone. He smiles, “Huh? What’s wrong? Don’t tell me you’re jealous? Me and Cyrene… we really are just friends, you know.”

“I didn’t say anything,” Mydeimos replies, words coming out in a single breath and sharper than a knife.

That pulls laughter from Phainon. He lightly says, “You didn’t have to say it.”

When Mydeimos glares, Phainon grins. And then, he dares to get closer, placing a hand on Mydeimos’ shoulder. He whispers playfully, “You heard what she said. I–” His fingers slide underneath the cotton shirt, ghosting over Mydeimos’ nape. “–am all yours.”

Mydeimos flinches back like he’s been burned, his face now a vivid red. This time, there’s no fist meeting Phainon’s face, no riverwater to swallow, no drink at risk of being tossed. Well, there *are* the picture frames that could be smashed over his head, but—

“Just—” Mydeimos grits out, hand on his nape, attempting to maintain his dignity even as his face is on fire. “Take a damn shower.”

Mydeimos punishes Phainon by making his pocket hurt and purchasing the most expensive items on the small menu—two wildly overpriced slices of Belobogian pizza and a strawberry parfait with pink wafer sticks sticking out of the yogurt. He doesn’t say it’s meant to be punishment, but Phainon only needs to glance at the quietly smug look on the man’s face to know.

“I thought you didn’t like greasy food?” Phainon points out as Mydeimos finishes the final slice.

“When did I say I hated greasy food?”

“…You know, on the first date, when you might as well have told me to keel over and die when I mentioned that there were good fries in the bar,” Phainon recounts.

Mydeimos hums—hums! He’s doing *what?* “I didn’t say I hated it. I just said it was greasy. That’s it.”

This time, Phainon’s the one giving an unamused look. “Right. I just expected you’d be a lot more… picky with your diet.”

“Why?”

Mydeimos is really the type to want everything spelled out for him, doesn’t he? And with purpose, too. He has this smile on his face, like he’s getting top-tier entertainment from the man before him. Phainon can’t find it in himself to complain as he’s reduced to a jester, though—that smile on Mydeimos’ face is contagious.

“I don’t know,” Phainon replies. “Maybe it has something to do with your figure.”

“You like my figure a lot,” *Keen observation, Brother Hanu. Please, tell us more about your findings.* “You keep mentioning it.”

“It’s hard to ignore.”

“Thanks,” Mydeimos flatly says. Then, as he picks up the spoon and prepares to dig into the sweet treat, “It’s cheat day. I can indulge.”

With that, Mydeimos shoves a spoonful of parfait into his mouth, then wipes the corner of his lips clean of yogurt. Phainon’s imagination absolutely does not run. Why would it? Why would he imagine Mydeimos’ hair held back by his hand? Why would he imagine Mydeimos’ mouth full of something else? That would be absurd.

This time, Mydeimos breaks the brief silence. “You hardly tell me anything about yourself.”

(His job is to push Mydeimos to the world of dating, not take up brain space. The less Mydeimos knows about him, the better.)

“Huh,” Phainon leans back against the seat, pretending to be in thought. “Do I…?”

“Yes,” Mydeimos affirms as he prepares yet another spoonful. “Tell me something interesting.”

Just like that, Phainon is put on the spot. He struggles to think of anything particularly interesting about his life as Mydeimos’ eyes are cast on him, expectant and soft in a way that makes his heart skip a beat or two. Mydeimos has been very dry for the past two dates—and Phainon expected him to be a far tougher nut to crack—yet here he is, actively engaging in conversation.

“Uh…” He frowns, because it has been a long time since he’s ever had to drop shallow trivia about himself. Everyone knows everyone in Aedes Elysiae—at least, those who matter know one another. The last time he’s ever been asked to share something interesting about himself was in orientation week for a student organization… eight years ago. Nearly nine, actually. “I don’t know how to drive.”

Mydeimos’ brows raise. “You don’t?”

“Never had a reason to learn,” Phainon explains. “Besides, I don’t have a car and I don’t plan on getting one, either. My bike works just fine, and it’s enough to bring me places I need to go.”

“I could still teach you,” Mydeimos offers with a little tilt of his head. “Knowing how to drive isn’t a bad skill to have.”

He thinks of it, humors the thought—him, behind the wheel. Mydeimos, on the passenger seat with a clipboard and (most probably) an irritated expression on his face as he barks orders. Phainon thinks it’s not too bad.

(And then, a sudden memory of gripping onto a plastic of treats, the greenery around them turning into a blur, the wind in his hair. A speed demon of a teacher.)

“Thanks, but I’ll pass,” Phainon carefully says. “I wouldn’t want to take up your time.”

“You already are taking up my time,” Mydeimos states.

“Sorry about that?”

“We both know you aren’t sorry about it.”

Phainon smiles. He takes a bite of his honeycake and says, “See, no need to ask questions. You already know me.”

Mydeimos takes Phainon home. Well, he was *supposed to* take Phainon home, but somewhere along the winding roads and under the burning afternoon sun, they find themselves taking a detour. Away from the hubbub of the commercial side of Aedes Elysiae, the lurid lights, and the noise. Deeper within the parts yet to have been touched by change.

The Sacrament Courtyard was once littered with many people throughout the day. Keepers of the shrine and people who believed in Oronoyx alike would move through its maze-like corridors and maintain its cleanliness. With time, it’s turned from a place of worship and into an abandoned lot,

just waiting to be bought and then reconstructed into something else that the tourists can have for themselves. Its keepers have long left, and those that are sentimental enough to try to keep it clean for old times' sake simply give up; maintaining a large courtyard is *hard work*, and hard work deserves *pay*.

"Cyrene and I used to play tag and hide and seek in here," Phainon says, leading Mydeimos up the staircase of the abandoned courtyard. "Then, the adults would shoo us away and tell us to play somewhere else."

"And would you?"

"No," he laughs. "Besides, they don't get *too* mad."

"Seems like testing people's patience has always been your expertise."

Mydeimos steps onto the balcony with Phainon. Phainon's heart swells when he notices the change in Mydeimos' expression. *Ah.* Yet another person captivated by the view below. Trees embrace the sides of the balcony, framing the scene of blue summer skies and the rolling ocean stretching out into infinity—the sea shimmers with the kiss of the bright sunrays, the waves glimmering like diamonds. The summer sky is unchanging, hues of blue still clinging despite the hour. From here, the rest of the world seems to melt away, leaving only the beholder and the picturesque view.

(This is a part of Aedes Elysiae that Phainon dares not share so easily. He likes to think of it as a secret for him to keep, a place so sacred and dear to his heart that he wouldn't want to profane it with the touch of another, the memory of another. He doesn't know whether it's foolishness or a deep sense of regret and guilt that pushes him to introduce this view to Mydeimos. A trade; your trust and your time, in exchange for my slice of paradise.)

"Pretty, right?" Phainon says, nudging Mydeimos out of his trance. "Cyrene and I would waste hours after class here on this balcony, doing homework or doing tarot readings or just talking."

Mydeimos seems hesitant to look away from the scenery. “Tarot readings?”

“Yeah. We’d ask the cards all sorts of things. If we’re going to pass the next exam, if we’re going to have a good harvest, if our crush likes us back…”

“You believe in that?”

“Are you always this skeptical of everything?” Phainon groans. “Yes, we do believe in it. *Believed* in it. It’s nice to think that someone out there always listens and always has an answer for you, no matter what.”

“I’m not skeptical of everything all the time,” Mydeimos retorts. “I believed in unexplainable things, too.”

“Yeah, like what?”

“Well…” He shifts, turning around and resting his back against the stone railings. “I used to think that if you swallowed watermelon seeds, a watermelon will grow in your stomach.”

“That’s just called being a kid. *Everyone* believed that.”

“Well, I used to think that Santa Claus was real. I’d write him a letter, too.”

“Hah! So you *did* believe in Santa. I knew it.”

“I was ten, and I trusted my parents when they told me only good boys get presents,” Mydeimos shakes his head. “I figured that was utter bull when I got in massive trouble, but still got the kitchen knife set I wanted.”

Phainon blinks. “You were a kid writing to Santa that you wanted a kitchen knife set… and your parents *actually* bought them?”

“I like cooking,” Mydeimos says, as if that justified giving a child a set of knives. “I’ve been helping out in the kitchen since I could control my hands.”

He tries to picture it—a small Mydeimos, a strict frown on his face, bossing the *real* workers around in the kitchen. Probably crossing his arms and

huffing out nonsensical instructions. Phainon snorts at the image. "*Helping out* in the kitchen? Really? Maybe that's what your parents told you to make you feel better."

Mydeimos frowns, "I'm serious. I do help out. It'd be strange for me to not know my way around the kitchen, since my family owns restaurant chains."

"Mydeimos, I don't know if you've learnt this over time, but *owning* and *working at* something are two different things," Phainon laughs. "Most people don't really care about your capabilities if you own everything. Some tech CEOs can't even work their way around basic programming."

"Then they don't deserve what they've been given."

(Bitterness takes hold of Phainon, sudden and unwelcome. *Cold*. As if someone like Mydeimos could understand, could *truly comprehend* what it's like. A man whose family has a summer home in a far-off province, who drives a car many can only dream of, whose dating bounty could pay off a debt.)

"You're not a child. You know that not deserving something hardly matters when you have the money to get it anyway." Another laugh, empty this time. "But I guess some people want to feel like they earned something they were already born with. Prove they're worth the title. I guess that's better than doing nothing."

"It's not about wanting to prove my worth. It's about being useful."

Phainon's mouth runs, "And are you useful to those restaurants? Personally cooking in the back and answering to every customer's demand and everything?"

"…No."

"Point proven."

Regret comes late; it comes when the words have already left his mouth and are already hanging over them like a heavy weight ready to crush what they

have. Phainon's charm, he knows, is a flimsy thing—a practiced performance more than it is instinct. Lips tugged into a smile, saccharine tones, the need to show he can handle all that's coming; a mask he wears to convince not only others, but himself, too.

Mydeimos huffs, "You've got quite the mouth on you. Finally, you're not kissing my ass anymore."

That makes Phainon pause. He had let his thoughts slip, let his bitterness show. Catches his words when it's far too late. Resentment is not a good look, especially when it comes unsolicited and unleashed upon a man undeserving to bear the brunt of years' worth of it. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to come off as—"

"No," Mydeimos shakes his head. "This is better. I prefer it like this."

Phainon wants to say, *you wouldn't*. Perhaps it's a small mercy they've only met just now, and Mydeimos isn't aware of how high the pedestal goes. Phainon is known to be sweet, helpful, and selfless—all things false. He can't even help himself; how do people view him so highly?

None of the words slip through the bars; they remain contained, carefully sealed behind an apologetic smile. "Like… what?"

"You, finally telling me what you think instead of smiling and nodding at everything I say."

Phainon turns around, leaning against the balcony in a way similar to Mydeimos. He tries for a lighter tone, "You prefer it when people are mean to you? There's a word for that."

"Not mean," Mydeimos corrects. "*Honest*. I prefer it if people would stop their insincere kindness and preluding their words with pointless pleasantries. I'd rather people be direct."

"Right," Phainon nods. He places a hand over his chest before making a fist and extending it towards Mydeimos.

Mydeimos huffs, looking down at his hand blankly. “What are you doing?”

“What? You don’t know this?” Phainon asks, shaking his fist. “*I offer my heart to you.* Did you skip being ten years old and doing this with your friends? It means, you’re getting honest Phainon from here on out.”

“So, you’ve been dishonest before this time?”

“*Oronyx have mercy,*” Phainon mumbles to himself, dropping his hand. Then, he says to Mydeimos, “No. I’ve been very honest. I mean everything I say.”

“You meant it when you asked me if I would be willing to give you a strip show?” Mydeimos’ eyes narrow suspiciously.

“No. That was a joke. I told you it was a joke.”

“Then that means you *don’t* mean everything you say.”

Phainon’s lips part, but not a single noise escapes. He is speechless yet again. He’s appalled at the display of obtuseness—until he sees the small twitch to Mydeimos’ lips, and he realizes, *oh*. He’s being teased. Of course, this man’s sense of humor is dry, too. The man executes his jokes the same way he normally speaks. “Oh, I get it now,” he flatly says. “You’re a wonderful comedian, Mydeimos.”

“Mydei,” he says. A beat, then, “Just Mydei is fine.”

“Oh,” Phainon stupidly replies. “Mydei, then.”

“Better,” Mydei says.

The quiet, even if brief, makes Phainon’s skin crawl. He wants to fill the air with chatter, if only to distract himself from the way Mydei’s name makes him feel a strange rush. It’s something as simple as a *nickname*—why is he acting like it’s such a big deal? It’s not. It’s just a more familiar way—no, a shorter way—to refer to him.

(*Undeserving,* a voice says in the back of his head. *Don’t act so familiar*.)

“So! You’re from Kremnos. How much different is Kremnos from…” he gestures to the scenery behind them. “…this?”

“Very different. Urban. Noisy. Less trees in the distance, more skyscrapers,” Mydei replies. “But convenient. Everything I need is right at home—my family, my friends, university.”

“Oh?” Phainon raises his brows. “So you’ve never really left your city for long?”

“No. I purposely chose to study there. I’d rather be close to family. Even if my family has the habit of visiting unannounced because they’re close by.”

“When you say family, is it just you, your mother, and father?”

Mydei shakes his head, “No. I have an uncle, too. Less suffocating, more strict, if that makes sense. My mother and father… they have tendencies.”

“You sound annoyed.”

Mydei lets out a little amused sound, “I am, a little. I’m not a child anymore. They act like I need their help every step of the way. I don’t.”

(*We’re so worried*, Gorgo says. A negotiation to pull their son out of his shell—a deal that Phainon took.)

Phainon ignores the dread in his stomach. “I’m sure they’re just worried about you. You should treasure every moment you have with them while they’re still there.”

“Everyone says that,” Mydei grumbles. “*I know*. I just wish there was a balance between being absent and being a helicopter hovering over me all the time. I’m old enough to look after myself. I don’t need them to make my choices for me and act like they know what’s best.”

The guilt is swallowed back, and Phainon manages to say, “I’m sure they would understand if you explained.”

“Would they,” Mydei asks, but it sounds more like a *challenge*. “Or do you just trust my parents too much for a person who hasn’t even seen the worst of what they’ve done?”

Curiosity twists along with the guilt. “What have they done before?”

“Pretty much all my friends from kindergarten to middle school have been picked by them,” Mydei says, shaking his head. “They’d pay their parents to make their kids befriend me. It’s all kids who are… bubbly, smart, have all the traits you want your kid to have. Probably hoped to have me influenced, more well-behaved.”

Phainon can’t contain the grimace this time—at least, he can pretend it’s due to the tale. “Picking your friends, huh…”

“Yes,” Mydei looks at Phainon, nodding slowly at his expression. Like, *it’s unbelievable to me, too.* “They told me about it, even. Admitted that my friends had been hired. So, when I went to high school, I purposely befriended the ones I knew my parents would hate, just to spite them.” He laughs lightly. “They became my true friends in every sense of the word, and spite stopped being the thing keeping me close to them.”

“Are you still friends with those people?”

“I am. They’re my closest friends,” Mydei says, a fond look softening his sharp features. “If it weren’t for them… I think I would’ve been resigned to my life being one completely decided by my parents.”

Despite himself, Phainon manages to ask, “If they’ve upset you that much, how come you’re still… close to them?”

Mydei looks down. The quietude feels almost as heavy as the weight on Phainon’s chest. Silence rings a little too loud and his palms itch and his stomach twists and—

“I have forgiven them for it,” Mydei replies.

(*Forgiven*, Mydei says. He trusted those people—*friends* that his parents have essentially *bought* for him. Phainon thinks about it—if all he thought was true turned out to be orchestrated, would he have it in himself to forgive who directed the act? He doesn't give the question time to simmer before he has an answer prepared. He wouldn't be able to forgive it. Forgive *them*. He would hold a grudge forever, keep the wounds of betrayal eternally open, because that's how he's always been. And yet…)

Mydei continues after a moment, "I'm sorry. That was a lot. I didn't mean to ramble on."

"No," Phainon hurriedly replies. "It's alright. I'd like to learn more about you."

"You already know too much about me," Mydei says, and the air feels a little less suffocating with that familiar trace of sass in his words.

"I could never know too much about you," Phainon returns, smiling. "I wouldn't be satisfied until I can recognize you with my eyes closed."

"That'd be easy. I could speak, and you'd know."

"Humor me, Mydei."

"I do," Mydei huffs. "I humor you more than I should."

"Not enough, actually."

"What an unfitting place to argue. We're before a wonderful view, and we're wasting our time with this pointless conversation."

"We have our backs to the view, actually," Phainon corrects, just to be annoying. Then, he holds his hands up, fingers making a frame around Mydei. "Oh, actually, on second thought… the view *is* before me."

"There you go again," Mydei sighs.

Phainon drops his hands with a laugh. Then, he inches closer, giving Mydei a nudge. "You're not *actually* uncomfortable with it, are you?"

“…No. If I were, I would’ve told you.”

Thought so, Phainon wants to say, but doesn’t. Instead, he offers Mydei a smile. Then, he jabs his elbow at Mydei’s side lightly, spouting his fun fact for their stop. “You know, people would go up here and scream their frustrations out.”

“Here? In a courtyard?”

“Yeah!” Phainon nods. “They believe that Oronyx will hear it better. You know, with them being up in the sky and all.”

A look of mild intrigue. “Yeah?”

“Yes,” Phainon nods. “Like this—”

Mydei watches in horror as Phainon cups his hands around his mouth and faces the scenery. Phainon screams, “My monthly expenses are rising, but my monthly salary is the same as it always has been!”

A wince takes over Mydei’s expression at the volume, and he looks down. “Someone must’ve heard you.”

“Nope! We’re pretty high up, don’t worry.”

Mydei pauses, then his jaw slackens. “You don’t actually expect me to do it, do you?”

“It’s a custom! When in Amphoreus—”

“—do as Amphoreans do,” Mydei finishes. “Yeah, but I’m already Amphorean.”

“Come on. Do you think Oronyx is so sensitive that they’ll start crying because you yelled?”

“Not even close to what I’m thinking, but nice try. I was thinking something along the lines of being a public nuisance by screaming.”

“No one hears,” Phainon reassures once more—a white lie, because people *do* hear, they just don’t care. “Seriously, try it.”

A battle of wills: Phainon’s pleading smile versus Mydei’s deep frown. The fight lasts for a moment, both fighters unyielding in the face of their opponent, but a little tilt of a head from Phainon makes Mydei falter, leaving an opening for a win.

A win is promptly snatched by Phainon. Mydei sighs and grasps the railings, leaning forward awkwardly, limbs all stiff. “I… I still don’t know what I want to do after graduating!”

(Mydei’s voice hardly travels, his volume barely rising. But he humored Phainon, and that’s what matters most.)

Phainon hums, “Makes you feel better, right?”

“Not really,” Mydei says.

“Aw, not even a little bit?”

“Not even a little bit,” Mydei confirms, but Phainon sees hints of a smile. It’s contagious.

Smiling around Mydei is easy, strangely enough. It’s almost natural—scarily so. Phainon almost wants to pull back before it becomes a habit, but this exchange with Mydei feels far too good to withdraw from.

Then, the thought of summer. It’s *summer*. Mydei’s only here for a while, not forever. When the days start to get shorter, when the night creeps in sooner, when the heat starts to ease up… Mydei will be gone. The arrangement would be over.

“You’ll come back here, won’t you?”

The question seems to take Mydei by surprise just as it did Phainon. “I guess I would. Aedes Elysiae—”

“For me,” Phainon clarifies, mouth functioning far faster than his brain. “You’ll come see me again, won’t you?”

Mydei pauses, and Phainon thinks he might’ve stepped over the line. *Too fast, too soon, too much.* He’s about to open his mouth to take it all back, laugh good-naturedly like his heart isn’t ready to beat out of his chest—

“I would,” Mydei replies. And just to make Phainon ready to drop dead on the floor, he adds, “But I’d like to show you around Kremnos, too.”

When Phainon opens his mouth to respond, he hopes he won’t throw his heart right up. “What, planning to bring me along with you when you go home? Make me your little souvenir from Aedes Elysiae?”

“You’re not little,” is Mydei’s response. “And you’re not a souvenir either. I simply want to return the favor of you showing me around.”

“Wow, do you do this to every friend you make on vacation? Offer to show them around your turf?”

“*Every friend?*” Mydei echoes and frowns. Then, he seems to think better of it and shakes his head, interrupting whatever train of thought he might’ve had. He says, “I don’t go on many vacations. I told you, everything I need is at home.”

“Not big on vacations at all?”

“No. I mean, my parents bring me along when they vacation, but…”

“Let me guess—you stay in the inn most of the time?”

“To my parents’ dismay,” Mydei confirms. “I do like to see the scenery, though. I’d go out and just stop by the view, and I’d draw it.”

Phainon whistles, “Wow. So you also do landscapes.”

“I don’t like taking pictures. I’d rather detail every tree or hill or wave with my own hand. Helps me remember the moment for longer.”

“You seem to really like art, and you’re pretty good at it, too. Have you ever considered pursuing a career in art? You know, since you mentioned you don’t know what to do post-grad.”

“Career?” Mydei tilts his head. “No, not really. I said I didn’t know what I *want* to do; I know what I *could* do. But if I made a career of everything I’m good at, I’d have a thousand—no, a *million* jobs.”

Phainon laughs indignantly, “And you say I’m cocky.”

“I’m simply learning your ways,” Mydei replies, not missing a beat.

“You should’ve learned how to flirt like me instead.”

“What, so I can go on and on about how I admire your body?”

“It would be nice to hear,” Phainon teases, grinning. “A change of pace from the usual snark.”

“You’re already aware that I find you attractive. There’s no need to reiterate.”

Mydei looks at Phainon with that usual frown on his face. Phainon’s heart stutters. Mydei is beautiful despite the expression strewn on his face, but Phainon still prefers to see that pretty flush from before. So, Phainon pushes, “But I want you to say it.”

There. The slightest of reds on his face. “No.”

“Please?”

“You’re just asking to get your ego stroked.”

“No, I just want to hear you say something sweet to me!”

“It *is* a matter of stroking your ego, then.”

“Please, Mydei?”

Mydei repeats, the flush on his face spreading further. “No. Praise is earned.”

“Will I earn it if I beg?”

Mydei closes his eyes. Breathes in. Phainon braces for the incoming punch.

It comes, alright—just not in the place he expected it to land. Mydei opens his eyes again, and he says, awkward like he’s attempting a dance with no practice, “You’re very handsome.”

Like a schoolboy praised by a crush, Phainon feels heat rush to his face, too. For a while, they simply look at one another, seemingly equally flustered. Then—

He tries to laugh. Keyword: *try*. It sounds strained to his ears. Too breathless and nervous. “Is that the best you could do? Praising me like you’re a grandma?”

Mydei’s eye twitches at the provocation. The flush on his cheeks does not fade. “What do you want, then? You beg for praise, but you laugh when I answer your pleas.”

Unable to resist, Phainon reaches a hand forward to poke Mydei’s cheek as he says, “I mean, I had high expectations for something I had to earn.”

“Humph,” Mydei holds Phainon’s hand—not to push it away, but to simply hold it in place as it attempts to poke his cheek once more. “I didn’t make you beg. Take it or leave it. I did what you asked for.”

“Can I negotiate for a better compliment?”

With the free hand, Phainon pokes Mydei’s cheek. His hand is caught once more, both now held in place by Mydei. Phainon attempts to struggle out of Mydei’s grip, but his hold is tight, like he doesn’t want to let go. It makes Phainon laugh.

“If you wanted to hold me—”

“I didn’t say that.”

“—You didn’t *have to* tell me, but you *could*. I would let you.”

“You let me do a lot of things,” Mydei grunts, but he doesn’t sound at all displeased.

“And I would let you do plenty more,” Phainon says, careful with the suggestion on his words. Anything too thick, and Mydei might just turn around and flee. But, to his delight—

Mydei doesn’t run. He doesn’t shy away with a turn of his head, doesn’t loosen his hold on Phainon. Instead, his gold eyes meet with blue ones, unflinching. A *first*—Mydei is the first to tell Phainon when he’s being too much, being annoying, being too *anything*.

And they stare at each other. Phainon wants to shift, feeling almost uneasy under Mydei’s eyes. A strange thing to feel, when Phainon has always been unflinching when it comes to this. *This*, being the prelude to a kiss. His palms start to sweat, his neck heats up, and he knows it’s not summer’s fault. This one—all Mydei’s fault.

He leans forward, testing the waters. Giving Mydei an opportunity to back away and tell him *no*. He’ll take it gracefully, he thinks, even if he’ll be disappointed. But honestly, he doesn’t want to be disappointed, he doesn’t want Mydei to shy away, he doesn’t—

Mydei kisses him.

It’s a sorry excuse for a kiss—just the briefest, faintest press of their lips, and it’s gone as quick as it came. But it’s still a kiss. The want for more is one that comes naturally, especially when he’s been given the stingiest of touches.

“Sorry,” Mydei says, as if there’s anything to apologize for.

“No,” Phainon chases after Mydei, only for his lips to be covered by Mydei’s palm. He flashes his tried and tested, effective pleading eyes, and

he relishes in the way Mydei wavers, even if only for a second.

“Enough for now,” Mydei says. *For now*, he says. *For now, so there’ll be a next time. For now—*

Phainon’s mind finally gets the Mydei-shaped pebble out of the gears, and the cogs of his rationality spin once more. He steps back, places a healthy and friendly distance between Mydei and himself. “You’re right,” he says, “We probably shouldn’t… in this courtyard.”

Mydei’s features twist into an expression of mild mortification, as if they did more than just graze their lips. “Oh.”

“It’s okay. Oronyx will forgive us… I think.”

The silence lingers—this time, comfortable. Not something waiting to be broken by an ill-received joke or a shallow question. A breeze whistles past.

“I should probably go home,” Mydei says after a long while. “My parents are waiting for me.”

“*Dude*,” Phainon snorts, like his lips aren’t still buzzing with the thrill of feeling Mydei’s mouth against his. “You’re twenty-one, and they’re still looking for you when you’re gone?”

Mydei frowns. “We’re having dinner together. I’m supposed to help with the cooking.”

Phainon sighs in mock exasperation. “Go, run back to Mommy and Daddy, then.”

“Don’t be upset,” Mydei says as he straightens his clothes. “You’ll see me tomorrow.”

“Hah, well, someone beat you to the appointment slot. I’m out with my friends tomorrow.”

“The girl—*Cyrene*, she invited me.”

“Oh?” Phainon scrunches his nose. Mydei… with his friends. With Cyrene, it’s fine; she showed she’s fine with him. Or, at least, put up an act that seemed to say she was fine with him. But with Livia and Piso… Phainon isn’t quite sure.

“It’s alright if you don’t want me to come along.”

“No, I *do* want you to come along.”

A smile plays at Mydei’s lips, satisfied. “Good. Then, I’ll see you tomorrow.”

(The drive home is quiet and a little slower. And, most importantly, when Phainon jokingly asks for his goodbye kiss, Mydei gives him an unamused look but pulls him close nonetheless.)

“This is the most important piece of the puzzle. The maker or the breaker. Purple or blue?”

It’s eight in the morning, the birds are chirping right by the window, and Cyrene is dangling two cover-up skirts in front of Phainon as she stands in her pink bathing suit.

Despite her groaning and moaning over Phainon’s *hopeless* fashion sense—which he disagrees with, by the way, he knows how to dress himself—he’s made the victim (audience and judge, according to Cyrene) of the morning’s one-man fashion show, the only model being none other than *her*. Not that Phainon hates it, no. It’s just that she asks him for his opinion and then proceeds to wear the *opposite* of what he chose.

He can hardly focus on the question. Or Cyrene, for that matter. He hardly slept. He wasted the night exercising because he figured it was the only way to calm his nerves. Only that it didn’t work, and instead, he’s aching all over—running on three hours of sleep, coffee, and the thrill of seeing Mydei later.

“I think they both look good,” he offers bleakly. “Though, I think blue complements your eyes more…?”

“Wrong!” she says, wagging a finger. “Purple fits my bathing suit better.”

He scratches his head. “Oh. Okay?”

He watches, then, as Cyrene faces the mirror and wraps the purple skirt around her waist. She adjusts the flower resting behind her ear, flicks her hair behind her shoulder, practices her stance in the mirror as if she needed to perfect her appearance. Cyrene is naturally charming; a single smile from her is enough to capture anyone’s heart. It’s something that, combined with Phainon’s smooth-talking, has gotten them out of unpleasant situations far too many times.

“There’s no need to stare at your reflection for an hour more,” he chimes in, reminding her of his existence as he leans back and sinks deeper into the beanbag chair. “You look good already.”

“Ah, but I need to up my game, so I can catch the attention of the cute girls,” she says. “I can’t let you leave me behind in the realm of love!”

“You know it’s not like that,” he replies, but whether it’s to convince himself or Cyrene, he’s not sure. “It’s not love, it’s business. I take Mydei out on dates, his parents pay me.”

(He doesn’t speak of the kiss, because it’s not a big deal; he’s done more with others, in a shorter amount of time. He doesn’t speak of the excitement of seeing Mydei, because it’s something she’ll cling to and tease him over.)

“Mydei?” She eyes him suspiciously through his reflection in the mirror. “When did *Mydeimos* turn into *Mydei*?”

“Yesterday. He told me to call him Mydei.”

“And what does he call you now? Honey? Darling? My love?”

If Mnestia wills it. “No. Come on, does he look like the type to start using those names? He’d probably sooner drop dead than use pet names. I’m just

Phainon to him.”

“Mm…”

“Now, why are you interrogating me all of a sudden? I told you I have no plans to break his heart. I’m going to keep it cool and casual for the two of us, then let it naturally die when summer’s done.”

“And if *he* breaks *your* heart?”

“What?” He laughs, uneasy. “I’ll say it again: it’s not like that. You know I’m not for those serious relationships. I’m far too busy for it.”

“Busy, or just evading everyone who wants to get close to you?”

“Both,” he admits. “But it’s directly linked. I’m busy, so I’m evading everyone. I’m evading everyone because I’m busy. See? Simple maths.”

Cyrene’s expression shifts, almost contemplative. Phainon knows what it implies, of course—he knows her well. But in the end, all she says is, “Mm, if you say so!”

The skies are clear, the sun is cooking the world alive—most rational and intelligent people know it’s absolutely not the right hour to come to the beach—and the shore is littered with the few people who can tolerate the heat.

“It’s perfect,” Piso says as he wipes away sweat with the back of his hand. “There aren’t many people.”

“And you’re sweating like a pig. Gross,” Livia points out, but doesn’t shy away from nudging his side with an elbow.

Piso shoots Livia a glare, “Oh, I’d *love* to see you stay dry and fresh in this weather. Don’t let me see a single drop of sweat on you.”

The incoming banter is broken up by Cyrene pressing a can of iced tea to their necks, returning from her run to the vending machines by the souvenir

shop nearby—because if it's not Phainon breaking up the fight by pulling the two away by the scruff, it's Cyrene that unites them by emerging victorious in their game of *who annoys who the most*. Both shriek at the cold, and Cyrene *laughs*. As easy as that, whatever complaints the two had prepared die down in their throats.

(Cyrene has always been the bright and sweet girl that Phainon took after, the model for his charm since the moment he watched her haggle a two-hundred Balance Coin dress down to a mere fifty Balance Coins. Her charm is natural, able to bring laughs to even the most serious of tables, able to bring smiles to all faces; his charm is barely half of what hers is, a cracking mask that lets slip the clumsiness beneath. It works, but not as well as he wished it would.)

Cyrene dramatically lounges on the hammock—one leg folded, cover-up skirt tastefully parted, and sipping on a can of maple iced tea. At the display, Piso playfully pokes Livia's arm and says, "Look at her. She's showing off again."

"Nope!" Cyrene says. "It's called relaxing."

"Right, right," Piso says, wholly unconvinced. "Uh, good luck on the hunt for a girlfriend."

Piso and Livia decide to dive in the water, rushing to the sea (*first one on the water gets free lunch*, Livia said) and kicking the sand behind them, leaving Cyrene and Phainon behind. Phainon watches on as Piso trips over nothing and Livia sticks her tongue out and calls him a loser.

Beach visits aren't all that special to the four of them; the sea has always been one of their spots, and they've spent years being scolded for spending most of their summers playing in the water. *What if you drown, they'll take videos before they help you, don't run off without telling us*—all usual scoldings accompanied by a pinch to the ear. Now, there's no one to scold them—and while that was the dream when they were children, it does feel a little empty when there's no *'I told you so'*s as Phainon tends to his sunburns.

Phainon lounges on the towel laid out beside Cyrene, resting under the shade of a tree. “You’re not going to find a cute girl if all you do is lie down and look mysterious.”

“Phainon, I’ll be honest with you,” she says, like she’s ever been dishonest with him, “you’re the *last person* I’ll take love advice from.”

Phainon is about to scoff when a shadow looms over him. At first, he thinks it might be Livia with her usual demands to make space for her, but he notices the shadow being a little *too* large, and Livia is a tiny thing that can be thrown around by a too-strong gust of wind in winter.

He looks up. Mydei is standing behind him, a small bag slung over his shoulder.

“Winter came early,” Phainon comments, raking his gaze over Mydei, donning a fully buttoned Penaconian shirt patterned with flowers and leaves and a matching pair of boardwalk shorts. Mydei is damn near fully covered, much to Phainon’s disappointment—which makes no sense, because he shouldn’t be disappointed that Mydei isn’t a nudist.

“I’m appropriately dressed,” says Mydei, raising a hand to wave back to Cyrene. He chooses to sit beside Phainon, their shoulders brushing.

Conversation, surprisingly, comes easily, even with Mydei present. Chatter fills the air—Phainon talks about the customer who confessed to stealing a car only four shots in, how he had to clean up a disaster of a yard recently, how a translation app failed to cooperate with a tourist’s accent and only transcribed utter nonsense when Phainon attempted to help them. Cyrene groans about a recent customer who came in with three rowdy children who only calmed down when she put on a kids’ show on the TV, having no luck in her love life, how her salon’s rent is rising. And Mydei—

“I think I’d like to put up a restaurant here,” he says.

Cyrene and Phainon exchange a look. Then, they laugh at the same time. Phainon begins, “It’s not the best place—”

“You’ll bleed more money than you’ll make, seriously…”

“—to start a business. Besides, when summer goes, the population dips—”

“…I mean, a lot of the businesses in here come and go.”

“—and you’ll only have like, eight hundred people to make money off of.”

Mydei says, deadpan, “It was just a thought. Nothing final. But I’ll take note.”

Livia approaches, hair dripping with saltwater and still breathless from both running and laughing. Her brows raise at the sight of the stranger, and she gestures towards Mydei—

“Who is this?” Piso asks sharply, eyes narrowed in suspicion, as he takes his place next to Livia.

Cyrene chirps as she hands the two their drinks, “This is Mydeimos! Phainon’s…”

“…friend,” Mydei finishes, and Phainon can’t help but frown. “I’m his friend.”

“Okay,” Piso nods before he takes a sip of his drink, slow and measured.

“Please, forgive him, he’s just like that,” Livia amends. “I’m Livia, and this one over here is Piso.”

“My kids,” Phainon fills in teasingly, ignoring the way his gut churns at the dreaded F word. *Friends?* He supposes they *are* friends, but the way Mydei says it, so sharp and final and damn nearly cutting—it feels like an insult.

“No way,” Piso grunts, then looks at Mydei. “Don’t listen to him.”

“I try not to,” Mydei says. “But he’s too talkative, so it’s quite hard to phase him out.”

Phainon's eyes widen, and he backs away, all theatrical and exaggerated. "Me? Too talkative? I thought you liked listening to me?"

Mydei stops. Then, too sincere for his own good, "I do. It was a joke."

"Oh, I see how it is," Livia hums. Phainon is tempted to ask her what she thinks *it* is—and how come she misses every sign that a certain boy sends her way, but is magically able to read the enigma that is Mydei?

"Where are we going for lunch?" Piso asks, poking Phainon's shoulder and effectively changing the topic. *Thank Janus for guiding this young man to another path.* He whispers, "Let's go somewhere cheap; *she's* going to purposely pick expensive dishes for me to buy."

Livia exclaims from Cyrene's side, "Hey, don't get any funny ideas about suggesting a place with a terrible menu!"

"I would never do that to you!" Piso calls back, then ducks back down to talk to Phainon in a low tone, "Okay, now we *actually* have to go to a place that serves slop."

"Sacrificing all of us just to get back at Livia? A new low, even for you," Phainon shakes his head in mock disapproval. "Hey, a tip: bullying your crush is not the way to go."

"I don't like her that way," Piso hisses, face turning red. "I don't bully her, and you are the last person I'll come to for relationship advice."

"That is the *second* time that someone has said that to me today."

"Maybe you should reflect on what that says about you," Mydei interjects.

Piso gestures to Mydei and nods. "See, your friend here has some sense."

Phainon can't believe it. Piso is taking the side of the outsider he claims to dislike. *I don't like tourists,* where?

He turns his head to give Mydei a playful glare, but stops when his eyes land on the sketchbook on Mydei's lap and the pencil leaving vague lines

on the paper. His teasing is replaced with a question. “What are you drawing?”

Mydei says, “The sea.”

Right. The *sea.* Phainon quietly watches Mydei work, tracing every line that soon turns into the shore, the waves, the sky. It’s like magic, the way everything just suddenly forms and takes shape with just a few strokes.

“Do you mind?” Mydei mumbles in the little space they share. “You’re breathing down my neck.”

“Sorry,” Phainon whispers back, not really meaning it. “Are you bothered?”

“Quite.”

He laughs, because Mydei does not make a move to put some distance between them. So, he repeats half-heartedly, “Sorry.” And, just to be safe, “Push me away if I’m too much.”

Mydei doesn’t. He continues to draw, defining his work. He would occasionally glance up, look into the horizon, then he’d look back down at his sketchbook. The picture gets clearer, slowly but surely. And though Mydei is talented, undeniably so, Phainon’s attention is better captured by that hooked nose, trailing down to soft lips that he has barely touched. Phainon leans closer to Mydei, contemplating resting his chin on Mydei’s shoulder—

“Hey!” Cyrene waves a hand, sunglasses off and cover-up skirt off. “Last one to the water is on lunch delivering duty!”

Phainon looks at Mydei. They lock eyes. They’re both unmoving for a second, then they both stand up, quickly shedding their shirts. Phainon’s ribs start to hurt from laughing at how ridiculously fast Mydei’s hands work on the buttons, so eager to escape the heavy burden of walking under the sun and carrying everyone’s takeout boxes. Then, that laugh turns into something akin to a choke when he gets a good look at those lines of muscle again and—

Mydei takes off, sprinting after a giggling Cyrene.

Livia snorts as she takes over the hammock, “Sucks to suck.” (The comment is pointedly ignored.)

A strong breeze passes, and Phainon squints his eyes as sand flies. He’s prepared to make a run for it, too, catch up to Mydei—

Then, that abandoned sketchbook catches his attention. He glances down briefly to meet his own eyes. There, on the paper, is his face, frozen in a mischievous smile. The lines are messy, but they’re *there*.

(*Helps me remember the moment for longer,* Mydei’s voice echoes in his head. He wonders, is his smile so worth remembering?)

Dinner comes early, all five of them squeezed into a narrow table at a local eatery. A part of Phainon, against his will, is ashamed. This is not the luxury Mydei is used to, he’s sure; not the fine dining that he must be accustomed to, not the comfortable seats he’s looking for. The ceiling fan rotates swiftly overhead, but does little to relieve them of the heat still clinging to the air. It’s made even worse with every shoulder touching, thigh brushing, and elbow bumping.

But the entire night, Mydei seems to fit right in. A small smile plays at his lips when Livia takes over the table, talking about her dreams of being a fashion designer. He nods with every detail Piso shares about his days working part-time for a gasoline station. He huffs lightly when Cyrene makes a joke. And—

“The food here’s good,” Mydei says, his words quietly shared in the small space between him and Phainon. No comment about how hot it is, how there’s hardly any space, how the forks are bent ever so slightly. None of the judgment Phainon expected.

Mydei hauls all of them home when the clock is at half past eight—not in the two-seater, but on the MPV. Livia is first to go, her home the farthest

from the beach, and her phone filled with missed calls from her mother. Next is Piso, his home just a street away from Livia's.

Next stop: Cyrene and Phainon's home. Cyrene practically bolts the moment Mydei stops the car, talking about catching her favorite show on time, even though Phainon knows that she *doesn't* have cable.

Phainon's hand goes to the handle, ready to bid farewell and then push his luck with yet another attempt at getting a goodbye kiss, when Mydei says, "May I come in?"

A slow turn of his head, surprise taking over Phainon's features. His mind scrambles and sputters like an old engine, torn between working properly and simply exploding. He says, "Oh. Sure?"

Perhaps Phainon's tone erred on the side of unwilling—Mydei says, "No, on second thought—"

"No!" he says, then winces when he realizes the sheer volume of his voice. He tries again, quieter, calmer, less desperate, "I mean, no. It's fine!"

The car is parked on Phainon's freshly tended lawn. A grimace is restrained, but the pain is quickly forgotten the moment Mydei steps across the threshold and into his home once more.

Mydei's first comment is, "The living room's clean now."

Phainon hazards a glance at the area, as if Mydei would disappear if he looked away for a second. "I don't like keeping my space unorganized."

"Say that to the mail pile," a gesture to the kitchen table, still hosting envelopes upon envelopes of bills. "Or are they an exception?"

"An exception," he good-naturedly returns.

Mydei stands in the middle of the living area, and Phainon instantly forgets all his lessons on how to be a good host. He, too, stands stupidly in place, taken by his own thoughts and the sight of Mydei in his home. *He's here, he's here, he's* here—

“Oh,” Mydei says when he runs his fingers through his hair. Phainon suddenly envies those fingers and wishes to replace that touch. “I’m trailing sand into the place.”

Just a statement—not an apology, but Phainon takes it as such. He grins as brightly as he can, distracting Mydei from the fact that his mind is racing, “It’s alright! I mean, I’m doing it too. We both went to the beach, ha-ha…”

Silence, yet again. Mydei looks out of place yet at home all at once, and Phainon feels just the slightest bit uneasy. He’s hosted many before—hookups, dates, and friends. He’s well-versed with the pleasantries, the smiles, the usual procedure. But his head is all muddled up, replaying the scene from yesterday over and over and over—

“May I use your shower?” Mydei asks, like Phainon could ever refuse him. Of course, that’s what Mydei is there for. A *shower*, because Phainon’s home is closer, more convenient, and so he can drive back home fresh. It’s absolutely not because he wants to bang Phainon, obviously.

“Sure, you can go first,” Phainon says, gesturing for Mydei to follow him deeper into the house. They stop before a white plastic door, and Phainon asks, “You have a change of clothes with you?”

“Yeah,” Mydei lifts his bag. “I got it.”

Mydei steps in, and the door closes. Phainon breathes out in… relief? Disappointment? He’s not sure. He’s lost when it comes to Mydei. He thinks Mydei is attractive, thinks the dry humor can be rather amusing, thinks he is an honest man despite the attempts to hide what he thinks. Something about him invites mischief in Phainon, too—not the mischief that’s performed to make a date giggle, but the mischief he’s long thought to have grown out of. A childish impulse that makes him want to keep poking and poking until Mydei does… well, *anything*.

Mydei reemerges in twenty or so minutes, distinctly smelling like Phainon. A part of Phainon is dissatisfied; he longs for that summery scent from Mydei. Another part is nearly giddy; Mydei smells like *him*. However, there’s not much time to dwell on the scent and settle on what he truly feels

when he gets a good look at a freshly-showered Mydei, his strawberry blond hair not in its usual fluffy state, wearing a dark tank top, and what might be the world's tiniest shorts.

"Um," he begins, because he just can't help himself. "Wow."

He's not humored this time. Mydei simply says, "Spare me."

Phainon is abruptly pushed into his own bathroom by none other than his guest.

For a good, long while, he stares at himself in the mirror. Hands on the sink, leaning forward, staring hard into his reflection. He thinks back to that drawing—

(A smile, immortalized in pen strokes. *His* smile.)

—and shakes his head, trying to clear his mind of Mydei. *Cool* and *casual,* he reminds himself. A summer fling, as Mydei's father not-so-eloquently put it. Why is he thinking so hard about this? He's never had problems with these types of arrangements. He's never had trouble rolling out of a stranger's bed, kissing a person he hardly knows. Is it the money that's throwing him off? No, it can't be; even before he knew Mydei's name, he had thought Mydei was the most attractive man he's ever laid eyes on. What is it, exactly, that's with Mydei, making Phainon feel like he's slowly going insane? The pretty face? The sharp tongue?

He does not know how long he spends in the shower, deliberating under the water. His mind spins back to the Sacrament Courtyard, rerunning the film again. He remembers the brief kiss, the way Mydei looked before they closed the distance, the caress of the wind when it's all done. Only when his fingers start to prune up does he realize how long he's wasted in the shower, and he's sure that Mydei must have gone already.

To his delight and agony, the source of his turmoil still sits on the living room couch. Mydei looks up from his phone and *freezes*.

"You're still here."

“No, actually, I’m already home,” Mydei says to be sarcastic, but Phainon’s heart starts singing ballads at the foolish prospect of Mydei calling *this* his home, too. The sarcasm’s effectiveness greatly diminishes with the way Mydei’s eyes burn right into Phainon’s bare chest.

Phainon swallows. Like an amateur still stumbling through a performance, he finds himself unsure of what to do. He could be bold, ask Mydei to get more comfortable in a place far cozier than the couch, but he has a feeling that Mydei would flinch from it, maybe find it distasteful. A slow crawl towards what they both *clearly* want—because Phainon isn’t so stupid as to think that Mydei’s staring means nothing—would be far more appreciated.

So he offers, “Let me get dressed, then let’s watch something?”

Mydei nods. “Sounds good.”

The current hurdle: they are *three* movies in, and nothing—absolutely *nothing*—is happening.

Phainon thinks himself a forward man. He boldly makes the first step to approach those who interest him. He has no problem arranging dates on the fly. Yet, here he is, an arm slung around Mydei, doing *nothing*. There have been attempts to move forward—

(“Can I take off my shirt?” Phainon asked as he lifted his top with a cheeky grin. “It’s a little hot. You don’t mind, right?”

“Do what you want,” Mydei said.)

And times Mydei’s touch grew a little bold—

(“I’m sorry,” Mydei blankly said when his hand landed on Phainon’s thigh instead of the popcorn bowl, and let it slide higher up. “I missed.”

“It’s fine,” Phainon waved off as if his dick did not just twitch in interest.)

But no fruit for the harvest. There's no more popcorn bowl to miss, nothing more to take off with the excuse of the heat. Phainon is being considerate, letting the inexperienced one dictate the pace they're going, but damn it if it is not torturous. He's topless, and Mydei is right next to him in shorts that are almost obscene. What are they doing?

"Watching a movie," Mydei suddenly says.

"Huh?"

"You asked what we were doing," he replies.

"Oh." So he had spoken aloud.

The movie plays on. The lead is running through explosions and dodging every bullet flying. Something else explodes in the background, and the scene turns slo-mo, suit jacket dramatically moving as the lead hops away from the disaster. It's a good movie, but definitely not one Phainon would put on if he's trying to get frisky. However, Mydei picked it, so—

"You said we were friends," Mydei speaks again, "yesterday, on the courtyard."

Oh. Did he? Phainon's recollection fails him, all memories of *yesterday* in his head being reduced to just the kiss.

"You were bothered by that?" Phainon can't help but laugh.

His laugh only serves to make Mydei more agitated, the frown on those pretty features only getting more defined. "I wasn't bothered. I just kept it in mind. Reminded myself that's where I stood."

"Mydei," Phainon pats Mydei's shoulder, then begins to gently rub. "We're alone. In my house. And I'm half-naked. Do we look like we're friends?"

"Maybe you have a weird definition for the word 'friend.'"

"Maybe you do, too," Phainon replies. "You called us friends, too."

“Because you called us friends.”

It’s Phainon’s fault, really; he hadn’t been as direct as he should’ve been. So he shifts, blocking Mydei’s line of sight, caging Mydei on the couch. Then, he leans forward, whispering, “I haven’t been able to stop thinking of kissing you all day.”

A beat of silence. And, “Then, kiss me.”

Phainon has seen many faces before his eyes flutter shut, has kissed many mouths. But he thinks the view is one of the best ones he’s ever had—Mydei, eyes half-lidded, lips parted ever so slightly, seemingly waiting for him to lean forward. And as much as he wants to take the sight in for a few seconds more, he can’t resist. He meets Mydei in a kiss.

He pulls away soon after, face twisting in… *what?* Is it disappointment? He isn’t sure, but there is a heavy feeling that’s akin to *that* when he feels Mydei’s unresponsive lips against his. Did he make the wrong move? Come off too strong? Too—

Mydei puts an end to the tornado of thoughts rotating in Phainon’s head, hands coming to cup Phainon’s cheek instead and pulling him into another kiss. This time, he *moves*. All tongue and teeth like he has the need to *consume*. Phainon is shocked by the intensity of Mydei’s desire, but can’t help but let out a groan.

Then—an unwanted thought. This is not the work of an inexperienced man. This is not someone who has been deprived of the so-called essential romantic companionship all his twenty-one years. Phainon would’ve been happy getting a terrible kiss and laughing it off and watching Mydei flush in embarrassment and—he feels Mydei pulling him closer—teach him how to do it right. But the fact is that he doesn’t need Phainon’s help.

He’s being a hypocrite, he realizes. He’s kissed many, probably far more than Mydei has. Yet, here he is, stomach twisting at the idea that he’s not the *only one* Mydei has. A heavy feeling settles in his chest at his selfishness. Mydei isn’t meant to be his—not once, not ever. How come the

idea of Mydei having kissed—and possibly touched—others before makes him ill?

The one who pulls away this time is Mydei. *Want* wars with *concern*, face scrunched up as he eyes Phainon. He asks, “What’s wrong?”

Phainon tries to laugh. It comes out bitter. “Didn’t expect it to be that good.”

“*Haikas,*” Mydei says that word again. “What, are you thinking of how many I’ve kissed before?”

Right on the money. “No. That’s—”

Mydei interrupts him. “You are. You’re a terrible liar.”

(*A terrible liar,* Mydei calls him. If only he had any idea.)

“I’m with you right now,” Mydei says, squeezing Phainon’s chin with a hand. “Don’t think about the others. Think about me.”

Phainon doesn’t want to have this conversation. It’s the last thing he needs, really. So he does the obvious—he pulls Mydei into another kiss, effectively shutting him up. He bites at Mydei’s lip, pulling away just enough to give it a light tug, then he surges back in, pressing their mouths together.

He has no idea how long they spend their time like that, pressing Mydei’s back against his couch, kissing like they need each other. But soon, Mydei has to pull away for a breath, and Phainon feeds his greed by trailing his lips down Mydei’s neck.

Mydei shudders. His hands fly at Phainon’s hair, tugging on the locks, “Phainon…”

“Yes?”

“More.”

“More? *Here*—” Phainon moves his lips back to Mydei’s and whispers, “—or *here*?” He drags his hand down and between them, palming Mydei’s half-hard cock.

“There,” Mydei groans.

Phainon laughs breathlessly against Mydei’s mouth, “Hm? Where? You’re going to have to tell me.”

“*Fuck you,*” Mydei hisses. “You know where.”

“No,” Phainon innocently shoots back as he lets his hand slip under the waistband of Mydei’s bottoms. “I don’t know. I can’t read your mind.”

“You’re so—*ah…*”

The complaint dies when Phainon begins to move, stroking Mydei until he’s fully hard, feeling his cock get heavier. Mydei’s hips buck up, seeking more of Phainon’s touch. And, as though to return the favor, Mydei’s hands clumsily reach for Phainon’s shorts too, attempting to tug them down.

The words just slip, no thought behind them whatsoever, “Have you done this before?”

Mydei stiffens. He says, “Again? What’s it to you?”

“Just…” Phainon knows when he’s fucked up, and he sucks in a breath, attempting to make his tone sound casual and conversational despite their position. “…curious.”

“Don’t make me think of other people,” Mydei groans. “I’ll go soft.”

That easily, Phainon feels light again. “I’m the only one that gets you hard?”

Mydei doesn’t bother to dignify the words with a response. He pulls down Phainon’s shorts instead, leaving them around Phainon’s thighs. Phainon shifts from the awkward position they’re in, standing up and shucking off

the only clothes he has on, and tugging down Mydei's shorts right after, too. He's more careful with it, folding it neatly to the side.

"Really?" Mydei asks as Phainon sits down. "Folding it?"

Phainon guides Mydei to his lap. He echoes his words earlier, "I don't like keeping my space unorganized."

His comment earns a half-amused chuckle from Mydei. And he tries to laugh, too, but it's promptly cut short when Mydei takes hold of Phainon's cock, focusing his attention on the head, tracing a finger over the slit.

Phainon's hips stutter. "Wait."

Mydei stops, lifting his gaze. Though his face is barely illuminated by the shifting hues of the television light thanks to their position, Phainon thinks what little he sees is nothing short of pure *sin*—cheeks flushed, golden eyes peering through his lashes, lips wet and parted. Phainon carves this moment in his head, a memory to come back to when it's all over.

Then, he notices the impatience on Mydei's face. So he says, "Just… let me…"

A shaky sigh is garnered from Mydei when Phainon stops pumping his cock. To compensate, he doesn't waste any more time—he pulls Mydei forward by the hips, bringing their cocks together. He holds them together, relishes in the sight of Mydei's cock weeping with need.

"Phainon," Mydei says, his tone airy. "*Move*."

"Yes, boss."

He begins to stroke both of them, their combined precum making the slide easier. Phainon's gaze is set on Mydei. He watches intently, taking in *everything*—Mydei's eyes fluttering shut briefly, tongue swiping across lips, head tilting forward. He takes the opportunity to bring their lips together again. He savors the taste of the pleasure Mydei has chosen to share with him, savors every groan and sigh released right into his mouth.

“You’re so pretty,” Phainon says as he pulls away, breaths heavy with pleasure. “Mydei, you’re so, *so* pretty…”

A response comes in the form of Mydei’s cock twitching and his breath catching.

“You act like you don’t like the praise,” Phainon coos. “But look at that.”

“I didn’t say… I didn’t like it.”

“Don’t rewrite… *Ah*, don’t rewrite history. I remember you saying it.”

“You’re jerking us off, and you still won’t shut up…”

He laughs off the snark, pressing their lips together once more, *almost* chaste this time around. Phainon nudges his nose with Mydei’s and kisses him softly and slowly, like Mydei could break. He surprises himself with his own tenderness. Where had he pulled this—fondness and affection, just seeping through every inch of him—from?

Mydei’s desire starts to taste a little more like desperation, and he rolls his hips, fucking himself into Phainon’s hand. Clumsy. Eager. He pulls away from the kiss, looking down to watch them, taking in a deep breath. His hand joins Phainon’s, but their pace are mismatched—Mydei’s hand moves far faster, pushing them closer and closer to the end.

“Mydei…”

Yet again, their eyes meet. Mydei’s expression quickly changes, desire intensifying and—oh, it’s a heady feeling, knowing that just the sight of Phainon gets him going. And get him going it does, because Phainon feels Mydei’s hips tremble as warmth coats their hands.

“So quick,” Phainon teases lightly. *Carefully*, even.

Mydei gives Phainon a glare, though its usual sharpness has been dulled down by the satisfaction coloring his cheeks red. And, because Mydei never seems to be able to resist biting Phainon’s bait, he continues to move his hand even as he hisses from sensitivity.

“It’s okay,” Phainon says between stuttering breaths. “You don’t have to…”

His words fall on deaf ears; Mydei focuses his attention on Phainon, smearing his finish with every move of his hand. It’s messy, it’s sticky, and Mydei’s eyes are on Phainon, expectant and waiting. Intense in all the ways that Phainon likes.

(He stares into those eyes. He could drown in them, he thinks.)

He comes under Mydei’s touch, and his head tilts back as he groans. However, Mydei puts a hand to his hair, pulling him forward to press their mouths together in another kiss.

For one scary moment, Phainon realizes he might just be the world’s worst hired date. And on the next moment, he melts against Mydei’s lips.

Phainon takes a long walk the next morning.

No one in their right mind is awake at such early hours of summer; the streets are empty, almost dead. He looks back on the old times when Aedes Elysiae was still a sleepy town without the busy construction sites for inns, when the only things standing tall at a distance were windmills, not commercial buildings.

Times change, he knows. *Things* change. In an ever-changing world, *that* is the only constant.

But change happens slowly, does it not? It took some time before Cyrene grew into the dresses Audata gifted her. It took some time before Livia shifted her focus from doodling on the margins of her notebooks to sewing full ensemble pieces. It took some time before Piso’s crafts turned from small toy boxes to sheds.

Logically, Phainon’s self-admitted aversion to anything serious involving romance should slowly melt away. It should not crack at the sight of the first attractive man he meets. It should not break at the sight of a smile. It should not shatter into a million pieces with a single kiss.

Phainon was praised for his bright mind in his youth. Yes, he was mischievous—spending more hours carving wooden blocks to make his own figures than actually studying—but he had an answer for every time he was picked in class to answer a question. It was this same brightness that led him to leave Aedes Elysiae and continue his studies at the Grove. It was this same brightness that earned him his precious diplomas.

This brightness fails him now as he watches the sky turn yellow and gold with the rising sun and thinks of Mydei's eyes.

Phainon is watering the flowers—Cyrene's flowers, that is—when Piso appears unannounced.

(Livia and Piso appearing in their homes unannounced is nothing new; the two have done that since they were children, knocking at the windows with toys in their hands. Years do not wash away old habits.)

"What's up?"

Piso hesitates, mouth open, but no words to offer. His fingers idly pick at his nails—a habit he's been scolded for many times. The skin around his nails is raw and red, punished by whatever thought has been invading his mind.

Then—"Livia's leaving."

Leaving. Phainon hasn't heard of such news. But, he thinks back to *twenty thousand*, the word overdue in bold. Worry quickly wells up. Could they be in the same boat as he is? Livia only has her mother to provide for her; Pythias is a teacher, not the most well-paying job there is.

Piso continues, "She's going to the Grove. She got accepted with a full-ride scholarship."

Phainon's eyes widen. "That's amazing news!" A pause, brows furrowing. "…Or not? Why do you look like that?"

“Auntie Pythias let it slip when we were talking,” Piso grumbles. “Livia didn’t tell me, even though she’s already known for months now.”

“Oh.” Phainon has had to act as the mediator for years, the bridge between the two. Quarrels were frequent, most especially when they were mere kids, and spats were a battle of pride. He falls into his role naturally, even now when the fights have lessened and have been reduced to competitions of who can dish out the best sarcasm. “I’m sure she had… reasons. Maybe she wanted to keep it a surprise?”

“No,” Piso replies. “She said she purposely didn’t tell me because she thought I’d be unhappy.”

You are *unhappy,* Phainon wants to point out. He can guess the reasons why, but in the end, that’s all it is—a guess. He wants to hear from Piso directly, know what it is that makes this worse, finally put a name to it—

“But she said she also *wanted* me to be unhappy for her,” Piso says, and the words come out bitter. “She said she wanted me to be sad that she’s leaving. But then she says she didn’t want me to make ‘that’ face—*ugh!* What does that even mean? She’s so confusing…”

“Well… you do seem pretty bummed out about—” he abruptly stops, then amends, “I mean, are you?”

“*Yes,*” the answer comes, loud and clear and heavy and probably the last thing Piso wanted to say. “I know I’ll miss her. But I’m happy, too. Because she’s happy and I know she’s wanted this for so long and she’s worked so hard and I…”

For a while, Phainon doesn’t say a thing. There’s only the whistling of the wind, the sprinkling of water against the leaves, the heavy silence between the two.

Finally, Piso says, “I just wish… People would stop hiding things from me because they think I can’t take it.”

An emergency debriefing is called a quarter past three.

Phainon ventures over all the way to Cyrene's salon, walks past rows of women relaxed on chairs as they get their hair cut or curled or dyed. He passes through the counter, slides into the employees' area in the back. After being reassured that Cyrene has no one to attend to—that her client is late to the appointment and probably doing a no-text no-show—he finds himself seated on a tiny stool, looking up at Cyrene as she sits on a *regular* chair.

"Cyrene," Phainon says over his glass of iced water. "I'm fucked."

Cyrene giggles, still ignorant of the depth of the shithole Phainon has dug himself in. She props her elbow on the armrest, leans her chin on her hand, asks in a sing-song tone, "Who was the guest of the night?"

"Mydei."

(It's terrible, how just saying Mydei's name makes Phainon feel like he's going to *die*. It sounds sweet on his lips. *Too* sweet. He wonders if this is why he's taken to shielding himself with evasion of commitment; he knows he'd be a victim of his heart, and the moment he lets down his guard, it'll *fall*.)

A pause, then, "Well, I figured it was him, but I thought you'd have a lot more to say than just his name. Like, tell me the details of what you two did together…"

"No, Cyrene, I don't mean it like that," he shakes his head. He places his glass on the floor, sits up straight. "I'm fucked. Like, actually."

Her eyes narrow. She follows suit, sitting up straight. "Something went wrong?"

"Sort of," he says at first. And then he amends, "*Yes*."

Cyrene's features curl into something scary—at least, as scary as she can manage with her soft countenance. "Do we have a car we need to deface?"

A fond laugh leaves him, endeared by the display of Cyrene's protectiveness. Phainon has always been the one who fights for Cyrene, ready to confront those who take advantage of her kindness. Perhaps she's decided it's her turn, though the only thing Phainon needs protection from is *himself*.

"No, it's not like that." He finishes his water, giving Cyrene a moment before he drops the bomb. "I think I overdid it with Mydei and started to actually like him."

Silence. Phainon expects Cyrene to blow up, stand up, place her hands on her head, pace around the room with theatrics, lamenting his stupidity—

"Okay?" Cyrene replies. "And?"

Phainon gives her a look. He repeats again, for good measure, "I actually like him."

"Okay…?" Cyrene repeats as well. "So what went wrong?"

Phainon can't believe it. He explains to Cyrene like she's five, "So, Cyrene, if you forgot already, I was hired to go on dates with Mydei. I like him. *That's* what's wrong."

Cyrene looks to the side, as if peering into an invisible camera. Then, she looks at Phainon again, tilting her head curiously. "Ah? Are you trying to say that you figured it out just now?"

"I didn't just figure *it*–" he makes air quotes. "–out just now. I started *feeling* it just now."

"Oh, Phainon."

"What?"

(The thing about Cyrene is that she notices things about him that he never does, just as he notices things about her that she never does. They read each other like books in a language only they know, a shared secret between *best of friends* since *forever*.)

“You’ve had a crush on him since… I think, the first time you two met.”

Incredulous, Phainon blinks at Cyrene. And when he recovers, he says, “I’m twenty-nine, not twelve. I do not get *crushes*.”

Cyrene must be in the mood to be cryptic; she sips her honey iced tea and says simply, “If only you’ve seen how you look at him…”

Phainon spends his entire shift not quite there; every flirtation thrown his way by a half-drunk patron flies over his head, his hands move on autopilot for every order, and he makes it a good distance on the way home before remembering he has a bike still parked at the back of the bar.

He pedals hard, like he’s running from something. And in a way, *he is*. He’s running from something new and so painfully real and unneeded. The last thing he needed this summer was to—oh, Kephale, he felt sick just thinking of the word—*fall*. But, in a way, he thinks he had it coming.

It’s a *cruel* punishment; karma for all whom he had avoided with a cool smile, all whom he had moved past easily. For all the dates he charmed and kissed and flinched back from when they got too close. A taste of his own medicine from a man who’ll come and go with the seasons—*literally*.

(Worse—the pit in his stomach grows, guilt gnawing at him with every passing second. *Honest Phainon from here on out,* he said, offering his heart with one hand while the other keeps constructing more of *whatever-they-have* on a lie.)

Phainon nearly runs his bike into a traffic barricade. He doesn’t, but if he did, he thinks it’d be deserved.

Saturday night only brings more chaos to Phainon’s already-messy life. A fight occurred earlier in the night, *and* a customer hurled the contents of their stomach right by Phainon’s shoes. His mood soured by the third hour, and by the time he was free from his shift, he was tired and ready to collapse into his bed, uniform and all.

So naturally, he runs into Mydei right outside the bar.

Phainon pinches the bridge of his nose, then rubs his eyes. Exhaustion bleeds through his words when he says, “Oh, Mydei. You’re here.”

“Cyrene told me you had a terrible day,” Mydei says. “Rather, *night*.”

Right. He texted Cyrene about the absolute shitshow that was his night. He didn’t know that Cyrene had Mydei’s number, nor did he expect that his messages would be forwarded to Mydei. So he answers, “Huh. And?”

Mydei gives him a sympathetic look, but it’s gone as quickly as it was there. He replies, “I’ll take you home.”

“No, it’s alright. I have a bike.”

“I know. You told me. You can put it–” he gestures to the MPV. “–in the back. There’s plenty of space.”

As much as Phainon wants to argue that he can handle himself, that he can bike home just fine, Mydei is already *here*, standing expectantly with a stance that says he won’t take *no* for an answer. And so, Phainon loads up his bike on the back (with minimal assistance from Mydei, at least) and ignores the pit in his stomach that only further *grows*.

The drive home is quiet. Almost deadly quiet. Mydei doesn’t put on music to fill the air with the absence of Phainon’s chatter.

Phainon feels ill. *Truly ill.* Whether it’s from exhaustion or guilt or both or something else altogether, he doesn’t know; his mind moves slowly. Sluggish. Torpid. Something sour and acidic forms at his throat, and he realizes, belatedly, that his illness isn’t simply mental. He puts a hand to his mouth swiftly before he ruins anything in the interiors.

Mydei hazards a glance, looking away from the dark roads. “Something wrong?”

His answer comes in the form of him fumbling for the window button, hurriedly rolling it down. Mydei stops the car as Phainon lethargically tilts

his head towards the open window, watching as Phainon breathes in the fresh air.

“Phainon,” Mydei says, concern heavy in each syllable. “Is everything alright?”

(*Nothing is alright*, he wants to say. He’s a liar and he thinks he’s in love and he’s tired and he still smells faintly of puke. But he’s his mother’s son and—)

“Sorry,” Phainon says, trying not to retch when he opens his mouth. “I’m fine. Just needed some fresh air.”

Mydei makes a sound of acknowledgement and, thankfully, doesn’t push to interrogate. He simply continues driving, speeding up slightly.

They roll up to Phainon’s house, and Phainon has to exert an exorbitant amount of effort just to get out of the car, his own hands uncooperative. Mydei occupies himself with unloading the bike with a persistence that Phainon doesn’t have the energy to refuse.

Mydei drags the bike over, stopping beside Phainon. For a moment, they simply stand under the fluorescent street lights, quiet. Not the comfortable type of quiet, not to Phainon; had he felt a little better, he would rush to shatter the silence.

“Phainon,” Mydei says, like the mere sound of that name on his lips doesn’t make Phainon’s heart skip. It’s soft, familiar, and Phainon painfully thinks that he wants to hear it from Mydei over and over again. “Do you need me to call Cyrene over?”

“I’m fine,” Phainon repeats, because he’s not a child who needs to be cradled and coddled. Not by Cyrene, not by Mydei. And besides, he *already* said he’s fine; why is Mydei pushing further?

“You’re lying again,” Mydei frowns, displeased.

Deceit—Phainon is intimately familiar with it. He's gone through years convincing himself he's doing well when all he's doing is sticking to comfortable habits that do nothing but bring him down. He's smiled at customers who test his patience. He hides his true thoughts even when he's asked for his honesty, because white lies taste better than his bitter truth. And, at times, he lies so much that he thinks he's losing sight of himself—who was that bright, dreamy boy who shares his name and face? Phainon is sweet, kind, easy to trust, and everything that sounds too good to be true. And—Phainon knows this well—when something sounds too good to be true, it's because it *is*.

The bile in his throat rises, gets only more rancid. He opens his mouth—

"I was paid," Phainon admits, a new form of vomit. (He convinces himself it's better to say it now than wait and build more of *this* on the shaky foundations of a lie until it inevitably collapses.) "Your mother and father, they… they paid me to go out with you."

Mydei's face changes; first, it was confusion. And then—

Disbelief. Mydei stares at Phainon. "What?"

"Please, don't make me repeat it," Phainon says, because he thinks he will truly hurl if he has to say it again. There's a desperation to his tone, a plea, an attempt at softening the strike that will inevitably come.

"You fucking *knew*," Mydei says, equal parts angry and hurt, dropping Phainon's bike. "I told you and I tr—"

Mydei cuts himself off. The word *trust* hangs off his tongue, but refuses to fall. He sucks in a breath through his teeth, continuing harshly, "What, stuck through so you can get paid extra for having sex with me?"

"It's not… That wasn't a part of the deal," The wrong thing to say, he realizes as fury slowly takes over the hurt on Mydei's face. "It was—"

"Don't!" Mydei interrupts. "I don't want to hear it."

Phainon aches to reach for Mydei, hold his hand, tell him it was *real*, that—at some point—he started blurring the lines between *pretend* and *the truth*. And the truth was that his chest constricts at the idea of Mydei with others, that he aches to hear his name from Mydei's lips, that he wants and wants and *wants* so much that it feels frightening.

(Phainon is many things. Tonight, he's a *coward*.)

Mydei goes to the driver's side of the car, walking past Phainon. He spits, mockery dripping in every letter, "Enjoy your pay."

And then, he's gone.

Chapter 3: more than three words

Chapter Summary

> Honest, from here on out.

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for the delay! Thesis and internship combo is killing me. “Mimi, what happened to the chapter count?” I say nothing and simply rub my epilogue-shaped belly
>
> As I have cast the previous chapter’s beta into Amphoreus’ eternal loop, this chapter is not beta-read, so forgive any and all mistakes, please…

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Summer is not summer without shaved ice, sticky and humid heat, and Phainon’s friends by his side. And his friends are not his friends without the smiles, the perfectly-timed jokes, and the high-fives after a successful teasing.

It’s in this afternoon, sitting by the docks, that he finds out summer isn’t *summer*, and his friends aren’t *his friends*. Not quite, not today. And it probably won’t feel like summer for a long while, not when someone is intent on avoiding them. Cyrene is busy with work, but she still makes time for this quick getaway. The same can’t be said about Piso—missing, leaving texts on delivered, and calls outside his door unanswered. It’s his father, Galba, who answers in his stead, looking every bit disgruntled as he poorly lies about his son being *busy*.

(“If he needs some time,” Livia said, pleading with Galba with the same eyes she used back in her childhood to beg for an extra ten minutes of play time. “That’s fine. Just tell him I want to talk, please?”)

Cyrene's shaved ice is halfway melted when she says, "Everyone is quiet today."

Not really, Phainon wants to say. It's as lively as ever. There are people taking their jet skis out for a spin, some children laughing and chasing each other on the shores, the sound of music playing from a loud radio of someone lounging on the sand. It's as noisy as it always has been in summer—but Phainon knows that when Cyrene says *everyone*, the words *that matters* go unsaid right after.

Livia digs at her ice with the plastic spoon a little harder. "That guy's not here, so I guess that makes sense. He's the loudmouth, after all."

Phainon knows that tone well. *He's mad at me,* Livia intends to say. But it comes out all wrong, too sharp and too antagonistic. The bait is tossed in the water, but no one comes to bite. And so, a heavy type of silence blankets the three of them—the last thing they need in an already-hot day, tensions high and ready to snap at any moment.

"Why didn't you tell him that you got accepted?" Phainon decides to ask, straight to the point, as they watch the waves come and go.

A scornful sort of laugh comes from Livia, a sound not often heard from her. They're far more accustomed to hearing stomach-splitting, borderline-painful, and unashamed laughter from one another. *This* falls completely out of place, like a puzzle piece forced on the wrong spot. "He'll have a lot to say about it. But he won't tell me any of it, and he'll complain to the two of you instead."

It sounds like half-truths, an attempt at hiding the core of the rot; Cyrene looks over at Phainon, and they silently come to an agreement, in sync as always. *Get it out of her system.*

"Hm? What did you expect him to say?" Cyrene asks.

A pause to mull over her thoughts. And then, Livia replies, "I don't know. But he always has something to say about the things I do, so I figured he'd have something to say about this, too. And even with his… his stupid habits

and saying that his blunt words are just honesty, he doesn't tell me anything that's on his mind. We're friends, but he keeps hiding things from me."

The fondness somehow seeping through the bitter words is not lost on Phainon. He knows that before anything else, before glances turned into discreet staring, before sarcasm softened into teasing, before something innocent might've bloomed into *more*, they were—and still are—*friends*, and that fact isn't something so easily forgotten even in the midst of a spat.

"You hid something from him, too, though," Cyrene sighs. "The more secrets you keep, the more he'll keep from you, too."

"Hah! He deserved that much from me," Livia retorts with spite. "He's the one who started keeping secrets from me first. See how he likes to be treated the way he treats others. He can stay mad for all I care."

Whether the sharp words are a show to convince Livia herself or him and Cyrene, he doesn't know. But he has a *feeling*, and he comments, "So, the pleading with Uncle earlier… What was that about?"

A glare is thrown his way, yet another rare thing from Livia. She compensates for the absence of a certain ill-natured man when she says, "And your boyfriend? Where is he to pick you up after you've been moping around all day? It's been a few days since he last showed up."

That quickly, the guns are turned to point at him. Cyrene leans forward from where she's sitting, peering at Phainon with a curious look. It's dangerous and, honestly, the *last* thing they need. Phainon's troubles are the least of their concerns, especially when Livia is leaving for the Grove soon and Piso is ignoring them.

"Mydei *isn't* and *never was* my boyfriend," flies from Phainon's lips before he can even think of the words. "And I'm not moping around."

A knowing look from Livia, then, "I didn't say a name."

"Who else would you be talking about?"

“Right,” Livia says, mimicking his voice. “Because who else would it be, if not *Mydei?*”

Her words nearly *sting*. Phainon resists the urge to retort with something equally sharp, just to be petty; he’s the adult in the situation, he reminds himself. No need to sink down to her level, especially when she’s upset. He’s not so immature that he’ll try to get even.

Instead of answering, he shoves a spoonful of half-melted shaved ice into his mouth—ignoring how his teeth scream with sensitivity—in hopes that it’ll remove the foul taste of longing that Mydei’s name leaves on his tongue.

Routine is a simple, ten-step dance:

One, Phainon will open his door to a quiet home. Some nights, he’ll see Cyrene’s windows illuminated, and he’ll call her over. Some nights, he’ll see Cyrene’s windows completely dark, her home empty.

Two, Phainon will place his keys on a small ceramic plate that he bought in Dolos, back when he was out on a trip with friends. Originally a souvenir for his parents, now all his to use.

Three, Phainon will drag himself to the shower. He’ll try his best not to waste too much time staring at the wall in contemplation of whether he’s really *happy* here or if he’s just *comfortable*, because he would not want the water bill to increase.

Four, Phainon will pass by his parents’ old room with its doors still closed. He’ll leave it frozen in time because, inside, he’s still a child who remembers being scolded for rummaging through their room when he grew bored. He’ll go straight to his room and put on fresh clothing.

Five, Phainon will prepare dinner for himself. He’ll follow the same motions he watched his mother do, follow recipes that a younger version of him would proudly declare as the *real* family treasures.

Six, Phainon will sit down for a meal. Alone at some nights, with company at some nights. But in every night, it'll be him that will wash his father's beloved porcelains, plates once treasured behind a glass display.

Seven, Phainon will brush his teeth and stare at his reflection. Sometimes, he'll see his mother staring back at him. Sometimes, it'll be his father staring back. He'll wonder who he resembles more as he spits out toothpaste, and he'll kill that thought before grief threatens to swallow him whole.

Eight, Phainon will spend some time browsing through Jadeslist on his newly obtained laptop. Then, he'll peer into the lives of his old friends in Okhema through pictures and posts on his feed until he feels queasy.

Nine, Phainon will go to bed. Some nights, he'll simply stare up at his ceiling, gaze at the little remnants of tack from peeled-off glow-in-the-dark stars. Some nights, he'll stare at his phone and waste more time than he should.

Ten, Phainon will fall asleep—quiet, still, alone.

That night, Phainon dreams well.

He dreams of being nineteen again, air distinctly smelling like freshly-cooked venison. His mother is to his right, rubbing his back and smiling wistfully. His father is to his left, holding back tears. And Phainon? He's laughing hard enough that his sides hurt.

In that bubble of memory, he's still their so-called baby. He's ready to leave for college, not for forever—though his parents make it seem like he's going to be gone for their entire life.

He takes his mother's hand, he offers his father a smile. He swears to them: he'll be back before they know it. And he promises that when he comes back, he'll drag them right out of Aedes Elysiae and all the way to Okhema so that his father's camera can capture new sceneries, so that his mother can meet his friends. Hieronymus clicks his tongue in admonishment and tells

him to think of his studies before he thinks of what comes after. *One step at a time*, he says. Audata laughs and gives Phainon's hand a squeeze.

When Phainon wakes, the silence does not bother him. He doesn't glance towards closed doors. He doesn't think that *home* feels more like a *hollow shell* without his parents. He's outgrown the grief that used to wrap around him. Time *heals*, and he knows he's had more than enough time.

Phainon goes through the motions as best as he can, his normal life coming back.

A flirty patron winks at him and slides a napkin with their number on it. He offers a polite smile in return before his bolder, much more blunt coworker spits out something about *work hours* and *knowing the difference between customer service and being interested*.

Livia and Cyrene come over to his place like they always do, lounging comfortably and trading stories until they get tired. Every visit no longer feels like it'll be the last. He spouts jokes easily, knowing their base is secure. They try to pretend the lack of a sharp, snarky voice does not bother them.

Someone answers his three-week-old post, asking him to save their garden. He finds a friend in the gray-haired woman with the two strange roommates—a cheery, pink-haired woman who apparently thinks you can never have too much fertilizer, and a quiet, black-haired man who tortures their plants with the water hose. After he pulls out weeds and trims rotten leaves, he tells them that you should *not* pretend your plants are a flock of pigeons waiting for bread crumbs, nor blast your plants with enough water to fill a kiddie pool (trade secrets, really). And with him finishing a glass of lemonade, he pockets his pay and offers a friendly wave goodbye, not expecting to see them once summer is over.

Aedes Elysiae, after all, turns back into the sleepy town it once was when the days get shorter. Everyone eventually has to go back to their normal lives, and keep the sight of eight pm sunsets and the sparkling sea in their

memory. For tourists, the time to move on just so happens to be autumn. For Phainon, it starts in the middle of summer.

Phainon pushes open the door to a home that is truly *his*. The so-called mail pile has been cleared out and shoved into a garbage bag. There are no dishes waiting in the sink. His books are all neatly tucked in the shelves.

It's quiet. Peaceful. Normal. There's no letter threatening to take his home away, no knocks on his door about a debt waiting to be paid. It's the life he knew and lived for *years*. Only that, this time, there's no more computer with a display that has given him ninety percent loading screens and ten percent *actual* webpages, the poor thing having been sent to retirement after Phainon's pay came in.

(*Enjoy your pay,* a voice echoes in his head, cold and spiteful. At the same time, a voice that Phainon has been searching for, yearning to hear for *days*. If this cruelty is all the voice can spit out, he'll take it kindly and in stride—better to have *this* than nothing at all.)

He should be happy. He should be relieved. He should be many things—*anything* but uneasy. Like a child itching to move, bored during their summer vacation. It's a familiar feeling; it's what he felt back in Okhema as he spent his days chasing interview schedules, job fairs, and every time-waster. There's a buzz under his skin that tells him he needs to do *something*. Anything at all, just to work that restless energy off, because if there's anything Phainon hates, it's having nothing to do and feeling useless.

Relief doesn't come from browsing online for a new gig; his fingers linger over the slightly peeled-off command and letter Z key, seemingly looking for a new thing to destroy further. The solution isn't to rearrange his living room, either; straying from how his father decided to arrange the table and seats felt *wrong*. The answer doesn't seem to be cleaning out his closet, too; spring had whisked out the very few clothes he was willing to part with.

When he's exhausted his options, he decides to go for a run. And when circling the same four streets proves insufficient, he makes the foolish

decision to extend his run past the usual, familiar scenery, feeling the ground beneath him change from uneven dirt paths with dried grass shying at the edges to concrete sidewalks. The view changes from rows of colorful homes sitting with dried lawns to tall towers of silver and glass windows. Unaware—or *uncaring*, that works too—tourists block the path, moving at a painfully slow pace and taking up most of the space. He runs past a woman who's stationary in the middle of the sidewalk to rummage through her bag, past a man with a crew of people holding a phone and a reflector, past a couple holding hands but walking a foot apart.

He runs and *runs* until his breath feels too sharp for his lungs and until his legs ache. It feels like *atonement*, even if the one whose forgiveness he wishes to earn does not see. It's the principle, perhaps; he's hurt someone, so he must hurt himself in return. Then, he stops, realizing his thoughts drift back to the one person he should keep out of his mind now that everything is said and done.

Phainon tries to steady his breath as his pace starts to slow. The run works to remove all the unease, replacing it with exhaustion. So he makes a move to turn around, go back home—

And Phainon's world *stops*. Because a few feet away is Mydei, walking out of a gym with headphones on and his gaze lowered to his phone. He crosses the short distance to the opposite side of the street, approaching that gaudy car of his. He doesn't see Phainon, not yet—but he probably *will*, if Phainon stays there like an idiot.

Speak of the devil, and he shall appear. The day Phainon happens to go past his usual jog route, he sees Mydei. Why not, right? It's not like Aedes Elysiae is large enough to avoid such an encounter. It's not like it's bad enough that the mere thought of Mydei makes Phainon feel like his body is turning inside out, ready to spill everything hidden within—he has to *see* Mydei, too.

There's only one option: to turn away and *run*. Forget the fact that this other route is longer, more exhausting, and more polluted with city-typical smoke —*this* route is without Mydei, without all the unpleasant weight of guilt

within, without the strange elation of seeing the man that his heart has taken a liking to. Less confusing, more manageable.

Coward, his mind jeers, singing the same song from *that night*. Unable to say sorry, unable to face the consequences. *An overgrown child.* But he doesn't let the jeering slow his pace, and he doesn't look back. He ignores the way the unease comes back, stronger this time around.

(Unease, or guilt? He doesn't know. But what he does know is that a part of him wishes Mydei—no, *Mydeimos*, because they're not so familiar anymore—had done more than just look at him that night. Wishes that Mydeimos had hurt him back. Wishes that Mydeimos threw at least a single punch. Something that leaves a mark—a *real* ache to feel, not just a phantom weight in his chest.)

"What's the Grove like?" Livia asks over the movie dialogue, and then hurriedly follows up with, "And don't tell me stuff I've already seen online. I mean, what is it like, really?"

He laughs, "I'm not sure about the other faculties, but it's a battlefield from where I came from. Attendance is mandatory for most classes, and every class is half a lecture and half a graded recitation. The exam season is even worse, and you'll be wrestling people for seats and sockets in the library."

"Is this you trying to stop me from leaving?"

"Me? Stop you?" he points to himself in mock bewilderment. "You asked for the truth. I gave it to you. You know I could never stop you from achieving your dreams. And no one could. Not even your mother, even if she ever tried to keep you home by grabbing onto your leg and stopping you from walking out the door."

It manages to pull a laugh from Livia, too; it sounds real and light, a change from her mood for the past few days. It makes Phainon laugh too—relief with a mix of pride, knowing that he managed to lift her spirits. And he adds, "At least, the aftermath of the exam season is something to look

forward to. You'll finally be able to drink to your heart's content. No one's going to be there to stop you from ordering whatever you want."

Livia laughs even more, "And now, you're promoting drinking to me. Who are you, and what have you done to the Phainon I know?"

He raises his hands in surrender, "I'm being realistic. I know no amount of *'absolutely no getting drunk'* speeches can stop you. It's just not possible to be completely sober during the weekend after exams. Besides, there's nothing wrong with indulging a little, especially as a reward… or as a way to get your mind off of mess-ups."

"Did you go *indulging*, then?" she pointedly asks. "Or going beyond indulging?"

He opens his mouth wordlessly. It's a response in and of itself. Then, he says, "I'd like to pass up on answering that."

"Hah! Careful not to let mom hear you. She thinks you're a reliable adult and a great role model now."

"Oh, but I *am* a reliable adult and a great role model."

Livia fully collapses into a fit of giggles, leaning against his shoulder. Phainon would pretend to be offended, had this been any other day—but it *isn't*. It's one of Livia's last few days in Aedes Elysiae this summer. So he wraps an arm around Livia, squeezing her closer and ruffling her hair with the other hand. "We've got the next Aglaea in Aedes Elysiae," he marvels. "A scholarship to the Grove… All that hard work to build your portfolio finally paid off, huh?"

She peels herself from Phainon. She replies as she combs her hair with her fingers, taming it after his attack, "I still can't believe it either. Sometimes, I think they emailed the wrong person."

"Well, I think they have the right person. You're brilliant."

A shy smile curls on her lips, accompanied by a light flush. Still, she keeps up pretenses, “You’re laying it on thick. Do you have a favor to ask me?”

“You’re welcome,” he opts to reply. “And there’s no favor. I mean it. Every bit of it.”

He *really* looks at Livia now—one of his closest, dearest friends. A girl who used to tug on his sleeve and eagerly show him her latest artwork, eyes sparkling as she awaited praise. He watched her waddle over sidewalks with squeaky shoes, watched her cover her mouth every time she spoke when she lost her first teeth, watched her fascination for fashion grow each and every year, watched her grow into the woman she is now.

He knows her well enough to know the little quirks to her expression; he *doesn’t* pretend not to notice it, the way she looks scared and hopeful at the same time. And he remembers himself, excited and afraid of failure, taking the early morning bus out of Aedes Elysiae and into the city. He remembers the guilt with every night he spent out making friends, knowing now that his parents only had pretty lies to offer to him on the phone, reassuring him that they were okay when that was the furthest thing from the truth.

He decides he’s had enough of pretty lies, too. So, he lets himself be honest.

“I’m worried about you,” he admits, and he restrains laughter at the way Livia’s face shifts to show how offended she is. “And I don’t want to speak for the rest of us, but I think we all are worried about you.”

“I’m not a kid anymore,” she says, crossing her arms. “I can handle myself out there.”

“I know you can,” Phainon replies, unable to hide the affection in his tone. “But the funny thing about caring about someone is that you can’t stop yourself from worrying even if you know they can handle whatever is going on.”

“Maybe you should try listening to yourself for once,” says Livia, her tone a touch too serious. “You know we care about you, but you don’t allow us to worry about you at all.”

Phainon doesn’t make it a habit to stay up longer than necessary, but the allure of staring at his phone until he inevitably falls asleep is one he cannot resist as a modern, mortal man.

He catches up on his backlog of short videos that Cyrene and Livia have been sending him throughout the week. A video of a man dancing in a crocodile costume in an abandoned supermarket? What the hell, sure. A video of a dog befriending some birds? Cute. A video detailing how to deal with various garden pests? Bookmarked. An animated video of a snoozing orange chimera dragged out of bed by a mischievous white chimera? Somewhat unsettling, despite the lighthearted nature of the video. Something about the art just does not sit right within him.

He catches up fast, the list surprisingly thinner than usual. Idle yet again, he steers himself to a familiar hack-and-slash game, tapping on his screen to do his supposed dailies that he hasn’t attended to since the end of spring. His account is in a state of rot, his units getting outdated each and every day. Meta is ever-changing, and farming is brutal—especially when he’s not one of those people who can dedicate time to the events the game puts out every month. Sucks to be the most employed unemployed person in the world.

He’s halfway through his dailies when Cyrene messages him. The banner on top of his screen reads: *You feel like going out tomorrow night?*

He clicks the notification, redirecting him to his messages. He replies, *Where?*

You know where~ We are sooo overdue for some drinks…

Drinking? Are you trying to get me to spill the beans about Mydeimos?

There’s no hiding anything from you, Cyrene replies with an accompanying sticker of a cat hiding its face behind its paws. He laughs faintly and begins to type his response.

You can just ask me like you always do. I would tell you.

The typing bubble appears and disappears like it's performing a magic act, lingering for a few seconds before vanishing from view. Cyrene takes more than a minute to reply, and all she says is, *Suresies~ Wait for me after work!*

He acknowledges the message with a sticker of a dog nodding before swiping to the right to dismiss their chat. His contacts list comes into view, the latest messages appearing underneath their names in light gray. And because he's intent on punishing himself further via memories, he clicks on Mydeimos' name.

Their last messages consisted of him making a joke—a corny one, he'll admit—which only received a thumbs-up reaction from Mydeimos. He remembers typing it and then laughing, not at his own joke, but at the speed Mydeimos saw it and reacted; instantaneous, like he immediately opened it and was disgruntled at what Phainon had to offer.

He scrolls up. *Oh*. The messages from after *that night*. Never having made it a habit to check in once anyone's out his door, Phainon grimaces at the awkwardness with which he messaged Mydeimos—an attempt at playing a role he has never taken on before, no script to base his new act on. His *'how are you'* and *'get home safe'* sound insincere through text, and his clumsy efforts receive only a blunt *'I know how to drive'* in response.

He scrolls up further, and his finger sabotages him, ever so lightly grazing the call button next to Mydeimos' contact name.

He flinches at his own stupidity and—as if Zagreus was out to get him—his phone falls from his hold, bounces off his bed, and thumps down on the floor. He groans, "Oh, come on!"

In a mad scramble to get to his phone, he partially slides down his bed, and the top of his head meets the tiles of his room before he successfully snatches it as it rings a number he shouldn't be—

The call ended after being on the line for *two whole seconds*.

Phainon pulls himself back to his bed and sits up as he stupidly stares at his phone. It *rang*. It rang for a good few seconds, and it didn't go to voicemail.

The call went through, it was accepted, and then ended.

(Cyrene once exasperatedly told him that he was the most imaginative man she's ever known, capable of making up a world so far-fetched and detached from reality when he was taken over by worry or excitement. While it served to make their camp nights entertaining when they were children, it also served to feed either their deepest fears or build anticipation for something that essentially amounted to nothing. While he likes to think that those tendencies died the moment reality hit him full-force a good few years ago, it all comes back to him as his phone locks, leaving him in the darkness of his room.

Hope. Something dangerous to have.)

Despite everything, Phainon manages a laugh. He sinks back in bed, making a mess of his sheets in the process. The lightness in his chest feels *familiar*.

So the door was closed. Just… not locked.

It's a Sunday night when Phainon is ushered into the resto-bar by Cyrene, their usual spot for their one-on-ones, and he can't help but feel like a fool for having tainted its memory with a first date with a certain man. It was his and Cyrene's spot, not Mydeimos', yet his presence haunts the establishment like a ghost that only he can see.

It's the bar where he and Cyrene spent their nights drinking their woes away when things go *wrong* or celebrating their joys over a shot glass when things go *right*. The tables have been a victim of getting drummed on when Cyrene first got her work published in a magazine. The tables have also been stepped on when Phainon's drunken glee over getting accepted to the Grove led him to *almost* perform a strip show. The walls have heard of Cyrene's first long-term girlfriend breaking up with her to reunite with an old ex. The walls have also heard of Phainon missing Okhema but feeling as though it's turning away from him. They've stumbled through sidewalks, laughing all the way home when the other trips over air, trouble half-forgotten or joy doubled by the time they decide they've had enough.

(Tonight, however, he doubts both the guilt and the hope will die with their heads held under the liquor.)

He stares into the table for *Oronyx knows how long*, tracing the lines of the wood. Two seconds. For two precious seconds, Mydeimos answered. Was it a mistake? Mere force of habit to just accept a call? Whatever the case may be, it hardly matters. What does matter is this one thing: he wasn't blocked. Well, he might've ended up blocked after that mishap, but Phainon would rather not entertain that line of thought.

He looks up, and Cyrene slides a glass of Drifting Wind his way.

"Thanks," he smiles. He swirls the drink in the glass, watching as the blues and greens blend into a pretty turquoise.

She starts the interrogation immediately, sipping on her glass of Drowning Sweetness. He catches the sickeningly saccharine smell of her drink from across the table. "So… You and Mydeimos. What happened? Spare a detail, and I won't forgive you. *Ever*."

His smile turns thinner. It's instinctual, the need to maintain that pleasant smile—until he remembers this is *Cyrene*, and any attempt at falsities is unnecessary. She's seen him through the good, the bad, and the ugly, and she's there to stay. So his smile falls into something more melancholic.

"Last Saturday, when he picked me up from work, I told him that his parents hired me." A pause, then, "Needless to say… he wasn't happy to hear it."

Cyrene doesn't say anything. At least, not aloud. Her expression, on the other hand, says about a thousand different things at the same time. But years of experience in speaking Cyrene's language tells him, loud and clear: *I told you so*.

He takes the silence as an invitation to continue, but not before he takes a sip of his bitter drink. "He didn't beat me up, at least. He just… walked out. Drove away."

“You sound disappointed that he didn’t hit you. There’s—”

“*—a word for that*, I know,” Phainon laughs, but it sounds too heavy, too forced, too fake. Unpracticed. It grates his own ears. “I guess I hoped he would make it even. It would make me feel far less guilty. Just… a selfish desire to make me feel better.”

“Your selfish desire is to be punched by Mydeimos because it would make you feel better.”

Another laugh, and this time, it’s not false. “Don’t say it like that.”

Cyrene laughs too—sweet, genuine, and familiar. She playfully raises her brows, “At least he knows now, eh? That means you can give it a second try, but for real. No more secrets.”

“A *second* try?” he echoes, ignoring how *hope* flickers in his chest again. “Oh, no, *no*. That’s not happening. I’m not as thick-faced as you think I am, you know.”

(Hope is the opening act to a tragedy. And Phainon has had enough tragedies for about thirty million lives.)

“Do you still like him?”

“Yes,” he replies, and he *hates* how that answer comes so quickly. “I’m not so fickle that I’ll stop liking him in a snap. It’s not going to go away that easily.”

“Then, go get him,” she says, like it’s so simple. Like Phainon could just march up to Mydeimos and ask for his trust and his heart to go with it, too. Cyrene’s confidence in Phainon’s charm is a confidence that, in his opinion, is ill-founded. Does she not see how rough and gauche his so-called charm is compared to hers?

Just as Phainon’s about to protest, she adds, “We’ve had enough regrets over the years. Let’s not add another one.”

Regret—yet another thing Phainon is familiar with. He regrets wasting so much time in Okhema when he could've stolen a few moments more with his mother and father. He regrets taking for granted all that joy he was given, regrets not paying it back in full. He regrets not destroying the pedestal where they display 'Phainon' before it became too high.

(How funny it is that, *here*, he stands so high, seen as infallible and selfless and perfect and *all things good*. Yet, when he's next to Mydeimos, he's a flickering fire next to the sun.)

"We're in different worlds, Cyrene. He's way up there—" he points up with one hand, and then taps the table with the other. "—and I'm all the way here. He wouldn't be happy with me."

"I don't think you get to decide that for him."

He leans back against his chair, "Do you think he'd like some guy whose idea of a dinner date is not at a fine-dining restaurant, but at a local eatery?"

"He seemed to enjoy the food we had when we *did* eat at a local eatery."

"He was probably just being polite," Phainon sighs. *He's nice despite the resting frowning face,* he almost says, but manages to swallow the words before he throws them up. "But that's not the point. The point is, he could go out with some guy back home—or anywhere else—who can bring him to some… bougie place where the price of a glass of wine will make me weep. Someone on his level."

"Not everything is about money. And—" She takes a sip of her drink. "—He seemed to like you. A lot."

"Sure, not everything is about money," he acquiesces, but continues with, "But it started with money, and he'll keep thinking it's about money. If I try to fix things, he'll think I'm just trying to dig some gold."

She shakes her head, "It's simple! Just prove that you aren't."

He gives her a look, “Okay, thanks. And what do you suggest I do to prove my integrity?”

“Talking is a good start.”

At that, Phainon downs all the contents of his glass. Then, placing it down the table, leaving circles of condensation on the wood, he says, “Oh, I forgot that it’s that easy.”

Cyrene gives him a mischievous smile before she proceeds to gulp down her drink in one go, too. She dabs at her lips with a handkerchief before saying, “Normally, drinking makes someone braver. Don’t tell me it gives you cold feet instead?”

“Hoh,” he huffs, rising to the challenge without intending to. “Are you calling me a coward?”

Only then does the night truly begin; Cyrene and Phainon take turns raising their hand, calling for their next drink. And when they both laugh about the next glasses being outside of their weekly budget, they downgrade to shitty beers. Still, when Cyrene’s there with him, even the most bitter of drinks turn into something *sweet*. Drinks are accompanied by stories after stories after *stories*—he talks about his first time kissing Mydeimos and liking it more than he probably should, and she talks about a woman with pretty mulberry eyes and a strange name.

And before they know it, he’s ready to cry over a picture of a dog that Cyrene showed him three minutes ago, while she’s bowing her head on the table and still giggling about a joke he cracked five minutes ago.

“Remember Snowy? He looked like Snowy…”

“Huh…?” Cyrene tries to peel herself from the table, nearly knocking over an empty bottle of beer in the process. He leans forward to help her up, holding her arm. Her face is red from all the laughing and—

She sits up straight, like she just swallowed a rod. He sputters wetly at the display, ready to laugh. But she peers behind him, and her eyes widen,

ready to pop out of their sockets. She bumps her elbow on the table when she leans forward, then she roughly and hastily tugs him closer by the shirt. She whispers, “Whatever you do, do *not* look behind you.”

Phainon sluggishly breaks away from her hold to turn in his seat, and he quickly regrets not taking Cyrene’s advice.

It feels almost like a bucket of cold water has been poured over him, chasing away the fog of drunkenness. Because there, a few feet away, is Mydeimos, looking as perfect as he usually does—with a man on his arm.

(It has been a week since he last saw Mydeimos. He remembers vividly how Mydeimos looked under the warm glow of the street lamp, face twisted in a mix of fury and betrayal. He remembers the sound of the brass bell as his bike falls to the ground. He remembers anticipating a strike, only to be left in a night too cold for summer.)

Disgust quickly fills Phainon, his brows drawing together as he spots the two lovebirds’ shoulders brushing. It’s sweet, it’s romantic, it’s *sickening*. It’s the last thing Phainon wants to see—and how strange it is to feel so sick over the sight, because *this* was the point, wasn’t it? Wasn’t it the goal for Phainon to be the springboard for Mydeimos’ love life, to give him a taste of the sweetness that is romance? He witnesses the fruit of the great experiment. Mydeimos—shut-in, anti-romantic, dry, terrible conversationalist Mydeimos—now seeks the warmth that Phainon once provided.

Phainon stares, a self-inflicted punishment. He watches as Mydeimos is led deeper into the bar by his date, watches as Mydeimos’ face twists into a familiar frown when the man whispers what might just be a terrible joke, watches as Mydeimos is beckoned to a chair. *Worse*—their eyes meet in that brief moment, both avidly aware of each other’s presence in this bar that suddenly seems too small, too suffocating.

He breaks away first, bringing his gaze back to Cyrene. Disbelief is all over his tone when he says, “He’s on a *date*.”

“I told you not to look,” Cyrene weakly says before covering her mouth, almost as if scandalized.

He watches as Cyrene’s eyes trail something—no, a *certain someone* behind him. Her expression sours with each passing second, and *oh*, he just can’t resist. He glances back again.

Mydeimos is already looking at him, face twisted with some unreadable expression. The lack of recognition makes Phainon’s stomach twist; Mydeimos’ expressions are always so telling, betraying his mouth’s attempts at dishonesty. Yet here he is, unable to decipher what it is exactly that Mydeimos wishes to say with his staring.

“Oh, Kephale,” he mumbles as he turns back to Cyrene, and she makes a noise in agreement with his crudely expressed sentiment. “He looked at me.”

She whispers, “*Still* looking at you. Do you want to leave?”

His answer comes out too desperate—closer to pleading than anything else. “No.”

Cyrene presses her lips together in a line. “Okay.”

Two bottles of beer are brought to their table. Cyrene tries to act normal, miming a regular night out with him as she discreetly whispers what Mydeimos and his date are doing. Two more bottles are brought over at Phainon’s request. Phainon tries to resist the urge to see for himself, to twist the knife a little more. He calls himself a fling because that’s what he is to Mydeimos, and that’s also what he wants to do to himself. Two shot glasses are brought over at Cyrene’s request. Cyrene laughs unnaturally at his attempt at a joke. Phainon stands up and excuses himself to the toilet, because he’s drunk enough to drown a ship.

It’s on the way back from successfully freeing up space for more drinks that he sees Mydeimos again. And yet again, Mydeimos’ pretty eyes are on him. He looks right back. How could he not? Something about those eyes draws him in, and why would he resist now? It’s *Mydeimos*. Gorgeous Mydeimos

with that head of strawberry blond hair and eyes of gold. Almost too pretty to exist—

“Watch it,” hisses the lucky bastard that gets to hold Mydeimos’ hand, colliding with Phainon when he turns around.

Unlike some people, Phainon was raised with proper manners by a loving family; an apology slips from his lips on instinct, albeit lacking sincerity. “I’m sorry.”

“You should be,” He eyes Phainon with distaste, his hold on two glasses of tangy Daiquiris tightening. Before Phainon can make a face at the display of attitude, he walks past, shoulder jostling against Phainon’s.

(Something about the man was irking. Was it the thick and nearly offensive scent of cherry and coriander around him? Was it the unpleasant personality seeping through every syllable spoken? Was it both? Or maybe something else, a feeling that Phainon doesn’t want to name just yet?)

Phainon’s fist flies faster than his mind runs. He pulls the man back with one hand before he sends the other hand colliding with the man’s face. Two glasses shatter on the floor.

Mister Looking Punchable is assisted by a nearby patron who whispers an *‘are you okay’* along the way. The concern is brushed off as he lunges for Phainon, and his punch clumsily connects with Phainon’s shoulder. Phainon stumbles back, but quickly sets himself right.

(Somewhere, he hears his name being yelled. Is that Cyrene’s voice? He’s not sure.)

He lifts another fist, but just as it’s about to hit the man again, arms wrap around his middle, feebly attempts to pull him back. “Ah, ah… That’s enough, Phainon! Stop, stop!” Cyrene tries for a cool and easy tone, her words muffled against his back. He feels her pull away slightly, turning her head to the side, “Help me, please?”

Cyrene's hold is slack, more like an embrace than anything else. And he loves Cyrene and tries to listen to her advice as much as he can—but tonight, he thinks he doesn't lend his ears to her words. Her attempts at pleading go in one ear and out the other.

Phainon breaks free from her, his fists still clenched. He rushes over to the man, throws another punch, and then another, and *another*—until he feels satisfied.

"Don't tilt your head back," is what Mydeimos says as Phainon presses a tissue to his nose.

It's the first words Mydeimos has to offer after a week of silence; Phainon has no choice but to listen. The drunken haze still clings, but Phainon's rationality is more or less back—at least, more present than it was earlier.

Phainon was hoisted off to Mydeimos' care and, for whatever reason, Mydeimos agreed to keep him company. Something about being the only one who can hold him back should he decide to go swinging again. It was Mydeimos who handed him a tissue after his nose was left bleeding from a lucky punch.

(It's a punch that Phainon returned in kind. And though there was a sense of victory in it for the briefest of moments, he remembers his father's half-worried, half-angry face when he once came home with a bruised face—and that was all it took for him to back away, giving up the fight.)

So here they are. Sitting on the curb, still waiting for Cyrene to emerge from the bar. He makes a note to come back the next day to apologize to Kyros. Then, to Cyrene, because Kephale knows that her forgiveness will take quite a bit of work after the stunt he tried to pull off. And with two apologies already tacked to his mental board, what's another one?

"I'm sorry," Phainon says, yet the word feels too light for the weight he wants it to carry. He wants to repeat it over and over until Mydeimos bends to his pleading, like a child begging for forgiveness after a transgression.

Mydeimos laughs coldly. “For what? For beating the shit out of my date?”

It’s a confirmation, and it’s one Phainon didn’t need to hear. The word echoes in Phainon’s head, bounces around like a ball. *Date*. They were on a date. Mydeimos went out with someone and allowed that someone to take him out on a *date* at a *bar*. Since when did Mydeimos like going to bars? Wasn’t he so averse to it, *glaring* when Phainon took him to one?

So Phainon can’t help but scoff, “Your date, huh…”

Mydeimos huffs right back. “What? Something wrong?”

“No,” Phainon replies, trying to be cool, like his head isn’t pounding and his heart isn’t ready to fall to the ground at the thought of Mydeimos going out with someone else. “No, no. He’s… alright. He’s okay. Just… okay.”

“*Okay?*” Mydeimos echoes, incredulous. “What, you think you’re better than him?”

Phainon laughs despite it all—because he is amused by the implication behind Mydeimos’ words, as strange as it is. He’s inviting rivalry, like some sort of princess who wants suitors falling at her feet and declaring their superiority over the other. And if that’s what Mydeimos wants, so be it. Denying Mydeimos is the last thing on his mind.

The words escape before Phainon can restrain them. “Yeah. I mean, I beat him, didn’t I? I’m better.”

(*He is.* That man walked out, cheek bruised, nose bleeding, and *furious* when Mydeimos went to Phainon, pulling him up when a strong shove sent him back. A side silently taken—Phainon knows victory lies not in who was left less battered, but in who gets to earn Mydeimos’ concern.)

Mydeimos’ lips part wordlessly for a beat, then, “You don’t have to sound so happy about it.”

No denial, no cutting retort about his ego—just familiar words. The first time he heard a similar sentiment from Mydeimos, the words were clumsily

hiding amusement beneath them. This time, there's no amusement. But there is something else. Something that Phainon wants to pry from Mydeimos' heart. That *something* sparks confidence in Phainon, lighting the cinder left by the liquor.

"No, don't pretend you didn't go out with him just to spite me," he says, pulling the tissue away from his nose. "Not after you spent the whole night staring at me instead of paying attention to your sorry excuse of a date to notice his terrible personality."

Mydeimos' expression twists, but there's not a single protest that leaves his lips. Strange—Phainon expected a defense on the ready, just waiting to slip. The fact that there isn't, that Mydeimos is caught off-guard and is rendered quiet, pleases a part of him.

That self-satisfaction fades into nothingness when the silence lingers. He quickly works to amend the mistake his unthinking mouth has made. "I mean… I *am* sorry. I'm sorry for hiding it from you."

"Hiding *what* from me?"

It's not like most of Mydeimos' questions—the ones where he pretends to be dense, just for the pleasure of hearing Phainon struggle to get the words of his entire flirtation out. It's not a jab at how ridiculous Phainon is. It feels too sharp.

(He hears those words again: *I've forgiven them*. Phainon wishes for Mydeimos to extend the same grace, even if every pinch of his fury is fury earned.)

"The…" he pauses, thinking of the right word to use. He decides then, "… arrangement that your parents and I had. I'm sorry I hid it from you."

Mydeimos' sarcasm returns full-force, "No, it's alright. The acting was almost convincing."

"It wasn't acting."

“You mean to tell me that the incessant flirting wasn’t acting? The pushy attempts to get me on a date with you? That it wasn’t because you were paid?”

“I didn’t even know who you were when I first approached you,” Phainon laughs, softer than he expected from himself. “But I did mean every praise, even after I knew. And I wasn’t just pretending to be happy that you were willing to go on another date with me.”

Mydeimos scoffs, half unconvinced and half disgusted. He turns his head away from Phainon as though he couldn’t even bear to look. A part of Phainon wants to hold his chin, tell him to look at the bleeding nose and bruised knuckles. Proudly declare that *this* is the least that Phainon could do to prove that it was *real*.

“You say that like I trust you.”

“I’ll do anything to convince you that it was real,” Phainon says, and it sounds scarily close to a promise. “It wasn’t just work.”

Mydeimos turns to look at him again. This time, Phainon catches a glimmer of something too similar to hope glinting in his eyes. That *hope* flickers in Mydeimos’ eyes under the warm street lights, and Phainon just wants to share everything he has to offer, just so Mydeimos understands. But he tells himself he should take it one step at a time. There’s no ticking clock, no home on a timer, so—

(One step forward—)

Mydeimos says, voice touched by betrayal, “It *was* work. You took the money.”

”I was going to lose my home without it. I *needed* it,” Phainon says. And, before he can stop himself— “Not everyone has Mommy and Daddy around to buy them their way through life.”

If the way Mydeimos’ expression twists in a mix of humiliation and fury is any indication, Phainon thinks he’s achieved nothing but feed that spite that

Mydeimos harbors.

The nights are shifting from *hot* to *warm*, summer slowly making way for fall—but Phainon thinks the distance between them makes the air feel crisp and cold like it's winter.

(—and two steps back.)

"I," Cyrene says, getting up from her garden stool, gloves covered with dirt, "am putting you on a liquor ban, Phainon. And I mean, *Okhema-seventy-years-ago-during-Prohibition* kind of liquor ban."

Phainon offers a feeble, apologetic smile as he says, "I don't plan on drinking anytime soon, so please, don't worry."

"And that's right!" she replies as she takes the plastic gloves off. "In fact, you shouldn't be drinking for the rest of your life!"

Phainon's apology takes two forms. The first form of his apology is an earnest *sorry*, and the second form is being roped into helping Cyrene with moving her jasmines and geraniums.

(He dares not protest when she huffs and hands him his gloves, telling him to get to work. Getting in a bar fight is the second-to-the-last item on the list of things he wants to do; the very last item on the list would be having to apologize and clean up after such a fight.)

Cyrene's fountain of patience flows endlessly for Phainon, though, because soon enough, they're sprawled on her couch, exhausted from gardening. Her head rests on his lap, and his hands busy themselves with her hair. He drags his fingers through smooth locks, rakes her bangs back. The fact that she doesn't glare up at him or slap his hand away proves that, *yes*, his apologies are accepted.

(Back then, their friendship was tested by whispers. Phainon was ten, Cyrene was twelve, and everything started to get weird; best friends turned into *not-so-friends*, and holding hands wasn't as innocent as people used to

view it. Growing up meant that it was no longer sweet for him to tug at her shirt before whispering gossip he overheard. Growing up meant that it was no longer cute for her to come knocking at his window late in the night, looking for company when her mother's promise of coming home early was broken yet again. *Best of friends* turned dirty, filled with speculation.

People were so sure that all the denial between the two of them would melt into the sweetness of romance, just as all friendships between girls and boys tend to do. It took years to dispel rumors; Phainon will never take the comfort of having her by his side for granted. He won't make such a mistake again.)

She looks at him, peering up from her phone. She's the same Cyrene he approached all those years ago, bright and pretty, just a little older and less of a tease. For a moment, he's struck by how the clock seems to reverse when Cyrene's with him—everything is so simple with her, and it almost feels like they're still children idling after class.

(She's a living, breathing piece of *home*. Home, fifteen years ago.)

She hums, "Pizza dinner party? I'll call those two over."

One successful call and three messages left on delivered later, *pizza dinner party* turns out to be a party for three held within Cyrene's home, complete with yet another debriefing. Phainon relives Sunday night with every word Cyrene says, and he internally sighs over her vivid storytelling painting too good of a picture of his foolishness.

"You're lucky Uncle Kyros likes you," Livia wrinkles her nose at Phainon's now-empty salad bowl. "Or he would've had you banned from the place."

"No, it's all thanks to Cyrene," he shakes his head, because the words lucky and Phainon simply don't belong together. "If it weren't for her, everything would've been much worse."

Cyrene beams, "Yes, it's all thanks to me! If it weren't for my pretty girl charms, he can say goodbye to Aedes Elysiae—no, Amphoreus' best fries!"

The conversation twists and turns like it always does; Livia talks about being mad at (read: *missing*) Piso, Cyrene talks about a pink-haired girl like her, and Phainon talks about anything but Mydeimos until he runs out of empty topics to recycle and until they've grown unamused at how he avoids the topic. There's no such thing as secrets when it comes to his friends, it seems.

"Do you *like* Mydei?" Livia says, comfortable and familiar in a way that makes Phainon want to frown. He wants to correct the name, but thinks better of it.

The question registers a second too late. It lingers in the air, unanswered, for a full second before he does end up frowning and leaning back against the carved wooden chair of Cyrene's kitchen. By then, the silence already works to answer the question for him—but he tries to speak over it, because he's not the type to let silence talk for him. "What's with the question?"

(Like and *like*—two different things. Because Livia knows Phainon will say he likes everyone, but finds it hard to say he *likes* someone.)

Livia takes on a pensive look. "You date a lot of people, so I want to be sure."

Cyrene has the decency not to laugh, but he does see her lips twitch in amusement before she turns away to get a pitcher of water.

Here, he pretends to be offended. Well, no—he *is* offended, because her observation almost sounds like an insult. He wonders then, when the truth started to be offensive to him. He places a hand over his heart and leans back when he says, "Calling me a playboy, Livia?"

"No," she shakes her head. "But you don't seem to actually like anyone you're going out with. It's like you're going out with them because you're too polite to say no or because…"

"*…because?*"

Livia pauses. Then, she decides saying, “I wasn’t born yesterday. You know what I mean.”

Phainon laughs, skeptical. “This is not a conversation I will have with *you*. Try again when you’re a little older.” Then, “You make it sound like I’m just using people or leading them on all the time.”

Livia takes a bite of her Penaconian pizza, savoring the pineapple chunk with a hum. She opts to say, “Mm, this is *so* good.”

When people talk about Phainon, they have many good things to say.

Phainon is *warm*. He has a smile that makes people let their guard down and a tongue that seems to know exactly what to say to soothe. No one’s intimidated by his presence; children love him, lost strangers gravitate towards him for directions, and people know to approach him for help. Phainon is the sun in spring.

Phainon is *charming*. He is the most wanted bachelor in town, mothers and aunties happy to steer their daughters and nieces his way. He’ll shake his head and refuse as politely as possible, but his refusal is taken as humility; no one believes him when he says their daughters and nieces sound *too good* for him. *Nonsense*, they’d say. *No one’s too good for a man like you. If anything*, you’re *too good for anyone*.

Phainon is *selfless*. He lends a helping hand even at the cost of himself. He helps out even the outsiders—the same people who drove half his friends away with every home torn down in exchange for a hefty sum of money.

People don’t know him at all. Maybe that’s a good thing; that way, his flaws are simply little secrets spoken between friends over a box of pizza and a bowl of greens.

Children in Aedes Elysiae learn the story of how Aquila’s cruelty brought long and scorching summers to their town. Oronyx was weakened for three months, defeated in their duel with the Eye of Twilight. When Oronyx

clawed their way out of their prison, they ended the merciless reign of Aquila, shortening the days once more.

Aedes Elysiae's annual festival is fast-approaching with every step towards autumn. It happens at the end of summer, when days feel shorter, the afternoons much cooler, and the waves a little rougher. It's the maker or breaker of many relationships—the time when so-called outsiders decide to either stay forever or leave the town as a mere summer destination.

Summer is leaving soon.

(*Mydeimos* is leaving soon.)

He looks at the bright side. At least, there'll be less trash by the sea. There'll be fewer people holding karaokes at three in the morning. Life will be quiet as usual.

…His life is quiet already, he thinks as he sits, keeping watch over a street. It's a quick gig—just controlling the boom gate for the three days people will spend decorating the street for the upcoming festival. Manage the traffic, make sure no big cars go in and destroy the bunting or run over ladders. It's *boring*. It *pays*. He spends hours of his day sitting down under the shade, and only standing up when he has to lift the arm of the barrier and let a car pass.

(His dream of being a museum curator rots in its grave as he brushes his bangs back, feeling sweat start to drip down his forehead.)

Day three rolls around—a cool Thursday that offers him reprieve from the afternoon-typical heat. He thinks of his must-dos to stave off the boredom that comes with sitting down by a barrier gate for six hours. He has to go shopping for lettuce and pepper. He has to clean his dishwashing rack. He has to—

A car rolls up, bright, flashy, and familiar in a way that sends Phainon's heart beating like a sledgehammer to his chest. The roof is folded, giving him a perfect view of a head of blond hair and a hand pressing down on the car horn.

Phainon doesn’t stand up, doesn’t lift the arm. He sits there, stupidly staring at the car—no, at its *driver*.

Mydeimos pulls his sunglasses up his head. He calls out in the flattest voice Phainon has ever heard, “Is this area closed?”

“Um,” he sputters and fumbles, the memory of Sunday night far too vivid in his head. “*Yes*.”

It isn’t. Somehow, his inability to say *no* to Mydeimos affects his logic, too. And on cue, in an intersecting road beyond the barrier, a car passes.

Mydeimos rests an arm on the window and looks at Phainon, unamused. “I don’t think so. Let me through.”

There’s a moment of silence between the two of them—Mydeimos looks at Phainon expectantly, and Phainon looks at Mydeimos with what he *hopes* is an expression that hides how his knees wish to meet the ground and how his hands want to clasp together in a display of *begging* for forgiveness. Composure and restraint is essential, after all; Mydeimos is an expert at it, seeing how he’s not tossing his sunglasses at Phainon’s head.

“Street decorations are undergoing,” Phainon decides to say. “You’ll have to go around.”

Mydeimos pinches his nose. Then, he does something that makes Phainon want to frown—he pulls out his wallet, and takes a few bills between his fingers. He extends his hand wordlessly.

It’s ridiculous. For a moment, Phainon wonders just how many hurdles Mydeimos has easily jumped over all thanks to his wallet. It makes Phainon laugh, but it sounds empty even to his ears. “I don’t want your money.”

The skepticism in Mydeimos’ face is as clear as day. When he speaks, his voice is low yet sharp, “You don’t? I was under the impression that you *needed* it.”

Phainon swallows down the bitterness. He takes the first step again, “I’m sorry.”

Mydeimos stops for a moment before sliding his sunglasses back down to his nose. He places his wallet back in his pocket before he says, “Not your fault that the road is closed.”

“No. I’m sorry for summer,” he says, like summer is already over. In a way, it feels like it already is. Mydeimos might as well take the entire season with him. “And I’m sorry for what I said Sunday night. I was just… I felt like it was the best way to express how lost I was. I know now that it wasn’t. I’m really sorry about that.”

His apology is wholly genuine, but unpracticed. There were no bathroom mirror rehearsals to make sure the words come out right, no pleading eyes presented in hopes that his charm will leave the offense forgotten. Just him —just *Phainon*, fumbling in the dark. Just him with his heart in one hand.

Mydeimos shakes his head. His voice comes out less sharp when he says, “No, I know the panic that comes with potentially losing a home. But stop feeding me more lies.”

Phainon has to protest, words flying out unprovoked, “But I wasn’t lying. I didn’t mean to make it seem like I’m just using you for money. I just wanted to come clean. I *did* enjoy being with you, going on dates with you, getting to know you. I liked when you call me out when I try to tease you. I loved every single date with you, even when you brought me to that café with the overpriced menu and you kept targeting me with your bumper car. And I liked listening to you when you finally moved past the one-word replies.”

(Unspoken, because it feels too heavy to say aloud: *you didn’t see the pedestal, you didn’t see me as someone* too good. *Thank you.*)

“Did my father offer you a bonus for grovelling afterwards?”

“This isn’t even grovelling,” Phainon laughs weakly. He doesn’t want Mydeimos to leave with a sour memory of summer, of a tainted memory of

Aedes Elysiae. He surprises himself with how easy the words come to him. “This is just me being honest. I mean everything I said. I’m sorry, Mydeimos.”

Mydeimos looks away from him. His car moves again, turning to the right. Phainon breathes out easier; he said his piece, it’s out in the open. Even if Mydeimos didn’t seem to believe it—

Before Mydeimos speeds off, he calls out, “You’ll have to try harder than that, if you want me to forgive you.”

(Unsaid, because pride is a stubborn, unmoving thing: *I’ll hear you out. Do your best. Win me.*)

“Do you think he’ll like it? Or should I make it more… flashy?” Phainon asks, his knee brushing against Cyrene’s as they watch the sun set in the distance.

“Mm? It’s *so* not like you to think this hard.”

“Thanks. I have to think hard,” he wryly says. “It’s *Mydeimos* we’re talking about here.”

Cyrene smiles. She simply says, “Just be yourself.”

The only thing Phainon is used to chasing is billing dues, but there is a first time for everything.

Phainon has never properly courted anyone before; people flock to him and he simply takes his pick. He’s inherited his mother’s beautiful snow-like hair and his father’s dazzling sapphire eyes, and such fortunes has gotten him far in the realm of not-quite-love.

Mydeimos stands outside his gate in his home clothes and with his hair haphazardly tied back. He looks utterly unprepared. Phainon finds that there

is something so charming about seeing Mydeimos wearing a shirt featuring a worn print of a cat.

“What… am I looking at?” Mydeimos asks, astounded.

Phainon gives his guitar a strum. “A serenade.”

“Yes, I can see that,” Mydeimos replies, then looks at Cyrene and Livia standing behind Phainon. “What I meant was, what are *they* doing here? Did you recruit them into your circus?”

“I need my bandmates to ensure a quality show for the VIP audience.” And it’s the truth. Phainon’s serenade would not be complete without Livia’s tambourine and Cyrene acting as the bouquet holder. He cashed in this favor by promising Livia that he will drag Piso out—Talanton can take Phainon if he doesn’t do good on that—and promising Cyrene that he will help her move furniture around to rearrange her kitchen. Never mind the fact that they’d all do this for one another without the favor trade; they enjoy the illusion that it’ll take a trade before they agree to do something so *‘incredibly silly.’*

Cyrene counts down, and Phainon watches as Mydeimos’ expression shifts from astonished to mildly horrified and embarrassed. And when Phainon begins to *sing*, Mydeimos closes his eyes and puts a hand to his forehead like he can’t bear to watch, but he doesn’t retreat into the safety of his home. Phainon counts it as yet another victory.

He sprinkles an apology between verses. And while he can’t see Livia’s expression, he can sense her starting to regret accepting the trade offer, her hesitance making the tambourine delay. Cyrene, on the other hand, keeps her upbeat attitude, bright like the sun with every sway to the beat.

The people going about their day in the upper-crust side of Aedes Elysiae slow their pace to gawk for a moment. Phainon overhears some surprised remarks about how *open* the province is to something *so progressive* and he wonders if they smell the poor off of him that it only takes a glance for tourists to recognize him as a local. He also overhears some dreamy

whispers from women passing by, giggling with their friends about how they want an admirer as shameless as *this*.

Once the song is over, Cyrene hands Phainon the bouquet, which is then promptly offered to Mydeimos. Roses, lilies, and tulips—a bouquet that the florist had recommended to him. *Apology flowers*, she called them.

The flowers are held under Mydeimos' scrutiny. He gives them a long, hard stare, and just as Phainon thinks he's about to slap them away harshly and give the performance a grade of zero like a harsh music teacher—he *takes it*. He takes it in his arms, and Phainon is momentarily stunned at the sight of Mydeimos holding the flowers close as though it's *precious*. He almost wants to take a picture of the scene, freeze it and frame it, come back to the memory later.

"Thanks," Mydeimos says, looking at… Cyrene and Livia? Phainon is ready to open his mouth and ask for Mydeimos' thoughts about the performance, if he's willing to give it another try, if—

Mydeimos retreats behind the gate. It shuts with a click, and Phainon stays to watch Mydeimos climb the stairs and disappear when he turns the corner.

Phainon manages to lure Piso out through an offering of a free late lunch and persistent knocking on his door.

He steels himself for the upcoming conversation, carefully picking each and every word he's about to say. It'd be no good to be as graceful as an unleashed dog in a glassware aisle; he'll have to tackle the conversation with the tact it requires, because Piso has made it abundantly clear that ignoring their group is something that comes easy. Phainon inwardly channels the eloquence that has won him many debates in college—

"I can't keep avoiding her forever," Piso says over a stick of barbecue, shattering the silence that Phainon was ready to swing a bat into.

"You can't keep avoiding *us* forever," Phainon corrects, offering a lighthearted nudge that hopefully hides the tiny grudge that bloomed over

the course of Piso's absence. "You're refusing to answer *everyone's* texts."

Piso's expression twists with guilt, but no apologies leave his lips. *Yet*. He says first, "I mean, you're all kind of a package deal."

"Still, there's no need to punish us for something Livia did, don't you think?"

With that, Piso breathes out, "Sorry." And then, he hastily adds, "I missed you all."

Phainon feels the grudge wither in his chest. "We missed you, too."

The words come out of Piso swiftly, like he can't help it, like Phainon was tugging it out his lips, "How is she?"

(*How is she*, he asks, like Livia is on her deathbed. Phainon *almost* snorts.)

"Upset," Phainon answers. "And also missing you. A lot. But she won't admit it."

"Mm…"

He finds himself not liking the look of triumph on Piso's face upon hearing the words. That boy might just take it as a sign that *avoidance* is an effective way of garnering affection. It *isn't*. Phainon can vouch for that. "If your goal was making her miserable," he says, "You succeeded."

Piso shakes his head, "That wasn't my goal. I just… needed some space to think."

"Mind sharing?"

For a second, Piso hesitates. Then, he seems to think, *what the hell*, and just decides to spill, "I *am* happy for her. I *really* am. She's smart and she worked so hard for all those projects and… I know a scholarship isn't easy to get. I want her to spend summer celebrating that. I'm just sad about her leaving and keeping it a secret until the very last minute. And I don't want to be selfish and make it all about me. "

Too late, Phainon wants to say. He says instead, “She’s been sulking a lot. Not really in a celebratory mood.”

“Can she stop thinking about me for a second?” *Can she stop breathing for an hour?* “I excused myself so she won’t have to spend days apologizing over every celebratory lunch and dinners with me ruining the mood.”

“Celebratory lunch and dinners aren’t *celebratory* without you.”

“And what’s left of the year won’t be *right* without Livia,” Piso replies. And he realizes his mistake, quickly backtracking, “I mean, it’s just that she’s always been—”

“We know,” Phainon says, saving Piso from the burden of having to perform a clumsy dance around the forbidden L-word. “We all know you’re into her.”

Piso groans and drops his stick of barbecue on his plate. He puts his head in his hands, seemingly devastated at having been *found out*. As if Cyrene and Phainon didn’t find out *before* Piso himself did. “Is it obvious?”

Painfully so. “A little.”

“Thanatos, take me now,” Piso mumbles. It’s only after a beat that his priorities kick in. “Does she know? Does she… like me back?”

It’s a ridiculous question. *Yes*, obviously. Does Piso genuinely not see the way Livia’s eyes seem to be unable to look away from him? Does he not notice how she finds a new excuse to touch him every single day? How can someone be so blind to so much affection?

“Only one way to find out.”

Piso frowns. But—

“Summer isn’t going to last forever,” Phainon warns, like both of them aren’t keenly aware of *this*. Like both of them are stupid and just letting the days pass them by. “Tell her what you feel before she leaves.”

Phainon returns to familiar silver gates with a new bouquet in hand. This time, budget was lowered (read: Cyrene's working, Livia's already preparing to pack, and Piso's helping Livia), so he only has himself as a so-called circus member this time around.

"Hi," he greets the intercom, expecting Mydeimos on the other side. "Come down, let's talk so I can beg properly?"

No answer comes. Phainon prepares himself, expecting Mydeimos to glare at him through the window in the third floor, but instead—

A moment passes, and Eurypon emerges from the gate. Phainon stiffens, rod materializing in his back.

Eurypon eyes him up and down, and then his eyes land on the *flowers*. Phainon is tempted to hide them behind his back.

"Did we not pay you the remaining half yet?" he asks, brows furrowing the same way Mydeimos' does.

Ah. Here it goes. "You have, um—" he pauses, trying to think of the proper way to refer to the parent of a man he wants to impress. "Sir."

Eurypon's brows might as well be superglued now. He echoes, voice dry, "Sir."

Phainon realizes, with horror, that while Mydeimos might take after his mother's beautiful features, his mannerisms are entirely his father's. A pretty face all scrunched up in a frown, an alluring voice as lively as the dead, a sweet mouth that—no, stop, it's not good to think about Mydeimos' mouth in front of his father.

He clears his throat and tries to explain, "I've been paid, yes. But I'm here to win Mydeimos over. *Properly*, with no external motivations."

"You're courting Mydeimos," Eurypon flatly says.

Phainon grimaces. He braces himself for what might be the worst grilling session of his life—with him as the meat about to be slowly burnt over the fire, of course—because overprotective, helicopter parents always want to know everything about their child, including the hired date that turned out to be real because he made the happy mistake of falling in love. And the scary part? He's ready to spout out the truth and not just what Eurypon wants to hear. He'll tell the truth, the *whole* truth, and if Eurypon decides to chew him out for it, then—

"Oh," Eurypon chokes, then places a hand on his face. He wipes his eyes and— oh, Kephale, is he… *crying?*

Phainon almost lowers the flowers. *Almost.* He doesn't want to damage them, so he keeps them cradled in his arms, and then takes a tentative step forward. He asks, cloddish, "What… Did I say something wrong?"

"Oh, finally," Eurypon says. "Mnestia hasn't forsaken my son. This is the first time I've ever seen a suitor in my entire life."

Is it truly so bleak? Is Mydeimos' love life so bleak that the sight of someone courting him sends his father to tears? Phainon highly doubts it. While he doesn't want to think of Mydeimos' mouth and what it does, he has to; a man who can kiss like *that* is not someone whose love life is hopeless.

Phainon manages an awkward laugh. "I'm glad to be the first." And, after a beat, "Is… is he here, though?"

It takes a moment before Eurypon calms down. And when he finally does, he gives Phainon a look that might be sympathetic. "Mydeimos is out with his mother."

"Oh," he looks down at the flowers. And then, "Ah, I'll just leave this for him, then. Please tell him it's from me."

(He nearly adds: *Be careful with it.*)

Eurypon nods sagely, "I will."

With that, Phainon hands the flowers to Eurypon with the same care one would have when passing a child between arms. The arrangement of flowers smiles at Phainon, and he can't help but wonder if Mydeimos would like the sight of them, too.

A text message comes late at night, his phone vibrating right when he's about to drift off to sleep. He expects it to be Cyrene with a well-timed and calculated joke a few minutes after seeing his lights turn off, sending him a link of an obscenely expensively priced regular product (a six thousand Balance Coins red plastic cup last week, a three thousand Balance Coins bubble wrap the week before that) and captioning it *'buy this.'* He nearly drops his phone on his face when he reads the name on the notification.

Don't talk to my father, Mydeimos says. *Don't kiss up to him.*

Phainon's mouth opens. He rubs the beginnings of drowsiness in his eyes before typing out his response: *There's only one person I want to ki*|

No, not that. Be serious. Mydeimos would like a frank answer, he thinks. *I didn't intentionally look for him, if that's what you think I did. He just so happens to be the person who answered the door when I came knocking earlier.*

Ok. Don't talk to him from now on. And don't kiss up to him again.

I've done no such thing.

You've given me a different impression. Don't talk to my parents ever again.

I won't, Phainon replies. And, he adds, *Did you like the flowers?*

Read. Phainon thinks it'll stay unanswered, but after a whole minute, Mydeimos reacts to the message with a thumbs up. Nothing more.

Fondness comes with the chuckle, and Phainon quickly learns that fondness is typical when it comes to matters involving Mydeimos.

The festivities bring noise along with it. Drum and lyre bands go on a parade, dancers fill the streets, and people gawk and watch before they're pulled into the celebration by overly-welcoming locals; the last hurrah of summer, of *liveliness*, before Aedes Elysiae goes back to being the quiet seaside province that it usually is.

The heart of the province acts as the heart of the festival, too. There, greased bamboo poles are waiting for climbers, ropes are ready for tug of war, and piñatas are hanging with treats. Excited chatter and drumbeats coalesce into one big song, every note a perfect soundtrack to summer. It's something that Phainon has been a witness to too many times, but it doesn't get any less special with every passing year.

This festival has become a melting pot of every culture, a taste of *everyone's* home; some tourists try their hand at running stalls, selling their local specialties and managing games they've brought from their hometown. And though Piso dislikes how the *outsiders* bring raised prices along with them, he seems more than happy to compete with Livia in scooping goldfish, a game brought all the way from Izumo.

"This is actually rigged," he grunts, looking at his ripped scooper and then at Livia's successful catch.

Livia sticks her tongue out at him. "No, you're just terrible."

Cyrene cleverly claims that Phainon has to join her in retrieving something she forgot at home, that she'll have to leave the two of them to it as she puts him to work—before giggling and whispering to Phainon the question of how he managed to lure Piso out.

"We had a conversation, man to man," Phainon jokes.

(If Cyrene gives him an unamused huff and a light swat, he absolutely deserves it.)

She drags Phainon to the other side of the square, jumping from one stall to another. As she finishes her quailed eggs covered in orange batter, she asks,

“So… That’s one out of two quarrelling couples reunited. How’s Mydeimos?”

Phainon sips his cup of silken tofu, sugar syrup, and sago pearls before replying, “He’s definitely softening up. I mean, the fact that he didn’t slam the gate in our faces is a good sign, right?”

“You’re optimistic,” she says. “I like it. What’s next on the game plan?”

“*This*,” he points down. “I’ll ask him to come to the final day of the festival. A *real* date.”

Now, Cyrene raises an eyebrow. “Huh, you’re sure he’ll say yes? But what if he says no?”

“Never plan for failure.”

“*That* is quite possibly the worst thing I’ve ever heard from you, and I’ve heard you sing with a sore throat.”

He raises one hand in a gesture of surrender and downs his treat in one go. He says, “I have good reason to believe he’ll say yes. He texted me the other night. And he says he liked the flowers.”

“He *said* it?”

“Well, he reacted with a positive emoji when I—hey, don’t laugh!”

Phainon chases Cyrene as she effortlessly weaves through the crowd, her laughter filling the air with song. He tries to touch her shoulder, but she remains just slightly out of reach, her talent of making the crowd part for her coming in far too handy. He’d say she’s playing dirty, but the protest comes out as a *laugh*.

(For a moment, he feels like the town is a little smaller, still fitting him perfectly. Summer may not look the same as it did ten years ago, but it still tastes like a sweet drink, sounds like drums and lyres, and feels like the *good ache* in his lungs when he laughs with each quick step.)

It’s later that evening when Phainon and Cyrene spot two certain friends walking around town hand in hand, fingers interlaced. Piso’s free hand carries bags of prizes. *Normal* Piso would groan and complain about it, but *lovestruck* Piso smiles tenderly at Livia like she hung the moon and the stars in the sky.

“Technically,” Phainon says, “I win. It’s almost fall.”

Cyrene gives him an unamused look. “Summer isn’t over yet, dummy. We both lost.”

Phainon finds the courage to text first, sitting down at the foot of his bed. *Are you free Friday?*

As soon as the text is sent, he locks his phone, places it on his bed face-down. He breathes in deeply, closes his eyes. Inner peace. Don’t panic. Don’t overthink. Don’t analyze your four-word text. Don’t—

His phone vibrates not even a minute later, and he cracks one eye open. He carefully picks up his phone to read: *Why?*

Summer festival this week. I want to celebrate it with you.

You’re very funny.

It’s not a joke! I’m serious. You can try coming outside your room and seeing for yourself.

I meant that your confidence in asking me out is very funny.

I’m happy I can entertain you.

Don’t be.

Phainon shakes his head. He swipes at his first message, adding a reply to it: *Are you?*

What if I am, but I don't want to come with you?

That's okay. Just tell me no, he says. He swiftly follows it up with: *But I think you want to come with me.*

?

A very simple reply from Mydeimos. Phainon huffs out a quiet laugh before replying, *You're talking to me.*

You're so cocky that you think everyone who talks to you wants you.

And yet you're still talking to me.

The typing bubble appears and disappears. Phainon counts yet another victory under his belt. Mydeimos takes a minute, and then another, before he replies—

I'll swing by the square after lunch. You'll see me if you do.

(As if Phainon's gaze could ever sweep past Mydeimos. As if Phainon wouldn't comb through a crowd just to find him.)

I'll see you, then.

Days move awfully slowly, sunny Wednesday sluggishly rolling into a cloudy Thursday. Every minute feels more like an hour, a crawl towards the end of summer that feels more like a dramatic, unnecessary slo-mo scene in a movie. It's the worst days of not-summer, the air all the more humid thanks to the clouds hanging above with the threat of rain.

Come Friday, the sky has grown dark, the air cooler. It spells gloom. The gloom sinks right into Phainon's chest, unfamiliar pre-date jitters coming to shake his being. It's a strange feeling; he's never been nervous for a date before yet, here he is, twenty-nine and shaking like a leaf in the wind as the clock ticks closer to *after-lunch*. Less like a man who's gone on more dates

than there are flowers in Cyrene's yard, more like a boy who’s still shoving letters under desks.

“I look fine, right?” Phainon asks, turning away from the mirror to look at Cyrene.

Cyrene looks up from her phone, eyes him up and down with an approving hum. “You look *more than* fine! What’s with the fuss?”

Phainon breathes in, gestures at his shirt. “I told you, I asked him out. I want to look perfect.”

“Oh, wow,” her brows raise, impressed. “He said yes?”

“I told you, he’ll say yes,” Phainon extends a hand, aiming to lean against the mirror. His hand doesn’t miss, but the mirror slides to the side, bringing him with it.

Once Cyrene manages to peel Phainon from the mirror and out of the house, they traipse through streets and into the square. The long walk doesn’t do wonders for Phainon’s nerves, doesn’t clear his head. Quite the contrary, in fact; each step feels like a step closer to a courtroom.

“If you were Mydeimos, where would you go first?” Cyrene asks, tugging on Phainon’s sleeve as she scans the stalls through the crowd—because four eyes are better than two. Phainon would argue otherwise as she’s nearly drowned out by the crowd thanks to her height, but commenting on her height might just earn him a pout.

“I’d go to… a stall where they serve Kremnoan food,” Phainon muses. It’s a shot in the dark, but one that Cyrene takes seriously nonetheless. She steers their way through the crowd, her hand curled around his arm. And then—

Phainon’s throat closes up. Because there, just a few feet away, is Mydeimos. Half of his bangs are braided back, held in place by a golden clip. His eyes are lined with red, making them look sharper and making the golds of his irises more prominent.

“Mm, maybe we should try somewhere else,” Cyrene says, peeking through shoulders as she stands on her tiptoes.

“No,” Phainon swallows dryly. “No, he’s right here.”

Somehow, as soon as Phainon says those words, Mydeimos finds him, too. They look at each other and—*oh,* Mydeimos tilts his head, sending an arrow right through Phainon’s chest. He looks down at Cyrene, but there’s only a dotted line outlining where she once was; she’s disappeared right under his nose, likely giggling with every step.

When he looks up, Mydeimos is already in front of him. Phainon’s heart joins the festive drums, echoing in his ears. He greets clumsily, “Oh, hi.”

Mydeimos simply nods in acknowledgement.

As far as dates go, this has to be one of Phainon’s worst attempts at starting one. They’re quiet in the middle of the buzz, too-tall and too-wide as people around them shuffle about and mumble *‘excuse me’*s and *‘pardon’*s. Mydeimos’ gaze is intense and, despite that, Phainon prefers *this*; he prefers this staring over the avoidant looks, the turned head like Mydeimos can’t bear to look at him.

He offers his hand yet again, just to test his luck for the day. “Let’s go somewhere less crowded?”

And yet again, Mydeimos doesn’t take his hand. He says, “Lead the way.”

(Phainon would say something about how more efficient it’d be if they held each other’s hand—that way, they won’t be separated—but he can already hear Mydeimos calling him *a child.*)

Phainon acts as a tour guide yet again, showing Mydeimos around the festival and telling him about local games. Mydeimos interrupts him every now and then to tell him that they play a variation of such games back home, just with a different name. Phainon whisks him from one food booth to another, where he earns free samples from friends’ stalls. He thinks he’s

had his fill of sweets from the previous days, but he remains polite and smiles nonetheless—

Mydeimos steals the treat from Phainon's hand, popping it right into his mouth. And after he swallows, he says to the one manning the booth, "It's delicious."

(He shrugs off the bewildered looks sent his way, uncaring in a way that Phainon never could be.)

It's when Phainon receives his fifteenth free sample of the day and they decide to steer clear from food booths that Mydeimos finally strikes up a conversation. "If you don't want it, you don't have to accept it."

"It'd be rude to refuse."

"It'd be far more rude to not properly savor food that they clearly worked hard to make," Mydeimos replies. "Learn to say no."

Phainon sits with that advice for a moment, lets it hang in the air before he waves it off with a laugh, "Alright. I will."

(*Easier said than done,* his mind says.)

They wander farther away from the crowds, away from the festivities. Here, it's easier to listen to Mydeimos—but he mourns losing the opportunity to lean closer under the guise of hearing better. But there's better privacy, at least.

"Sorry," Phainon says as they aimlessly walk around. "The weather around this time of the year is usually pretty good. The clouds want to participate in the festival, I guess."

Mydeimos sighs, dissatisfied. "I've heard *sorry* from you for the past few days more times than I care to count. Aren't you tired of saying it? I'm getting tired of hearing it."

Without thinking, Phainon says, "Sorry." And then, "I mean, I'm trying to apologize, so…"

“Do you think saying it over and over will make it any more convincing?”

Phainon stops. He asks, “You… don’t think I’m being sincere?”

“I don’t care for your apologies,” Mydeimos says. “Not anymore. I prefer to hear the reason why you took my parents’ offer.”

Oh. Straight to the point. Phainon breathes out slowly, as if to prepare himself. He starts, “Like I said, I was going to lose my home. Living here isn’t cheap. Not anymore. Well, not like it ever was cheap to be alive…”

Mydeimos raises a brow then vaguely waves with a hand, prompting him to continue.

Phainon quietly speaks, more vulnerable than he’d like to be, finally dismounting from that high horse called his pride, “I can’t bear to lose it. It’s the last of what I have of my parents. They worked hard to keep it. But ever since a lot of richer folks…” he gestures to Mydeimos. “…started moving in here, everything’s gotten a lot more expensive, you know? The high demand of *everything* here every summer drives the value up, too.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah. It’s already hard to keep up as it is. So you can imagine how terrible it is in the summer. And I don’t really have a regular, five-days-a-week job because I’m overqualified for everything because I made the fatal mistake of having a masters degree on a *history* of all things, so—” he inhales sharply. “—*yeah*. That’s the problem that made me sink low enough that I thought going on dates with you and getting paid for it was the solution.”

He expects a cynical laugh, a shake of head, a declaration that he’s ridiculous—but what he gets is a question: “History? What did you want to do after graduating?”

Phainon is surprised that Mydeimos wants to talk about *that*; his dreams took a backseat the moment he came back home. “I wanted to work at a museum as a curator. That was before I found out that you needed a PhD and connections, that it’s highly competitive, and that, if you *do* land a job

there, the money you spend out of your pocket to maintain the museum is more than the money you get from working. So, that's a bust."

"So money really is the problem."

It's not funny, but Phainon laughs still. "Since when was it *not* a problem? If I could, I'd go back in time and tell my younger self to pursue something more practical like… anything science. Maybe I wouldn't be stuck here if he was a little smarter."

"Yout want to leave?"

Phainon goes quiet at that. After a moment, he says, "No. Everything I need is right here."

"Not *everything*, clearly," Mydeimos pointedly says. "You can't possibly get the job you want if you stay here. There's no museums in Aedes Elysiae."

He snorts, "*Right*, you're a fresh graduate. I almost forgot about that. It's not that easy. Besides, I already made peace with the fact that I'll never get to work where I want. That's just the way the cookie crumbles. Besides, I think I've been enjoying cooking more lately…"

"You've given up."

"No, I'm just choosing my battles," Phainon corrects. "You can't fight it all, Mydeimos. You'll get tired and burn yourself out fast."

Mydeimos frowns—not a new look, but the way he looks at Phainon seems to say that he's upset at something unsaid. "So you're just staying here? And when summer comes around again and you can't afford anything again? What do you do?"

"Oh, are you concerned about me?"

"Answer me," Mydeimos presses. "What's your plan if this happens again? Are you going to date someone new, pray they have parents willing to pay you?"

“It’ll all work out again.”

“This summer only worked out because of *me*,” Mydeimos says, words enough to cut through Phainon’s easy smile. “You got lucky we were here.”

It slices the wrong nerve. “Ah, so I should thank my lucky stars that led me to answer your parents’ listing?”

“It’s the truth,” Mydeimos replies. “If we weren’t here, what would you do? If I didn’t come with my parents and they never made you date me? What, then?”

“*Stop*,” Phainon puts his foot down before anything else happens. Above, the clouds grow thicker, gray covering the summer-typical blue skies. Then, he sighs. “If you weren’t here… I guess we’ll never know, won’t we? You’re already here.”

“It’s work,” Mydeimos says again, his voice quieter, as if to whisper to himself. “*I* was work.”

“You weren’t *work*,” Phainon swiftly takes Mydeimos’ wrist. “Going on dates with you weren’t things on my checklist. I’m sorry that it’s how everything started, but—”

“Stop saying sorry,” Mydeimos interrupts, wrenching his hand from Phainon’s hold. “You’re not sorry.”

“I *am* sorry. I didn’t want to hurt you, but I did.”

“I had a feeling it was too good to be true.”

(*Too good to be true*. Is that how Mydeimos viewed Phainon? That knowledge cuts deeper than any other insult Mydeimos could spit out. Phainon feels the distance between them grow larger, feels the pedestal grow taller under his feet. Perfect Phainon, infallible Phainon, *everything-good-in-the-world* Phainon. He wants nothing more than to lose that title.)

Phainon knows when he’s fighting a losing battle. Yet, he tries again—“I meant it, Mydeimos. I meant it when I said I didn’t see you as just a friend.”

There—the cynical laugh long awaited. “Really?”

“You want the truth? I’ll give it to you,” Phainon says. “I wanted to keep this casual. It’d be a lot easier that way. But you… you’re *you*, and I somehow forgot how to do *casual*. You made me break every rule I set for myself with your snark and your pretty face. You made me—”

(*—feel like I’m just myself. Like I’m not perfect. Like I’m not untouchable.*)

“—feel like there’s more to *this*,” he continues, “That it’s not just all about praise and drinks and mindless conversation. And I think… no, I *know* I’ll regret it for the rest of my life if I lose you once summer’s over.”

That softens Mydeimos’ stance, makes his tense shoulders relax ever so slightly. “Flattery will get you nowhere.”

“It’s not flattery. It’s honesty.”

“And I’m supposed to believe you?”

“It’s honesty,” Phainon repeats—but he places a hand to his chest before making a fist and extending it towards Mydeimos.

(*Take it,* he wants to say. *It’s yours now.*)

Mydeimos looks down at Phainon’s hand. It’s like déjà vu, the way he stares down, unsure whether to take it or move past it. After a second passes, he tentatively lifts his hand, almost as if to take—

Rain pours down, sudden and heavy. It’s the first rain after months of merciless heat, but it feels more like *punishment* than *relief*, coming at a time like this. People around them begin to take shelter, sprinting with friends and laughing as they go.

Somehow, between the stalls and the rain and the laughter—Phainon’s hand finds Mydeimos’ and they *run*, too.

There’s no laughter between the two of them, just quiet resignation that almost feels like a knife against Phainon’s throat. He looks back to glance at

Mydeimos, and his heart gets lodged in his throat, because Mydeimos is looking at Phainon like he's keeping this memory in his head to draw later, eyes raking over the wet snow-like hair, the silver necklace, the white clothes clinging to skin thanks to the rain. It's a look so unbelievably tender that Phainon wonders if Mydeimos has ever looked at him like this before —then he realizes how stupid that thought is, because it's an obvious *yes*, judging by the way Mydeimos looks away.

He gives Mydeimos' hand a squeeze, another form of apology.

Mydeimos doesn't yank his hand back.

They temporarily seek shelter in the abandoned courtyard, and Mydeimos squeezes the rainwater from his hair. "I don't know why I like you," he grumbles, but Phainon doesn't miss the fondness in every syllable.

"So you like me."

Mydeimos' mistake registers a second too late. He doesn't amend it. Instead, he goes quiet.

It feels too real, too much, in all the right ways. And for the first time in a long time, Phainon doesn't shy away, doesn't plaster a cool smile on his face while internally planning his disappearing act. This time, he scoots closer to Mydeimos, damp shoulders brushing against one another.

"I like you, too," Phainon admits, because if there's one thing he learned this summer, it'd be that falling in love feels a little less like a blade seeking to cut through his lies and more like the truth naturally floating to the surface.

(Summer tastes like a sweet drink, sounds like drums and lyres, and feels like the *good ache* in his lungs with each laugh. Love? It tastes like promises in his lips, sounds like the rain, feels like eyes cast on him, and looks like *Mydei*.)

“I know,” Mydei says. Then, “You don’t have to tell me. You’re not very good at hiding it at all.”

“I don’t want to hide it. I want to be honest.”

“Honest, huh?”

“It’s what you want, right?” Phainon asks. “You said you preferred it that way. Less flattery, more honesty.”

Mydei gives Phainon a look that looks ready to bring up Saturday night under the street lights. But he doesn’t. What he says is, “The flowers looked like flattery to me.”

“You don’t like the flowers?”

“They wither and die.”

“Origami flowers it is, then.”

“You’re really into the idea of giving me flowers.”

“I’ll stop if you say you didn’t like it. But you didn’t say you didn’t like flowers. You just said you don’t like how they die.”

“Humph.”

And if Phainon laughs before pulling Mydei into the world’s clumsiest kiss ever… No one else has to know, right?

Livia leaves one rainy Saturday morning, taking the first bus out of Aedes Elysiae. To beat the post-vacation traffic, she says.

By some miracle, she manages to shake off her mother, declaring that it’s about time she’s independent, that she can walk to the bus stop by herself—but she doesn’t manage to shake off Phainon, Piso, and Cyrene. Not in a million years.

Cyrene’s putting on a brave smile—one that Phainon knows will melt into small sniffles and tears later—as they all wait under the bus stop, watching the rain pitter-patter against the road. Piso’s in a worse state, his hand grasping Livia’s so tightly that Phainon is tempted to peel it off if only to help Livia’s circulation.

“I’ll be home every summer and winter,” Livia exasperatedly says, sweeping her gaze across them. “Why do you all look like that?”

“You’ll be gone for half the year,” Piso replies, more earnest than he’s ever been. “And if you meet someone new—”

“Don’t even,” Livia interrupts. “You idiot, I told you I only have eyes for you.”

Phainon closes his eyes tight as he restrains a laugh that’s more from embarrassment than it is from amusement. To be polite, he clears his throat, “We’re still here, by the way.”

The bus soon pulls into the stop, doors folding and revealing cold interiors. Phainon and Piso both take Livia’s bags, helping her lug them into the vehicle. And they watch through foggy windows as Livia sits down and waves goodbye.

Only when the bus is out of sight does Piso sigh heavily and Cyrene lean against Phainon. He wraps his arms around them both, pulling them close, letting the scent of floral shampoo and cedar soap mix and surround him.

“You know what they say,” Cyrene sniffs. “Distance makes the heart grow fonder.”

Piso laughs weakly, the sound weighed down by unspoken sentiment. “I guess.”

Summer doesn’t last forever.

Phainon watches as Aedes Elysiae grows smaller, quieter. The air carries the promise of winter, the chilly winds of autumn already beginning to sing against the leaves. People leave, packing up and taking the noise with them.

Mydei leaves, too. There's no teary goodbyes this time around, of course—Phainon is above that, and Mydei claims that he never cries. Besides, goodbye doesn't mean goodbye *forever*.

(Summer comes back. It always does.)

"Text me when you're home?"

"Mhm."

"Can I call you?"

Mydei focuses his attention on his bag like it's the most interesting thing in the world when he says, "Do what you want."

Phainon is still Phainon; some secrets stubbornly refuse to reveal themselves, hiding under their comfortable cloaks. He's still the apparent most eligible bachelor. He's still known as the helpful north star.

And he goes to work as usual, customers fewer in number, nights quieter. But when a woman slides him a napkin with her number scrawled on the soft sheet—

"Oh," he says, smiling as gently as he could. "I'm not interested."

(Next to him, his colleague gives him a look. Like Phainon grew a second head.)

It's one winter morning when he notices something out of the ordinary. There's something under construction where a bar used to be, just a three-minute bike away from home. He adjusts his glasses, pushing it up his nose with a knuckle, nosily reading the building permit tarp.

Huh. A restaurant, according to the project name. Phainon chuckles. Unless the owner bleeds money, there's no way it'll remain open all year. Yet another restaurant that'll say *hi* for the summer and then go *bye-bye* right after summer.

He prepares to pedal again, but pauses when his eyes land on the name of the project owner.

He coughs, "Mydei?"

Chapter End Notes

> "Mahal kita kaso bente lang pera ko eh" (I love you, but I only have twenty pesos in my pocket) was a sentiment that I have felt so deeply before. Realizing your lover's mere spare change is your big pay is a realization that is beyond bitter. I want to think of a world where it's possible to look past that difference and be happy.

> Thank you so much for reading this far! Thank you for the comments on the previous chapters, too. I love reading what you all have to say (especially for chapter 2, I saw some reactions on Twitter), and lots of them made me laugh. I'm still a little hesitant when it comes to sharing my writing, so seeing people enjoy what I wrote made me really happy. Thank you again!
>
> Catch me go crazy over Amphoreus on Twitter…

Chapter 4: the four-letter word

Chapter Summary

> Step off the stage, take my hand.

Chapter Notes

> This chapter is unbeta'd. Sorry. It has been a long, long while since I wrote for fun. Between chapter 3 and this epilogue, I've been stuck in production jail, writing for shows (that I am not even interested in but am somehow working on). I was stuck writing in a certain tone for a lighthearted and educational genre, and I think that has scrubbed the soul out of my writing style. If there was a visible and jarring style change, please blame the production house I am working with (half-joking)...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first anniversary really sticks, Audata once said, giggling against her palm giddily as Phainon looked at her with an expression that only an exasperated teenager can make.

He's heard their stories a thousand times before—hell, maybe even *more*. He's heard of how they met (Hieronymus was fifteen, trying to make some extra money fixing fans during the summer, and quickly found out that the girl who hired him was a pretty girl his age who had just moved in), how their first date went (Audata hitched a ride at the back of her crush's bike and felt so free as her hair was tousled by the wind and kept laughing at her mother's furious yelling). But, most importantly, how their first anniversary as a couple was.

His mother sighed about how dreamy her darling Heironymus was, how she felt his love with every display. His father huffed proudly at how he managed to pull such a sweet smile from his beloved Audata, how she shyly laughed when he whispered how much he loved her. They tell the

story so vividly that Phainon could close his eyes and picture himself there, out of place in a world he's not supposed to exist in.

("Oh, Phainon," Audata said as she ran her fingers through Phainon's hair. "You were always there with me. With us. Maybe not physically, but you were *there*."

Phainon grimaced at the sight of his father nodding in agreement. "Please, don't tell me any more.")

Their anniversary was so memorable that, even after over twenty years had passed, his parents remember every detail as if it were just yesterday. They tell the tale over and over again like broken records. And while the teenaged Phainon could not be any less appreciative, the Phainon of today holds the memory close to his chest, keeping it there, safe and sound.

Today, their words echo in his mind. *The first anniversary really sticks,* he repeats in his head, his voice in unison with his mother's. Naturally, he has to try his best to impress Mydei enough that, someday, they could tell the story to… well, honestly, Phainon isn't sure. Their kids, maybe?

Warmth blooms in his chest at the thought. But before it can turn into something burning hot that travels south, the pressure of preparing the perfect first anniversary strikes his head like a mallet.

Mydei is… a little hard to impress, Phainon thinks. He knows how to keep Mydei happy, sure, but what's the point of an anniversary when your happiness levels are just the same as they are on a regular day? What makes an anniversary special, anyway? He's never dated anyone long enough to get to anniversaries, and he doesn't think he would've had it in him to prepare flowers and dinner if he were ever to reach that point back then.

(The Phainon of the past always had one foot out the door, after all. He was sweet enough to want, but not enough to keep.)

The thing is, Phainon gives Mydei flowers—origami ones, anyway—daily when he's visiting. With an additional fun fact about the flower of the day, for good measure. Was he to make a larger bouquet of them and spout more

fun facts? And what about dinner? Mydei does the cooking most days he's in Aedes Elysiae, and he's a damn good cook. As expected of the executive chef, of course. And, another thing: how is the head chef supposed to impress the executive chef? Mydei's his boss, for Kephale's sake; he's already tasted everything Phainon has to offer.

He bows his head, his forehead bumping against the table. His list of ideas for their anniversary only gets pathetically thinner every time he combs through it and actually thinks about it rationally. Why in the world did he ever think it was a good idea to bring Mydei to an amusement park? Mydei isn't fond of crowds. And an escape room, really? Because solving riddles *definitely* is a fun way for Mydei to spend an anniversary, right?

Phainon lifts his head and then drops it down again, hitting his forehead a little harder. It doesn't make him feel any better, nor does it give him any brilliant ideas. If anything, he's only feeling more hopeless. Their anniversary is in a week, and Mydei is coming to Aedes Elysiae in three days—if he doesn't finish his plans *now*, he risks spoiling the surprise if Mydei catches him brainstorming in the future.

He'll sleep on it. And when he wakes up, he'll be invigorated and overflowing with ideas. That's usually how it goes.

Phainon is decidedly *fucked*.

Mydei barrels in his home like a tornado—not literally, but he might as well have—arriving at eight in the morning and two days earlier than expected.

"Mydei!" Phainon greets as he shoves his notes filled with brilliant ideas under the couch with a stealthy foot. "You're early."

Mydei sets down his bags. He smells like heaven, and Phainon stops himself from rushing in for an embrace and a kiss. It's not for lack of desire, make no mistake—it's just that Phainon's last shower was yesterday afternoon, and he absolutely sweated through the night. He's not about to subject Mydei to *that*.

“Are you sending me out?” Mydei asks with a raise of his eyebrow.

He manages a laugh. He swipes his foot behind him again, just to make sure. The feeling of being a failure makes his chest twist. “I would *never*.”

“Uh-huh. You’re sending me out. Don’t worry, I can take a hint.”

(Phainon loves his dry humor, the flat way he delivers every joke. Phainon even loves how Mydei didn’t bother texting him a heads-up for his arrival, how he just pulls up to the front of his house, honking. Phainon loves Mydei, and he wants this to last so, *so* badly—but he can’t plan the first anniversary that Mydei deserves after everything he’s done for Phainon.)

“No,” Phainon replies, the word a drawl in a way he hopes is playful. He swallows hard. “I love you, stay.”

Mydei looks at him for a moment, his expression unreadable. But when he steps closer, uncaring for the light sheen of sweat on Phainon, Phainon’s arms automatically open to accommodate Mydei, and everything melts away, for a while.

“Matthiola Incana,” Phainon says, handing Mydei the flower of the day. “They’re native to Amphoreus, and they’re coastflowers.”

Mydei takes it. He notes, “I’ve seen this in Styxia before. They smell good.”

“We should go there someday.”

“Someday,” Mydei nods.

“What’s a good anniversary gift?”

Cyrene looks up from her phone and gives him a look, “So you haven’t finalized your anniversary gift for Mydei?”

Busted. Not like Phainon has any dignity left, anyway. Cyrene has seen him through it all. Still, he feels the need to defend himself, “I mean, I have ideas, but I need to refine them.”

“Okay,” Cyrene chirps in a way that makes her sound like she’s unconvinced. She probably is. “Run your ideas by me, then.”

“Flowers and a nice dinner cooked by yours truly. An out-of-town three-day vacation. And…”

“And…?”

Phainon looks at Cyrene with lips pressed into a thin line. A silent sign of surrender. Maybe it’s the stress weighing down his shoulders, maybe it’s the pressure she can clearly read—but Cyrene simply sighs at his answer before looking down at her phone again.

She’s typing when she says, “Don’t overthink it. Mydei would be happy with anything you have to give.”

Easy for you to say, when everyone loves what you do, is a reply Phainon leaves unsaid.

Every hour ticks by awfully slow and terribly quick at the same time; Mydei is in his kitchen, chopping up onions with such quickness that his hand almost blurs in Phainon’s vision. He refuses Phainon’s help, saying something about Phainon being more of a nuisance than anything else. Phainon, as the law of arguing with one’s boyfriend demands, insists that he can handle the kitchen.

“I’ve been ruling this kitchen for years, you know?” he says, watching Mydei work with nearly mechanical precision. “I know what I’m doing.”

“I know you do. We wouldn’t have hired you if you didn’t,” Mydei replies, not even looking at him.

Why is it that, nowadays, nobody looks at him when talking to him? Phainon casts out that thought in favor of replying, “Exactly. So let me do something instead of just leeching off of you.”

Mydei stops chopping the onions. He finally looks at Phainon, “You’re already cooking on the daily, and you’re on PTO. I won’t put you to work.”

“Still, it’s your first day back—”

“No,” Mydei firmly replies. Phainon pointedly ignores the frustration building in him, mustering a smile instead.

Phainon takes his plans outside. The cover of the notebook has been crumpled from his hasty attempts at hiding it, and the pages are filled with ideas scratched out. The summer heat burns through his shirt, unbearably hot. It makes his mind move slower, like it’s caught in a haze.

He’s torn between flowers with dinner and a three-day vacation. It’s nice to stay in—Mydei has shown his clear appreciation for staying in. However, a three-day vacation would be a good art exercise for Mydei.

“If only I could bring Mydei somewhere impressive,” he muses aloud, tapping his pen against the table. If only money weren’t a problem; Phainon would fly Mydei out to a nice, scenic location and sit by his side as he draws. Instead, all he has to offer is a vacation a few towns over and—

He pauses abruptly at the harsh reminder of his lack of a car. What good would it be to have Mydei drive them to the plans Phainon made? How could he be so stupid and forget the logistics of how they’d get there to begin with?

Phainon sighs deeply as he scratches out yet another idea.

“I love you,” Phainon breaks the silence in the night, tucking a stray lock of hair behind Mydei’s ear.

“I feel like you’ve been upset at me.”

Phainon blinks. “Huh?”

Mydei shifts in bed, getting a little closer to Phainon. In summer, the proximity is agonizing in two ways; the weather makes their bodies sticky, and Mydei has always been an irresistible presence when pressed against him. Phainon’s heart wants to pull him closer, and Phainon’s brain demands to pull away.

“You spent most of the day out,” Mydei says. “Are you avoiding me?”

(Phainon couldn’t avoid Mydei, even if he tried. As much as his brain asked him to pull back and keep his body cool, his heart wins the battle.)

“No,” Phainon says sincerely. He’s upset, yes—at himself, not at Mydei. *Never* at Mydei, he thinks. So he repeats, “I love you.”

The way Mydei looks at him is a challenge, asking him quietly, *do you?* So Phainon places a hand on his chest, then makes a fist and offers it to Mydei.

Finally, Mydei curls against Phainon, “You’ll have to think of another way to prove it.”

Phainon gets the hint. Still, he feels the need to be the voice of reason, asking, “Don’t you have an alarm set early tomorrow?”

Taunts come easily. Mydei says, “And this is a concern, why…? Will it take you seven hours to get me off?”

Now, *that* is something Phainon won’t let slide. He laughs wryly, snaking an arm around Mydei’s middle, pressing their bodies closer. “*Okay*. Just don’t blame me for how you feel tomorrow.”

“Casa Blanca Lily,” Phainon says as he hands Mydei the flower of the day. “These flowers are native to Xianzhou. *Very* expensive.”

Mydei appears amused, “Bought some before?”

He gasps in mock horror. “Hey, don’t tell me you forgot the flowers I gave you before! Casa Blanca Lilies were in your apology bouquet last year!”

“So they *were* apology flowers.”

Mydei admits he’s never tried fried bananas before, so Phainon chooses Mydei’s cheat day to beat him to the kitchen and prepare their snacks.

“My mom used to make these for me when I was a kid,” he says, dropping the sliced bananas in the frying pan. “They’re delicious.”

“And a health risk,” Mydei points out, gesturing to the sugar-coated bananas yet to be fried.

“*And* sweet,” Phainon nods, and he feels a slight tug of irritation at nothing in particular. What is with him? Is it the weather? Was the heat making his temper flare up? “But it’s good.”

Mydei’s lips curl into a small smile, “I find it hard to trust your taste. You like to mix and match all sorts of strange things.”

Phainon’s eye twitches. That feeling of irritation grows in his chest. He just wants to be a good boyfriend, but he feels like he’s being denied a chance at every turn. “Are you doubting my mom’s choice of snacks?”

Maybe it’s because Mydei heard the edge in his tone, maybe because Mydei saw how his grip tightened on the frying pan’s handle—but he backs off, and his smile fades. He says, “Don’t be ridiculous. Of course not.”

Phainon breathes out slowly. “Okay.”

The rest of the afternoon is quiet. Phainon regrets speaking at all.

When Phainon crawls to bed, Mydei says nothing to him. Not a greeting, not even a provocation that used to come easily. Phainon finds himself

missing Mydei poking and prodding in his own little way that, when faced with silence, he finds himself unsure of what to do with himself.

He opts to wrap his arms around Mydei. “I love you,” he whispers.

Mydei says nothing in response. He hardly replies to it verbally, anyway. At least, that’s what Phainon tells himself to push down the unease.

Phainon slides little origami flowers towards Mydei. “Daphnes. They mean immortality and victory. Flowers for heroes.”

“I don’t think I’ve done anything particularly heroic recently.”

“You’re doing charity work as my boyfriend.”

Mydei gives him a dry look. “Ha-ha.”

Guilt begins to form in his chest. Phainon doesn’t know what to do with it.

He looks up from the plates he’s washing to watch the window. Mydei and Cyrene are lounging in the yard. He heard they made plans to work together on one of Cyrene’s ideas, and Phainon thinks that’s what they’re talking about; Cyrene does the writing, and Mydei illustrates her ideas. Outside the window, bathed in the afternoon sunlight, Cyrene says something funny behind her iced lemonade, and Mydei offers her a little huff and a smile.

They look happy, Phainon realizes. And while *he’s* happy that two of the most important people in his life are getting along, there’s a sense of bitterness that takes over. But he isn’t stupid—he knows Mydei sees Cyrene as a friend, and Cyrene is very much uninterested in men. So it isn’t jealousy, he tells himself. Not that.

But when he’s so used to being Cyrene’s bestest friend, when he feels like Mydei has given him more blank looks than a smile these days, Phainon feels his heart clench in his chest.

Phainon looks down at the plate he’s holding under the faucet. All that water, and he hasn’t even scrubbed off the grime yet.

“How’s the project with Cyrene going?” Phainon asks Mydei over dinner.

Mydei shrugs, nonchalant. “I’m still waiting for her to give me the complete story. She says she’s going to try to go hands-off on what I draw and let me be my own boss.”

Phainon shoves a piece of cauliflower in his mouth. After he swallows, he replies, “As if you haven’t had enough of being your own boss, huh?”

Mydei pauses. Then, his expression twists into a frown, “You’ve been snarky these days.”

Guilt twists and turns in Phainon’s chest, taking up more space than it deserves. He replies with a shrug mirroring Mydei’s, “I’m learning from you.”

“Forget Me Not,” Phainon names the blue paper flowers. “Guess what they mean.”

“It’s a gift for when you want the person to forget you.”

Phainon laughs at Mydei’s sarcastic tone, “Yes, correct. Brilliant.”

Every hour ticks by awfully slow and terribly quick at the same time; Mydei is in his kitchen, chopping up onions with such quickness that his hand almost blurs in Phainon’s vision. He refuses Phainon’s help, saying something about Phainon being more of a nuisance than anything else. Phainon insists that he can handle the kitchen. Mydei gives a firm ‘no.’

Later, after lunch, Mydei and Cyrene are lounging in the yard. He heard they made plans to work together on one of Cyrene’s ideas, and Phainon thinks that’s what they’re talking about; Cyrene does the writing, and

Mydei illustrates her ideas. Outside the window, bathed in the afternoon sunlight, Cyrene gives Mydei a playful nudge, and Mydei nudges her back. Phainon looks down at the greasy bowl still in his hand and scrubs a little harder.

“I love you,” Phainon whispers when he slips into bed. Mydei turns his head to glance at Phainon. He tells Phainon to go to sleep already.

“Marigold,” Phainon says as he gives Mydei yellow paper flowers. “Back then, priestesses of Mnestia used them to make love charms.”

Mydei takes it wordlessly.

The dreaded day arrives.

Phainon *hates* to think that he dreads their first anniversary. But he does. His hands feel clammy, his heart is ready to beat out of his chest, and the summer sun seems determined to cook everyone alive. Weather forecast claims that it’s only 33°—one of the cooler days and not even close to the most brutal of temperatures that Aedes Elysiae has to offer—yet it has never felt hotter.

Mydei is busy preparing lunch when Phainon sneaks into his parents’ bedroom to retrieve the flowers he’s been folding up for the past few days. His parents’ bedroom was sacred to them both, especially to Mydei, who made a point of not touching it when they cleaned together, so Phainon was able to hide away one half of his pathetic, pitiful gift.

(And, in his mind, the plan goes like this: Phainon gives Mydei the flowers. They enjoy Mydei’s lunch together. And then, Phainon will tell Mydei that he’ll take care of dinner, and Mydei will say *yes*. Phainon will then prepare a movie for them to watch before bed. Or before whatever they might do before bed.)

Only that, when Phainon walks out of the room with the bouquet hidden behind his back and into the kitchen, Mydei is already waiting for him. Oh.

Phainon cringes at his lack of discretion. Still—

“Happy anniversary,” Phainon says just as Mydei deadpans, “You’re breaking up with me.”

Phainon’s jaw drops as he pulls out the flowers from behind him. Mydei’s expression turns into pure shock for a moment, but swiftly recovers with a mild look of disbelief. He eyes the flowers, wary, like they could grow teeth and start biting anytime soon.

He asks with a disbelief that matches Mydei’s, “Why would you think I’m breaking up with you?”

Mydei looks offended at the question—he gives Phainon his signature frown, and his lips press into a firm line. He says, “Don’t say that like I’m an idiot. You’ve been acting weird these past few days.”

A flinch is promptly restrained. Apologies begin to form in Phainon’s throat, but what comes out is, “I’ve been really stressed recently, Mydei.”

“So you avoid me.”

Phainon lightly shakes the flowers still in his grip, “I wasn’t avoiding you. But I can’t exactly just fold these in your presence now, can I? You’d be asking me why I was suddenly mass-making them when you only get one per day.”

“I’d think you were preparing for the next few days.”

“No, because you’re not stupid,” Phainon huffs. “You’d be able to read me. Easily!”

Mydei crosses his arms, “I *wish* I could read you easily. Then I wouldn’t have to guess what’s wrong all the time. I try to say the right thing, and you give me sarcasm. Thanks for that.”

“Are you calling me immature?”

“When did I say that?”

“It sounded like it,” Phainon says, and there’s a sharpness creeping in his tone. He doesn’t like it.

Mydei glares at him, “You really do have a talent for putting words in my mouth.”

“You’re the one assuming I’m breaking up with you! On our anniversary!”

Mydei glances away, directing his gaze to the walls. “Because you’d probably prefer to break up with someone face-to-face than through the phone.”

Phainon has plenty of protests. One, he has broken up with someone—multiple people, actually—over the phone before (Mydei doesn’t need to know that right now, though). Two, he can’t even imagine breaking up with Mydei; it’d be like trying to pull the sun from the sky. Phainon is happy to belong with Mydei. Elated, even.

Silence lingers between them, a little painfully awkward. Just like how it was a year ago, Phainon wistfully thinks. So he amends, “I’m not breaking up with you. I don’t want to, and it didn’t even cross my mind.”

Mydei’s eyes meet his. “So what’s the issue, then? Why won’t you just tell me?”

A million worries rush to Phainon’s mind, some of them not even relating to Mydei. And what comes out is—

“I’m not proud of how we began,” Phainon says, gesturing with a hand vaguely. The way Mydei’s eyebrow raises just makes him feel crazy. “I mean, imagine having to explain to people, oh, yeah, I met my husband because his parents paid me to date him, then I fell in love for real. And on top of that, our first anniversary is pathetic and simple and forgettable because I can’t take you somewhere impressive. It’s embarrassing.”

“Husband,” Mydei repeats, his voice just slightly choked, like it’s the only thing he gathered from the conversation. The heat in the room vanishes because it all rushes to Phainon’s cheeks instead.

A second passes before Phainon hastily corrects, “*Boyfriend*. Boyfriend, sorry.”

Mydei dwells on it a little more. “You said ‘husband.’”

“Slip of tongue,” Phainon says, turning red in the face. Because of the heat, obviously. What else would it be? “I meant to say ‘boyfriend.’”

Great. Now he’s about to scare off his boyfriend on their *first* anniversary by rushing into marriage. When his mother said that the first anniversary sticks, he liked to think it was because it was perfect, not because it was *horrifying*.

The silence is beyond painful. Phainon wants to dig a hole in his kitchen floor and curl up there until the end of time. (Here lies Khaslana, it’d say. And when people ask who the hell is Khaslana, he’d just laugh from beyond the grave, because nicknames really do stick.) Maybe Mydei would even help him dig.

“I was so caught up in my assumptions. I’m sorry,” Mydei says, the apology in his mouth sounding unpracticed. It shouldn’t sound endearing to Phainon, but it does. “You don’t need to take me anywhere fancy. Just… being here with you is perfect.”

“No,” Phainon shakes his head as he steps closer to Mydei, wrapping one arm around him. “*I* should be sorry, I’ve been so short with you recently. And Cyrene too, I think.”

“*And* Cyrene?” Mydei echoes, his tone sounding a little lighter. “Unforgivable.”

“I know. I’m sorry,” Phainon repeats against Mydei’s shoulder. “I’m stupid.”

“You are,” Mydei affirms. Then, he adds, “I love you.”

Phainon pulls Mydei into a kiss. And then he tries his luck, “Let me take care of dinner tonight, please?”

“Begging for work… You’re something else.”

“Thanks.”

“I didn’t mean it as a compliment.”

“I know. But you love me.”

Mydei doesn’t reply with words, no—instead, he gives Phainon another kiss.

“Your father brought me to the courtyard,” Audata sighed, all dreamy and nostalgic. “And he gave me my favorite flowers.”

Phainon scratched his head. “But the courtyard is something you go to every weekend. And you said Dad gives you flowers every week. If you do the same thing you do on the regular, what makes it so special?”

Audata reached for Phainon’s nose and gave it a pinch. She chirped, “You’ll get it one day.”

Chapter End Notes

> Phainon still has to learn not to bottle every frustration up. Mydei still has a lot to learn about a world he wasn’t born in. But they’re learning together and they’re going to be okay.
>
> Thank you for reading this far (for real now) and thanks for waiting! I loved reading everyone’s comments, and they honestly motivated me so much to finish this fic at last.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!